

Heaven Is Not Your Reward

The Resurrection Hope the Church Traded for an Escape

JAMES BELL

Heaven Is Not Your Reward

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Published by LiveWell by James Bell. livewellbyjamesbell.co

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Behold, I am making all things new.

THE VOICE FROM THE THRONE, REVELATION 21

Contents

Introduction	1
The Funeral That Told the Truth	
Chapter One	7
The Shell in the Box	
Chapter Two	13
Where the Clouds Came From	
Chapter Three	19
What the New Testament Actually Promises	
Chapter Four	24
The Hinge of History	
Chapter Five	30
The Redemption of the Body	
Chapter Six	36
A New Heaven and a New Earth	
Chapter Seven	41
With Christ, But Not Yet the End	
Chapter Eight	47
The Disposable Earth	
Chapter Nine	53
Why Escapism Makes Justice Optional	

Chapter Ten	59
Grief in the Light of Resurrection	
Chapter Eleven	65
What We Will Actually Do	
Chapter Twelve	71
Hell and Judgment, Honestly	
Chapter Thirteen	78
How Resurrection People Live Now	
Chapter Fourteen	84
Facing Your Own Death	
Chapter Fifteen	90
The Already and the Not Yet	
Chapter Sixteen	96
In Defense of Your Grandmother's Hymns	
Chapter Seventeen	102
The Day the Sea Gives Up Its Dead	
Chapter Eighteen	107
The Ascension and the Absent King	
Chapter Nineteen	112
The Mission of a Resurrection People	
Chapter Twenty	117
The Millennium and the Maps	
Chapter Twenty-One	123
Marriage, Children, and the Hope That Outlasts Them	
Chapter Twenty-Two	129
The Suffering That Comes Before the Morning	
Chapter Twenty-Three	135
The Table, the Water, and the Rehearsal	

Chapter Twenty-Four	140
Why the Cathedral Was Not a Waste	
Chapter Twenty-Five	145
How an Atheist Came to Bet His Life on a Corpse	
Chapter Twenty-Six	150
The Ache the Modern World Cannot Name	
Chapter Twenty-Seven	156
The Endless Wanting and the End of It	
Chapter Twenty-Eight	162
What Death Cannot Keep	
Chapter Twenty-Nine	167
The Resurrection on a Tuesday Afternoon	
Chapter Thirty	173
What the Early Church Knew	
Chapter Thirty-One	179
The Skeptic's Hardest Question	
Chapter Thirty-Two	184
When You Cannot Feel the Hope	
Chapter Thirty-Three	189
What Heaven Actually Is	
Chapter Thirty-Four	194
If Not Escape, Then Why Evangelize	
Conclusion	199
The Morning You Have Not Yet Seen	

INTRODUCTION

The Funeral That Told the Truth

I HAVE STOOD AT the front of a lot of funerals. Fifteen years of it now. I have watched the same casket wheeled up the same aisle under the same fluorescent light, and I have said, more times than I can count, the words a pastor is supposed to say. But there is one funeral I keep returning to, because it was the day I heard the church tell the truth about what it actually believes, and the truth was smaller than the Bible.

The man in the box was named Walter. He had farmed the same ground outside Fenton for fifty-one years. He had calloused hands and a slow way of talking and a habit of showing up at the church before anyone else on a Sunday to run the vacuum, because he did not think a man should sit while a thing needed doing. When Walter died, his daughter asked me to say something at the graveside, and then his brother stood up first, uninvited, and said the thing I have heard a thousand times.

He said, Walter is not here. This is just the shell. He is up in heaven now, looking down on us, and one day we will all be

together with him there, far from all this.

Everyone nodded. It was a comfort. I do not blame the man for saying it, and I do not doubt he loved his brother. But I stood at the edge of that grave, next to that farmer's body, on the ground that farmer had loved, and I felt the whole weight of a lie the church has been telling itself so long it does not know it is a lie anymore. Not a wicked lie. A comfortable one. The most comfortable lie there is.

The lie is that the point of the whole thing is to leave. To get the soul out of the body, out of the dirt, out of the farm and the calloused hands and the slow talking, and up into a location called heaven where none of it follows you. The lie is that the body in the box is a shell, and the earth we buried it in is a waiting room, and the entire story of God is an evacuation plan.

I believed that once. I want to be careful here, because I came to all of this late and hard. I was an atheist until I was a grown man. I did not grow up in the church absorbing its comforts. I came to Christ as an adult who had spent years deciding the whole thing was a fairy tale for people who could not face the dark. And when I finally could not resist it any longer, when the resurrection of Jesus of Nazareth broke over me as something that had actually happened in actual history, I walked into the church expecting to find people who believed that. People whose whole life was built on the fact that a dead man got up.

What I found instead, mostly, was people waiting to die so they could go somewhere else. Sincere people. Kind people. People who would give you the coat off their back. But their hope, when you pressed on it, was not resurrection. It was escape. It was the shell in the box and the soul in the clouds.

And I remember thinking, even then, even now, that this was not the thing that had knocked me down. The thing that had knocked me down was a tomb that was empty on a specific Sunday morning outside a specific city. Not a rumor of heaven. A body that was gone.

I want to tell you in this book that the church made a trade. Somewhere along the way, and I will show you where, we swapped the Bible's actual hope for a thinner one. We traded the new heaven and the new earth for a disembodied heaven only. We traded resurrection for immortality of the soul. We traded God's promise to make all things new for a promise to take us away from the things that break. And because it was a comfort, and because it was easy, and because it let us stop caring about a great many things it is hard to care about, we did not notice the price.

But there is a price. When your hope is escape, the body becomes disposable, because the body is what you are escaping. When your hope is escape, the earth becomes disposable, because the earth is the thing you are leaving behind. When your hope is escape, justice becomes optional, because why would you scrub the deck of a ship that is going down. When your hope is escape, grief has no floor under it, because you are pretending the body in the box was never really the person at all. I have watched all four of these prices get paid, in real people, in my own congregation, in my own heart. This is not a book I am writing at anyone. I am inside every indictment in it.

Let me say the thing plainly, because the rest of the book is the argument for it. The New Testament does not promise you a disembodied heaven as your final home. It promises resurrection. It promises that God is not going to abandon the

material world He called good in the first chapter of the Bible, but redeem it. It promises a new heaven and a new earth, which is to say a renewed creation, and a city that comes down out of heaven to the earth rather than a people who float up out of the earth to heaven. It promises, as the scholar N.T. Wright put it in his 2007 book *Surprised by Hope*, life after life after death. There is a life immediately after you die, with Christ, and it is real and it is good. But it is not the end of the story. It is the waiting room. The end of the story is your body, raised, on a healed earth, under the reign of the God who made it.

That is a bigger hope than escape. It is also a harder one, because it will not let you off the hook about anything. If God is going to redeem this world and not junk it, then this world matters now. If God is going to raise your body and not discard it, then your body matters now. If the poor and the grieving and the wronged are not being written off as passengers on a doomed ship, then justice is not a distraction from the gospel but a rehearsal for the world that is coming. Escape lets you relax. Resurrection puts you to work.

I want to steelman the escape before I take it apart, because the people who hold it are not fools and are not, most of them, being lazy. The going-to-heaven language does something real. It says the dead are safe. It says God has not lost them. It says there is a place of comfort beyond the reach of cancer and car accidents and the long humiliation of old age. All of that is true, and I will defend it in these pages, and I will not let the recovery of resurrection cost us the genuine comfort inside the older way of speaking. When Walter's brother said his brother was with the Lord, he said something the Bible affirms. The problem was not what he affirmed. The problem was what he assumed it meant, and what he

assumed it ruled out, and how small he had let the story become without ever choosing to.

So here is what this book is going to do. I am going to take you back to that funeral, and then further back, to the third and fourth centuries, to show you where the clouds-and-harps picture came from and why it is not actually the Bible's picture. I am going to walk you through what the New Testament actually promises, and I am going to plant the whole thing on the one fact everything else hangs on, which is that the tomb of Jesus was empty and His body was raised. Then I am going to follow the consequences out, all the way out, into your body and the dirt under your feet and the injustice in your city and the grave you have already visited and the one you have not yet had to.

I am not writing this to win an argument about eschatology. I could not care less about winning that argument. I am writing it because I have buried too many people under a hope that was too small, and I have watched too many people live small lives because they thought the real thing started somewhere else, and I have felt the pull of the same escape in my own chest at the funerals of people I loved. I have five sons. I was raised without a father, and I have spent my whole life since deciding what kind of world I was going to hand them. I refuse to hand them an escape hatch. I want to hand them a hope big enough to make them love the world God made and grieve it honestly and work in it like it matters, because it does.

Heaven is not your reward. I know that sentence sounds like a demolition, and to a certain picture it is. But hold it a moment before you flinch. What if the reason heaven is not your reward is that heaven, the disembodied waiting room,

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

was never the point. What if the point was always bigger. What if the point was a raised body on a remade earth, God dwelling with His people, every tear wiped away by a hand you can feel, and Walter, calloused hands and all, standing on ground that does not die.

That is the hope I am asking you to want. Let me show you it was there the whole time.

CHAPTER ONE

The Shell in the Box

I WANT TO STAY at the graveside a little longer, because the sentence Walter's brother said deserves to be taken seriously and not just used. This is just the shell. He is not here. I have heard some version of it at nearly every funeral I have ever conducted, and I have said versions of it myself, and I need you to understand that I am not sneering at it. I am grieving what it costs.

Start with what is true in it. When we say the dead person is not here, we are reaching for something real. The thing that made Walter Walter, the personality, the memory, the love, the will, is not lying in that box in any way we can reach. Whatever a human being is, it is not simply a quantity of meat, and when the meat stops, something has gone that the meat did not contain. The materialist, the version of me that argued against all of this for years, has a genuine problem here and knows it. You can weigh the body before and after death and the number does not change and yet everything has changed. Something is absent. The brother at the graveside is not wrong to feel it. He is naming a real absence with the only words his church ever gave him.

But watch what the words do next. This is just the shell. The word just is doing an enormous amount of work, and all of it is destructive. It says the body was a container, and the container is empty now, and the container was never the point. It says that what we are burying is packaging. And once you have said that, once you have called the body a shell, you have quietly agreed to a picture of the human person that the Bible does not teach and that Christianity spent its first centuries fighting.

The picture is this. A human being is a soul, and the soul is the real you, and the body is a temporary suit the soul wears. On this picture, death is not an enemy. Death is a graduation. Death is the moment the soul finally gets free of the suit. And salvation, on this picture, is essentially death perfected, the permanent liberation of the soul from the body, the shell discarded for good so the real you can float off unencumbered.

I want to say this as clearly as I can. That is not the Christian hope. That is a hope, and it is an old and respectable one, but it is the hope of Plato, not the hope of the empty tomb. It came into the church from outside and made itself so much at home that most Christians now assume it is the gospel. It is not. The Christian hope is not that the shell gets discarded. The Christian hope is that the shell gets raised.

Consider what the New Testament actually does with a dead body. When Jesus stands outside the tomb of Lazarus in John 11, He does not comfort Martha by telling her that Lazarus is a soul now, free at last, better off. He weeps. He is, the text says, deeply moved, and the word underneath the English is closer to angry, a snorting, indignant fury. Jesus

stands in front of death and He is enraged. Why would He be enraged at a graduation. Why would the Son of God stand at a doorway of pure liberation and shake with anger. He is angry because death is not a graduation. Death is an enemy. Death is a violation of the world His Father made. And then He does the thing that gives the game away entirely. He does not release Lazarus into a better disembodied existence. He calls the body back out of the tomb. Lazarus, come out. The dead man walks out in his grave clothes, and the crowd that had come to comfort a soul gets a body instead.

That scene is a preview. It is not the main event, because Lazarus will die again, and the raising of Lazarus is a sign pointing forward to a raising that will not have to be repeated. But the direction of the sign is unmistakable. When God addresses death in the pages of the New Testament, He does not tidy up around it by relocating souls. He reverses it. He brings the body back.

Now hold that next to the funeral. This is just the shell. Do you feel the collision. At the tomb of Lazarus, God treats the body as the thing to be recovered. At the graveside of Walter, the church treats the body as the thing to be discarded. Somewhere between the Gospel of John and the funeral home, we changed sides. We started agreeing with death that the body does not matter. We started calling the enemy's verdict a comfort.

I felt this collision in my own body before I could name it. My grandmother died when I was still an unbeliever, still convinced the whole apparatus of faith was wishful thinking, and I remember standing at her open casket and being furious in a way I could not explain and did not want. Everyone around me was calm, murmuring the shell and the

better place. And the atheist in me, the one who supposedly did not believe in any of it, wanted to grab someone by the collar and say, that is her. That is her hand. That is the hand that made the pie and held mine when I crossed the street. Do not tell me it is a shell. The hardest materialist and the most orthodox Christian ought to be able to stand together in that fury, because both of them, if they are honest, know that the body is not packaging. It is the person. It was always the person.

The word the Bible uses for the human being is not soul, floating free. In the second chapter of Genesis, God forms the man from the dust of the ground and breathes into him, and the man becomes a living creature, a living soul, and the Hebrew there does not mean God installed a soul into a body. It means the dust plus the breath together became a living being. You are not a soul that has a body. You are, in the biblical picture, an embodied soul, a besouled body, a unity so complete that to tear it apart is precisely the horror that death is. That is why Jesus is angry at the tomb. Death is not the soul being freed. Death is the human being being ripped in half. And the whole promise of the gospel is not that the tearing is fine because only the disposable half was lost. The promise is that God is going to put the halves back together, and more, He is going to do it in a body that can never be torn again.

I know the objection, because I have made it. Someone will say, Pastor, this is a distinction without a difference. Whether we float off as souls or get raised as bodies, either way we are with God and either way we are comforted, so why press so hard on it. Let people have their shell.

Here is why I press. Because the picture you hold of the

end quietly governs how you live in the middle. A man who believes the body is a disposable shell will treat his body as disposable. He will treat other people's bodies as disposable. He will find it very easy to believe that what happens to bodies, to hungry bodies, to imprisoned bodies, to the bodies of the poor and the trafficked and the bombed, is a secondary matter, a temporary matter, packaging trouble, because in the end the bodies do not count. And a man who believes God is going to raise the body will find that he cannot look away from bodies at all. The doctrine is not academic. The doctrine walks into the food pantry and the hospital room and the voting booth. What you think happens to Walter's body is going to show up in how you treat the living.

So no, I will not let people have the shell. Not because I want to take a comfort away, but because I want to give a bigger one. I want to tell the brother at the graveside something better than his church told him. I want to say, you are right that Walter is not fully here, and you are right that he is safe with the Lord, and you are more right than you know, because this ground you are standing on is not his final defeat. This body you are burying is a seed, and the God who made it is not in the habit of losing what He has made. What goes into the ground is not garbage. It is planting. And planting is the most hopeful thing a farmer ever does.

Walter would have understood that. He put things in the ground his whole life on the faith that they would come up changed and greater. He would not have called a buried seed a shell. He would have called it the beginning.

That is where I want to take you. But first I have to show you how the shell got into the box in the first place. Because it was not always there. There was a time when the church

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

stood at its gravesides and did not call the body a shell, but a seed. Something happened between then and now. Someone smuggled a different hope in through the back door, and the church, tired and frightened and wanting comfort, let it stay. Let me show you who, and when, and why it worked.

CHAPTER TWO

Where the Clouds Came From

I NEED TO TAKE you to Athens, and then to Alexandria, and then to a bishop's study in North Africa, because the picture of heaven you carry around in your head was not, for the most part, born in Jerusalem. It was born in Greece, and it entered the church through the front door, welcomed as a friend, and it has been sitting in the best chair ever since.

Start with Plato, four centuries before Christ. Plato taught that the material world is a shadow of the real world, a flickering copy of eternal Forms that exist in a realm of pure mind. The body, on this account, is the prison of the soul. The famous image in the *Phaedo*, written around 380 before Christ, has Socrates on the day of his execution positively cheerful, because death is the day the philosopher has been training for his whole life, the day the soul finally sheds the body and returns to the pure realm where it belongs. Death is liberation. The body is a tomb. There is even a Greek pun for it, *soma sema*, the body is a grave. For Plato the goal of the wise life is to practice dying, to loosen the soul's attachment

to the flesh so that when the moment comes the soul slips free and goes home.

Now I want you to notice how close that is to Walter's brother at the graveside, and how far it is from Jesus at the tomb of Lazarus. Socrates is cheerful at death because the body is a prison. Jesus is enraged at death because the body is a person. Those are not two versions of the same hope. They are opposite hopes wearing similar clothes. And the tragedy of Christian history is that we let the cheerful Greek walk in and take the seat that belonged to the weeping Jew.

It did not happen all at once, and it did not happen because anyone was wicked. It happened because the gospel spread out of its Jewish homeland and into a Greek-speaking world where everyone already had Plato in the water. When you tell a Jewish audience the dead will be raised, you are saying something they have longed for, something in Daniel and in Ezekiel's valley of dry bones, something native to their hope. When you tell a Greek audience the dead will be raised, you are telling them the worst possible news, that the soul which had finally escaped its prison is going to be sentenced back into a body. Remember the response in Athens in Acts 17, when Paul preaches the resurrection on the Areopagus. Up to that point they are curious. The moment he mentions a man raised from the dead, the text says, some of them mocked. Of course they mocked. In their picture, resurrection is not salvation. Resurrection is being sent back to jail.

So the early Christian teachers had a choice. They could hold the hard Jewish hope, resurrection of the body, against the entire cultural grain, or they could translate it into terms the Greeks already found beautiful, immortality of the soul.

And the terrible thing is that the translation was never a straightforward lie. The Bible does teach that the soul survives death and goes to be with Christ. So the teachers could pick up that true strand, the intermediate life with God, and let it grow until it quietly swallowed the whole. Immortality of the soul was in the Bible as a station on the way. Platonism made it the destination.

Watch the men through whom it came, and be fair to them, because they were often great and they were often right. Origen of Alexandria, working in the early third century, was a genius and a martyr's son and one of the deepest biblical minds the church has ever produced. He also breathed so much Platonism that his picture of the end lets the material world grow thin and spiritual, souls ascending back toward God, the physical almost embarrassed away. The church later judged some of his teaching on this, and rightly. But the deeper influence was not any single doctrine. It was an atmosphere, a set of instincts about what is high and what is low, spirit high and matter low, and those instincts sank into Christian imagination and never left.

Then comes Augustine, the towering bishop of Hippo, converted in 386, the man whose mind shaped Western Christianity more than any other after Paul. I love Augustine. I owe Augustine more than I can say, and so does every thoughtful Christian in the West whether they know it or not. And Augustine came to Christ straight through Platonism. He tells us so himself in the Confessions, written around 397. He read the books of the Platonists first, and they lifted his mind toward the eternal and the immaterial, and only then could he read the gospel. The Platonists were his ladder. And a man does not climb a ladder into the house and then throw it away entirely. Some of the rungs came inside with him.

Now to Augustine's enormous credit, and this is the part most tellers of this story get wrong, Augustine did not abandon the resurrection of the body. In the *City of God*, finished around 426, he defends the bodily resurrection at length and with force, against exactly the Platonists who found it distasteful. He insists the flesh will rise. He is more orthodox on this than his reputation suggests, and I will not let the easy version of church history slander him. But even in Augustine, and far more in those who came after and had a tenth of his care, the center of gravity had shifted. The living hope, the thing that got said at the graveside, the thing that got painted on the ceilings and sung in the hymns, drifted from the body raised on the earth toward the soul ascending to heaven. The doctrine survived on the page. The imagination went Greek.

And imagination is what governs a funeral. No one at Walter's graveside had read Plato. But everyone there had inherited Plato's picture through a thousand hymns and paintings and Sunday school felt boards, the soul rising to the clouds, the harps, the gates, the body left behind as so much shell. By the Middle Ages the church ceiling shows you souls floating upward toward a golden heaven. By the nineteenth century the hymnbook is full of it, this world is not my home, I am just passing through, I will fly away. I have sung *I will Fly Away* at more funerals than I can count and meant it and felt the lift of it, and it is a lovely song, and it is Plato with a banjo. The soul flies away from the body to a home elsewhere. It is not resurrection. It is escape set to music.

I want to be careful not to overcorrect, because that is its own trap. The Greeks were not wrong about everything, and the longing for a world more solid than this one, less shadowed, less subject to decay, is a true longing that the

gospel answers rather than denies. C.S. Lewis, who understood Plato better than most of us and loved him rightly, saw this. In the last of the Narnia books, *The Last Battle*, published in 1956, Lewis has the characters run up into a country that is more real and more solid than the old one, and he half-quotes Plato with a wink, it is all in Plato. But watch what Lewis does with it, because it is exactly the correction I am after. His new country is not less physical than the old one. It is more. The grass is greener, the mountains higher, the rivers wetter. Lewis takes the Platonic longing for the more real and refuses to let it float off into pure spirit. He drives it down into a new and heightened materiality. That is not Plato escaping the world. That is the world redeemed and intensified. That is the biblical hope using the Platonic longing as a servant instead of a master.

So here is the verdict of this chapter, and I want it to land. The clouds-and-harps heaven, the disembodied soul floating up to a spiritual realm, forever free of the flesh and the dirt, is not the teaching of the Bible. It is a Greek picture that the church adopted because it was beautiful and because it was easier to preach to a Greek world and because part of it was true. We did not do it out of malice. We did it out of translation and fatigue and the ordinary human hunger for comfort. But we did it, and I am inside the we, because I have preached that floating soul myself before I knew what I had swallowed.

The good news is that the older hope was never actually lost. It sat underneath the Greek picture the whole time, in the creeds we recited without hearing them. I believe in the resurrection of the body. We say it every week and think we are saying the soul goes to heaven. We are not. We are saying the exact opposite of Plato, and we do not even notice. In the next chapter I am going to make you notice. I am going to

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

open the New Testament and show you, page by page, that what it promises is not the soul's escape from the body but the body's rescue from death, not a flight from the earth but the healing of it. The Greeks are in the best chair. It is time to ask them to get up.

CHAPTER THREE

What the New Testament Actually Promises

LET ME MAKE A promise I intend to keep in this chapter. I am not going to argue this from cleverness. I am going to argue it from the text, out loud, the way you would argue about what a will actually says when the family is gathered and the money is real. Because it is real. Your hope is the most real thing about you, and I want to read you the will.

Begin with the word. Resurrection. In Greek, *anastasis*, which means a standing up, a getting up. Not ascent. Not escape. Not the release of a spirit. A standing up of something that was lying down. When the New Testament reaches for its central image of the future, it does not reach for a bird leaving a cage or a prisoner going free. It reaches for a body that was horizontal becoming vertical. A corpse that stands. That single word should have kept us honest for two thousand years, and mostly it did not, because we heard it and pictured a soul rising. It does not mean a soul rising. It means a body

standing.

Go to Paul, First Corinthians 15, written around the year 54, which is the oldest and most sustained treatment of the Christian hope anywhere in the New Testament, older than the Gospels in written form. Paul is writing to a church in Corinth, a Greek city, full of exactly the Platonic instinct we just traced, and some of them are saying there is no resurrection of the dead. Notice they are not atheists. They are Christians who believe in an afterlife. What they cannot swallow is a bodily one, because they are good Greeks and the body is the prison. And Paul does not meet them halfway. He does not say, well, the important thing is that we go to be with the Lord in spirit. He goes to war for the body. If there is no resurrection of the dead, he says, then not even Christ has been raised, and if Christ has not been raised your faith is futile and you are still in your sins and those who have died in Christ have perished. He stakes the entire gospel on a bodily resurrection and refuses any spiritualized substitute.

Then he anticipates the Greek objection precisely. Someone will ask, he says, how are the dead raised, with what kind of body do they come. That is the Corinthian sneer, the same one Athens gave him on the Areopagus. And his answer is the seed. What you sow does not come to life unless it dies, and what you sow is not the body that is to be, but a bare seed, and God gives it a body as He has chosen. It is sown perishable, it is raised imperishable. It is sown in weakness, it is raised in power. It is sown a natural body, it is raised a spiritual body. Now that phrase, spiritual body, has been misread for centuries as if it meant a non-physical body, a ghost, and that reading is exactly backward. The Greek does not contrast physical with immaterial. It contrasts a body animated by mere natural life with a body animated by the

Spirit of God, a body so filled with the life of God that it can never die again. It is more solid, not less. It is Lewis's greener grass. Paul is not promising the Corinthians they will escape the body. He is promising them a body that has finally caught fire with the life of God and cannot be put out.

Keep reading, because Paul draws the line straight to the earth. The last enemy to be destroyed is death. Not accommodated. Not befriended. Not reinterpreted as a graduation. Destroyed. Death is an enemy to the end, and the end is its destruction, and the mechanism of its destruction is resurrection. That is the whole shape of the hope. Not souls escaping the reach of death, but death itself put to death, and bodies standing up on the far side of it.

Go to Romans 8, the same Paul a few years later, and watch him refuse to leave the rest of creation behind. He says the creation itself was subjected to futility, groaning as in the pains of childbirth, waiting for its own liberation. The creation waits with eager longing for the revealing of the children of God, because the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to decay. Read that slowly. The trees. The oceans. The soil Walter farmed. Paul says they are groaning, in labor, waiting to be set free. That is not the language of a world about to be discarded. You do not put a laboring mother out with the trash. Labor is the language of something about to give birth. Paul says the whole material creation is pregnant with its own redemption, and our resurrection and its renewal are tied together in one delivery. If the church's real hope were escape from the world, Paul forgot to tell the world, because he has the world straining toward the same future we are.

Go to the Gospels and look at what the risen Jesus actually

is, because He is the pattern and the guarantee of everything Paul promises. When Jesus comes out of the tomb, He is not a ghost. He goes out of His way to prove it. In Luke 24 the disciples think they are seeing a spirit, and He says, touch me and see, a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have. And then, in the detail that undoes every Platonic reading of the resurrection, He asks if they have anything to eat, and they give Him a piece of broiled fish, and He eats it in front of them. The risen Lord of the universe eats a fish. You do not feed a soul that has escaped its body. You do not hand broiled fish to a liberated spirit. The whole point of the fish is that this is a body, a real one, continuous with the one that was crucified, still bearing the wounds, and yet different, able to pass through doors and appear and vanish. Transformed, but physical. The seed and the plant. That is what is coming for you. Not a wisp. A body that can eat fish on a healed earth.

I have to slow down here, because I know what the objection is, and it is a serious one. Someone reading this will say, but Pastor, what about the passages that clearly talk about going to heaven when we die. What about Paul saying to depart and be with Christ is far better. What about the thief on the cross, today you will be with me in Paradise. Are you throwing those out. And the answer is no, absolutely not, and I want to be scrupulously fair to them, because a bad case for a true thing helps no one. Those passages are real and I believe every word of them. Paul does expect to be with Christ the moment he dies. The thief is with Jesus in Paradise that very day. There is a real, conscious, comforting life with the Lord immediately after death.

But here is the thing the escapist reading misses. In every one of those passages, that state is not described as the end. It is described as an interim. Paul in Philippians wants to

depart and be with Christ, yes, and in the very same letter he says our citizenship is in heaven, from which we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body. He is not waiting to go to heaven. He is a citizen of heaven waiting for heaven's King to come here and raise his body. The going to be with Christ is the front porch. The resurrection is the house. And the church, over the centuries, moved into the porch, decorated it, hung pictures on it, and forgot there was a house at all.

So let me give you the verdict of the whole New Testament in one line, and then I will spend the rest of this book proving I did not overstate it. The New Testament does not promise that you will go to heaven. It promises that heaven will come to you, that God will raise your body, that He will renew His creation, and that He will dwell with His people on a healed earth forever. Going to be with Christ when you die is true and precious and I will preach it at your funeral. But it is the smaller half of a larger hope, and the church has been living in the smaller half for so long that the larger one sounds strange, almost like heresy, when you finally say it out loud.

It is not heresy. It is the oldest thing there is. It is what got Paul mocked in Athens and killed in Rome. It is the reason there was ever a church at all. Because at the center of it, at the very hinge of history, there is a tomb that was full on Friday and empty on Sunday, and a body that got up. Everything I have said in this chapter stands or falls on that one event. So that is where we go next. Not to a doctrine. To a grave, outside a city, on a specific morning, and the thing that happened there that no Greek philosophy and no comfortable funeral has ever been able to explain away.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Hinge of History

EVERYTHING I HAVE SAID so far rests on one claim, and the claim is not a doctrine. It is an event. Either a specific man named Jesus of Nazareth was dead and then was bodily alive again on a specific Sunday outside Jerusalem around the year 30, or He was not. If He was not, then this whole book is a beautiful arrangement of nothing, and you should close it and go do something useful with your afternoon. I mean that. I am not interested in a hope that floats free of history. I spent too many years as an atheist to want a comfort I have to lie to myself to keep.

So let me tell you how I came to believe it, because I did not believe it easily and I did not want to. I was in my twenties, sure that religion was what frightened people told themselves in the dark, and I picked up the arguments for the resurrection expecting to knock them down, the way you flick a chess piece. What I found instead was a problem I could not make go away, and the more honestly I looked at it the worse the problem got, until one day I understood that the problem was going to cost me my whole picture of the world.

Here is the problem, and I want to give it to you the way it

was given to me, which is not as a Sunday school flannelgraph but as a historian's puzzle. In the first century, a movement started in Jerusalem, within weeks of the crucifixion, claiming that its executed leader had been bodily raised from the dead. That movement grew explosively in the very city where the tomb was, where the authorities who had killed Him held power, where anyone could have walked the fifteen minutes to the grave. The Roman and Jewish authorities had every motive in the world to end the movement, and one very simple way to do it. Produce the body. Walk to the tomb, roll the stone, carry the corpse into the street, and the whole thing collapses in an afternoon. They did not do it. The best explanation for why they did not do it is that they could not, because the tomb was empty and they knew it, and their own counter-story, recorded even in Matthew's Gospel, was not He is still in the grave but His disciples stole the body. You do not invent a story about a stolen corpse to explain a corpse that is still lying there. The empty tomb is conceded by the enemies of the movement in the very act of trying to explain it away.

That is the first fact. Here is the second, and it is the one that finally broke me. The people who claimed to have seen Him alive did not merely say it. They died for it. Now people die for false beliefs all the time, I knew that objection, I had used it. People fly planes into buildings for things that are not true. But there is a difference, and it is decisive. The men who fly the planes are sincere about something they were told by someone else. The apostles were making a claim about something they said they personally saw with their own eyes, a claim they were in a position to know was false if it was false. A man may die for a lie he believes. A man does not, as a rule, die under torture for a lie he himself made up and

knows he made up, when a single sentence of recantation would save his life. And they did not recant. They went to their deaths, most of them, insisting they had eaten with a dead man.

The scholar Richard Bauckham, in his 2006 book *Jesus and the Eyewitnesses*, made the case that the Gospels are not late legends but are anchored in named eyewitness testimony, that the very names preserved in the accounts function the way a living witness list functions, people you could go and ask. This matters enormously. The resurrection accounts are not the kind of thing that grows up centuries later in the fog when everyone who could contradict it is dead. They circulate while the witnesses are alive and can be cross-examined, and they name women as the first witnesses, which no first-century forger inventing a persuasive story would ever do, because a woman's testimony was not admissible in a court of that world. You do not build your central legal proof on witnesses your culture will not accept, unless you are stuck with them because that is actually what happened. The embarrassment is the evidence.

And then there is the church itself, the thing you can still walk into on a Sunday. N.T. Wright, in that 2003 study *The Resurrection of the Son of God*, pressed hard on a historical oddity most of us never notice. Second-Temple Judaism had a range of beliefs about the afterlife, but where it believed in resurrection at all, it believed in one great resurrection of all the righteous at the end of history, together, at once. No Jew expected one man to be raised in the middle of history ahead of everyone else. It was not a category anyone had. And yet within a few years you have thousands of Jews, monotheists to the bone, reorganizing their entire week around the worship of a crucified man, moving their sacred day from

Saturday to Sunday, and saying that the resurrection, the great end-of-history event, had begun, in one man, ahead of schedule. Something happened to make first-century Jews say a thing their entire framework had no room for. The most economical explanation for the mutation is that the event actually occurred and forced the framework to bend around it.

I could keep going, and scholars far better than I have, but I want to be honest about what these arguments do and do not do. They do not compel belief. Nothing about the resurrection compels belief, and I think God designed it that way, because a proof that left you no freedom would not leave you any love either. What the arguments do is remove the option of the lazy dismissal. They make it intellectually respectable, even intellectually demanding, to conclude that the tomb was empty and the appearances were real. They got me to the place where unbelief cost me more than belief, where the naturalistic explanations required more faith than the resurrection did. The disciples stole the body and then cheerfully died for what they knew was a hoax. Everyone hallucinated the same physical man eating fish over a period of weeks in groups of up to five hundred. The whole thing is a legend that somehow grew instantly, in the one city where it was checkable, among the one people whose framework had no slot for it. At some point the alternatives become their own kind of miracle, and a shabbier one.

But I need to say why this chapter sits where it does in this book, because it is not here merely to defend the faith in general. It is here because the resurrection is not one Christian doctrine among many. It is the hinge on which the whole hope I am arguing for actually turns. If Christ is raised bodily, then the future I have been describing is not wishful

thinking. It has already started. One tomb in history is already empty. One body has already crossed from death into the indestructible life on the far side, and Paul calls Him the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep, which is a farming word, Walter's word. The firstfruits are the first sheaf of the harvest, brought in ahead of the rest, and the whole point of firstfruits is that they guarantee the field. You do not bring in the firstfruits and then leave the field to rot. The firstfruits are a promise the size of a harvest. Christ's risen body is the first sheaf of the new creation, standing already in history, and it means the rest of the field, your body, the earth, all of it, is coming in behind Him.

That is why the escapist hope is not just too small but actually gets the resurrection backward. The escapist treats Easter as the day Jesus proved there is a heaven to go to, the day the soul was shown to survive. But Easter did not vindicate the immortality of the soul. Everyone in the ancient world already believed in some version of that. Easter announced something no one believed, that the new creation had begun inside the old one, that God had started the renewal of the world with a single body, and that death, the last enemy, had a crack running through it that would one day split it open entirely. Easter is not the proof of escape. Easter is the beginning of the end of escape, because it is the beginning of the world being made new rather than left behind.

Let me close where I began, as the skeptic I used to be. If you are reading this and you do not believe a word of it, I am not going to press you toward a decision, because manufactured urgency is a con and you would smell it. I only ask you to sit with the size of the problem before you dismiss it. A grave that the authorities could have emptied with a

wheelbarrow and never did. A dozen men who could have gone home and lived and instead died insisting they had touched a wound in a living man they had watched be killed. A people who changed the shape of time itself around an event their own beliefs said was impossible. You can conclude they were all deluded or lying. People have. But you cannot conclude, honestly, that it is stupid to think otherwise. And once you cannot conclude that, you are where I was, standing at the edge of a grave that will not stay shut, feeling the whole world you built begin to lean.

The tomb is empty. That is the hinge. Everything else in this book, the body, the earth, the justice, the grief, the death you will one day face, swings on it. So now let us follow it out. Start with the thing the whole Greek world found most offensive and the risen Christ made most central. The body. Your body. Why it matters, why God will not throw it away, and why what you do with it now is not a side issue but very nearly the whole thing.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Redemption of the Body

SAY THE WORDS OUT loud, because the church has been saying them for seventeen centuries and almost no one hears them. I believe in the resurrection of the body. Not the immortality of the soul. Not the survival of the spirit. The resurrection of the body. It is in the Apostles Creed, which took its shape in the early centuries and which millions of Christians recite by rote every Sunday, and it is the single most anti-Platonic sentence in the Christian vocabulary, and we have managed to say it every week while believing the opposite. We say body and picture soul. We confess resurrection and imagine escape. The creed has been trying to correct us the whole time and we have not been listening.

I want to make you feel the strangeness of the claim, because familiarity has worn it smooth. God is going to raise your body. Not a spiritual essence of you. Not a better version of your personality unhooked from matter. Your body. The one reading this. The one with the bad knee and the scar on your hand and the face you do not like in photographs. That

body, or rather that body transformed as the seed is transformed into the plant, is going to stand up on the last day and live forever on a renewed earth. Christianity is, at its root, the most embarrassingly physical of all the great faiths, and we have spent centuries trying to make it more respectable by making it more spiritual, which is to say more Greek, which is to say less true.

Why does the body matter so much to God. The answer is in the first chapter of the Bible and I do not think we have ever fully recovered from forgetting it. In Genesis 1, God makes the material world and looks at it and calls it good, and He says it again and again, good, good, good, and at the end, very good. Matter is not a mistake. Matter is not a prison the soul fell into. Matter is God's idea, God's handiwork, God's delight. And then God does the thing that ought to have settled the entire question forever. He makes a body out of the dirt and He puts His own image in it. The image of God is not stamped on a disembodied soul floating above the mud. It is stamped on a creature of dust with lungs and a spine. You are the image of God as a body. The Platonist thinks the body drags the divine spark down. The Bible says the body is where the divine image lives.

And then, at the center of the Christian story, God does something that no Platonist could have dreamed and that most Christians still cannot quite metabolize. God becomes a body. The Word became flesh, John says, and dwelt among us. Not the Word put on the costume of flesh temporarily and then shed it. The Word became flesh. God took a body, a real one, that got tired and hungry and wept at a friend's tomb and bled on a Roman cross. And here is the part that undoes escapism entirely. After the resurrection, He did not give the body back. The ascension is not Jesus finally shedding the

flesh now that the earthly work is done and returning to pure spirit. The ascension is a human body, a scarred human body, taken up into the very life of God. There is, at this moment, a man in the presence of the Father. The incarnation was not a temporary emergency measure. It was permanent. God has joined Himself to matter forever, and that alone should have killed the idea that matter is what we are trying to escape.

So the redemption of the body is not a footnote to salvation. It is the shape of salvation. Look at how Paul talks in Romans 8, the same chapter where the creation groans. He says we ourselves, who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as we wait eagerly for our adoption, the redemption of our bodies. Read that carefully, because it upends the popular picture. In the popular picture, salvation is your soul getting rescued out of your body. In Paul, salvation is your body getting redeemed. The body is not the thing you are saved from. The body is part of what is saved. Paul does not say we wait for release from the body. He says we wait for the redemption of the body. The escapist has salvation pointed in exactly the wrong direction, away from the body, when the Bible has it aimed straight at the body.

Now let me steelman the other side, because I owe it. A thoughtful believer will say, but Pastor, does not Paul himself say flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God. Does he not talk about longing to be away from the body and at home with the Lord. Is there not a real strand in the New Testament that treats the body as a burden. Yes. There is, and I will not pretend it away. Paul groans in this tent, he calls the body lowly, he knows its weakness and its appetite and its capacity for sin, and he longs for its transformation. The Christian view is not a naive celebration of the body exactly as it is. The body is fallen. It gets sick. It betrays us. It dies.

Paul is not a sentimentalist about flesh.

But watch the difference, because it is everything. When Paul says flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom, he is not saying the body is discarded. He is saying the perishable must put on the imperishable, the mortal must put on immortality. It is the same seed and plant again. The problem with flesh and blood is not that it is physical. The problem is that it is perishable, subject to death and decay, and what cannot inherit the kingdom is not the body as such but the body as dying. The solution is not to strip off the body but to clothe it with a life that death cannot touch. When Paul longs to be away from the body, he immediately clarifies, in Second Corinthians 5, that he does not wish to be unclothed but to be further clothed, so that what is mortal may be swallowed up by life. He does not want to be a naked soul. He wants a better body. The Christian hope is not less body. It is more.

I have to make this concrete, because a doctrine of the body that stays in the head has already betrayed itself. If God is going to redeem your body, then your body matters now, and what you do with it and to it and through it is not spiritually neutral. This is where the escapist and the biblical hope produce two completely different kinds of person. The escapist, deep down, treats the body as a rental car. It is going to be junked anyway, so who cares if you run it hard, feed it garbage, use it for whatever appetite is loudest, exploit someone else's body for your pleasure, because none of it finally matters, the soul is what counts and the soul is going to heaven clean. This is not a caricature. This is the actual working theology under a great deal of Christian behavior, including a great deal of my own over the years, and it is Platonism, not the gospel. If the body is disposable, the body is expendable, and every sin against the body, gluttony and

lust and violence and neglect, gets quietly downgraded to a minor offense against packaging.

But if God is going to raise this body, then this body is holy ground. Paul says exactly this to the Corinthians, in the middle of an argument about sexual sin, of all places. Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit, he says, and then the reason, glorify God in your body. Not in your soul only. In your body. The reason a Christian cannot treat the body as a playground for every appetite is not that the body is bad and must be suppressed. It is that the body is destined for resurrection and must be honored. The same logic that makes escapists loose about the body makes resurrection people reverent about it. What God is going to raise, you do not defile. What God is going to redeem, you do not throw away.

And this reverence for the body reaches past your own. If every human body is destined for either resurrection or judgment, if every human body carries the image of God and is claimed by the God who took a body Himself, then there is no such thing as a disposable person, because there is no such thing as a disposable body. The hungry body must be fed. The sick body must be tended. The imprisoned body must be visited. The trafficked body must be freed. The unborn body must be protected. The elderly body, drooling and forgetful and inconvenient, must be honored, because it is not a shell wearing out but a temple awaiting glory. The whole ethic of Christian care for the vulnerable grows straight out of the resurrection of the body, and the whole slide toward treating certain bodies as expendable grows straight out of forgetting it. I have watched the church do both. I have done both. The doctrine you hold about the last day is quietly writing your ethic on this one.

So here is the verdict. The redemption of the body is not the least believable part of the Christian hope that we tolerate out of loyalty to the creed. It is the center of the thing. It is God refusing to let go of what He made, refusing to let death have the last word over the dust He shaped and imaged and became. Your body is not a shell. Your body is a seed. And the God who planted it does not plant what He intends to lose. Now let us follow the seed into the ground where it is planted, because it is not planted in nowhere. It is planted in the earth, and the earth, it turns out, is going somewhere too.

CHAPTER SIX

A New Heaven and a New Earth

TURN TO THE LAST two pages of the Bible, because the whole story has been walking toward them the entire time and almost no one reads them for what they say. Revelation 21 and 22. Ask the average churchgoer how the Bible ends and they will tell you we go up to heaven. Read the actual text and watch it do the opposite. And I saw a new heaven and a new earth, John writes, and then, I saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God. Coming down. Not us going up. The city comes down. Heaven comes to earth. The direction of the entire Christian hope, at the very last, is not evacuation but arrival, not our ascent to God's realm but God's realm descending into ours.

Sit with that a moment, because it reverses everything the funeral told us. The escapist gospel has one basic vector, and it points up and away, souls rising out of a doomed world toward a heaven located elsewhere. The Bible's own ending has the opposite vector. It points down and toward, the New Jerusalem descending, God moving into the neighborhood,

heaven and earth married at last. And then John hears a great voice, the voice from the throne that gives this book its title, and it does not say behold, I am taking my people away. It says behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them. And behold, I am making all things new. Not all new things. All things new. There is a world of difference in that one word. God is not scrapping creation and starting over with a fresh batch. He is taking the things that are and making them new. The verb is renewal, not replacement.

I know the objection, and it is a strong one, and I have to face it head on, because there is a passage that seems to teach exactly the escapist picture. Second Peter 3 says that the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the heavenly bodies will be burned up and dissolved, and the earth and the works that are done on it will be exposed, or in some manuscripts, burned up. For centuries this has been read as proof that the material world gets incinerated, annihilated, deleted, and that all that survives is the saved soul heading elsewhere. If that reading is right, my whole book is wrong, so let me not dodge it.

Here is what the reading misses. The fire in Second Peter is not the fire of a garbage incinerator. It is the fire of a refiner. Peter himself gives the key when he compares it to the flood of Noah. The flood did not annihilate the world. The flood judged and cleansed the world, and the world came through it, washed. Fire in the Bible is overwhelmingly the image of purification, the smelter that burns away the dross and leaves the gold, and Peter's whole point is moral, that the corruption and injustice done on the earth will be exposed and burned out of it, not that the earth itself will be deleted. The best manuscripts, in fact, do not even say the earth will be burned up. They say the earth and the works on it will be found, laid

bare, exposed to judgment. What passes away in the fire is not the creation but the evil in it. The earth is not the fuel. The earth is what is left standing when the fire has done its work of burning away everything that defiled it. Peter ends the passage not by saying we await new souls in a new place but that we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells. Same phrase as Revelation. The earth survives the fire, purified, and righteousness moves in.

Once you see that, the whole Bible snaps into a single shape. It does not begin in a garden and end in a cloud. It begins in a garden and ends in a city, and the city is on a renewed earth, and there is a river running through it and a tree of life on its banks, and the tree, John says, is for the healing of the nations. The story is a great arc from Eden to New Jerusalem, from a garden God planted to a city God perfects, and the whole physical creation is carried across the arc, wounded and then healed, subjected to futility and then set free. If the point were escape, the Bible would end where Plato ends, with the soul going home to the realm of pure spirit. It does not. It ends with God coming home to the realm of matter He never stopped loving.

Now let me say what I think we lost when we lost this, because it is not abstract. We lost the goodness of the world. If your hope is that God is going to burn all of this and take you elsewhere, then a sunset is a distraction, a body is a burden, a mountain is scenery on the way out, a marriage is a temporary arrangement, a garden is a hobby, and the deep pleasure you feel in a good meal or a cold lake or the face of someone you love is at best a harmless indulgence and at worst a snare that ties your heart to a world you are supposed to be leaving. The escapist cannot fully enjoy the world without guilt, because the world is the thing he is trying to get

out of. And I have met these Christians, and I have been one, faintly ashamed of loving the earth, treating every earthly joy as a lesser thing to be endured until the real thing starts somewhere clean and immaterial.

But if God is going to redeem the earth and not destroy it, then every good thing in it is not a distraction from the hope but a foretaste of it. The sunset is not scenery you are leaving. It is a rehearsal for a glory that is coming to stay. The cold lake and the good meal and the beloved face are not snares. They are appetizers, samples of a renewed creation where such joys will not fade and will not be tainted and will not be interrupted by death. C.S. Lewis got at this in a sermon called *The Weight of Glory*, preached in 1941, when he said that our earthly pleasures are not the thing itself but the scent of a flower we have not found, the echo of a tune we have not heard. He was not despising the pleasures. He was saying they point beyond themselves to a world where the flower is found and the tune plays without end. That is the resurrection reading of earthly joy. Not guilt. Anticipation.

And this changes how you hold everything you love. When you understand that God is going to renew the creation, you can love the world with your whole heart without idolizing it, because you know its goodness is real but not final, wounded now but destined for healing. You do not have to choose between loving the earth and longing for heaven, which is the false choice escapism forced on us for centuries. You get to long for heaven to come to earth, which means you get to love the earth as the very thing your hope is bending toward. The farmer loving his ground, the mother loving her child's small body, the friend loving the lake in October, none of it is a lower love to be repented of. It is the first line of a poem God intends to finish.

So the verdict of this chapter is simple and it is enormous. The Bible does not end with you going to heaven. It ends with heaven coming to you. It ends with a city descending, a God dwelling, a creation renewed, and a voice from the throne saying not that the old is being thrown away but that all of it is being made new. You are not waiting to leave. You are waiting for the King to come and finish the world He started and never stopped loving. That is a bigger hope than escape, and a harder one, and a truer one. But it raises an honest question I refuse to skip, the question every grieving person actually asks at the graveside. If the great hope is a renewed earth still to come, then what about now. What about the person in the box today. Where is Walter tonight, while the earth still waits. That question deserves a careful and honest answer, and it is the one we take up next.

CHAPTER SEVEN

With Christ, But Not Yet the End

*The dead in Christ are not home yet.
They are on the front porch, and the
porch light is Christ Himself.*

HERE IS WHERE I have to slow down and be a pastor, because everything I have argued so far can be misheard as taking a comfort away, and I would rather cut off my hand than take comfort from a grieving person under the banner of correcting their theology. So let me say it plainly before I say anything else. If someone you love died in Christ, they are with the Lord right now, tonight, and they are more alive and more at peace than they have ever been. I believe that with everything in me and I will say it at your funeral without a flicker of hesitation. The recovery of the resurrection does not cancel the comfort of the intermediate state. It puts it in

its proper place, which is precious, but not final.

Let me define the term, because the church has a name for this and most people have never heard it. The intermediate state is the condition of the dead between their death and the resurrection. It is the in-between, the porch I keep mentioning, the time when the body is in the ground and the person is with Christ but the last day has not yet come and the body has not yet been raised. And the Bible does teach it. It is not the whole hope, but it is real, and I will not let anyone tell a widow otherwise.

The evidence is not thin. Jesus tells the thief on the cross, in Luke 23, today you will be with me in Paradise. Today. Not at the end of history, but that very day, the two of them together in some real place of comfort. Paul, in Philippians 1, says that to die is gain, and that his desire is to depart and be with Christ, which is far better. He does not say to die is to sleep dreamlessly until the resurrection. He says to die is to be with Christ, and to be with Christ is better than the good life he is currently living. In Second Corinthians 5 he says that to be away from the body is to be at home with the Lord. And in Revelation, John sees under the altar the souls of those who had been slain for the word of God, and they are conscious, and they cry out, and they are told to rest a little longer. Conscious rest, in the presence of God, awaiting something still to come. That is the intermediate state, and the New Testament is not shy about it.

So the person you buried is not unconscious and is not annihilated and is not floating in some gray nowhere. They are with Christ, at rest, comforted, safe. Let that be as large as it is. When I stand at a graveside and a widow's whole body is shaking, I do not lead with new creation eschatology. I lead

with this. He is with the Lord. She is at peace. The Christ who loved them in life is holding them now. That is true, and it is the first word of comfort, and I will never demote it.

But watch what I just called it. The first word. Not the last. And here is where the church went wrong, not by affirming the intermediate state but by mistaking it for the whole thing, by moving into the porch and calling it the mansion. Because if you read those same passages carefully, every single one of them treats being with Christ as an interim, not a destination. The souls under the altar are told to wait, which means they are waiting for something. Paul who longs to be with Christ is the same Paul who in the same breath longs for the resurrection of the body, who says our citizenship is in heaven from which we await a Savior who will transform our lowly bodies. He is not waiting to get to heaven. He is a citizen of heaven waiting for the King to come and finish the job by raising him bodily. The intermediate state is real, but it is called intermediate for a reason. It is the middle. It is not the end.

N.T. Wright put this in a phrase I have never been able to improve on, and I quoted it earlier because it deserves repeating. Life after death, he said in *Surprised by Hope*, is not the ultimate Christian hope. The ultimate hope is life after life after death. There is a life immediately after you die, with Christ, which is wonderful and real. And then there is a life after that life, the resurrection, when the body is raised and the earth is renewed and God dwells with His people forever. Two stages, not one. And the whole error of escapism was to collapse the two into one, to take the first stage, the soul with Christ, and treat it as the final home, when the Bible treats it as the waiting room before the real thing.

Why does this distinction matter, if the first stage is already so good. It matters because of what gets lost when you forget the second stage. If being a disembodied soul with Christ is the final destination, then the body is genuinely dispensable, the earth is genuinely disposable, and the resurrection becomes a strange and unnecessary appendix. Why raise the body if the soul is already home and happy. The escapist has no good answer, and so the resurrection of the body becomes, in the escapist's actual functioning faith, a doctrine he recites in the creed and cannot explain and secretly suspects is redundant. But once you see the intermediate state as the porch and the resurrection as the house, the whole thing coheres. The soul with Christ is comforted but incomplete, at rest but still awaiting the body, at home with the Lord but not yet home in the full sense, because a human being is not meant to be a naked soul forever. Even the blessed dead are waiting. Even Walter, at peace with Christ tonight, is waiting for the morning when his body comes up out of that ground.

I find this unbearably tender rather than cold. Think about what it means. The people we have lost, safe as they are, are not yet all they will be. They are, if I can put it this way, not yet finished. God is not done with them. The best is still ahead even for the ones already with Christ. When I imagine my own father, whom I never really had, and I imagine, if he is with Christ, that even his comfort now is not the end of what God intends for him, that there is a resurrection morning coming when he stands whole in a body that death can never touch again, I do not find the intermediate state diminished. I find it enlarged, because it turns out to be a doorway rather than a room.

Let me handle the honest hard questions, because a pastor

who dodges them is no pastor. What is the intermediate state actually like. Are the dead conscious or asleep. Do they experience the passage of time. And the honest answer is that the Bible tells us enough for comfort and not enough for a map. It tells us the dead in Christ are with Him, at rest, conscious in some real sense, comforted. It does not give us the physics. Some passages call death a sleep, and I think that image is meant to convey peace and the certainty of waking, not unconsciousness, because the same authors elsewhere clearly describe the dead as aware and with Christ. There may well be, on the far side of death, no experience of the long wait at all, since a soul outside the body may be outside time as we know it, so that the moment of death and the moment of resurrection touch. I do not know, and I will not pretend to, because the one unforgivable thing a pastor can do at a graveside is invent details to sound authoritative. What I know is enough. They are with Him. They are at rest. And they, like us, are waiting for the morning.

So do not let anyone, including me, take the intermediate comfort from you. When your mother dies in Christ, she is with the Lord that day, and you may say so, and you may weep with relief that she is beyond the reach of the cancer and the fear. That is true. But do not stop there, because the Bible does not stop there, and the church's centuries-long habit of stopping there is exactly the trade this book is trying to reverse. Say the first word, she is with Christ. And then say the second word, the one we forgot. And she is waiting, as we are, for the day her body comes up out of the ground and God makes all things new. The first word is comfort. The second word is hope. You need both, and the church for too long gave you only the first and called it the whole gospel.

Now, having secured the comfort, I have to turn hard,

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

because the trade we made did not only shrink our hope. It changed our behavior. It made us treat the world as a sinking ship. And a man who thinks he is on a sinking ship does not repair the deck. In the next chapters I want to show you the price we paid in the world we actually live in, and I want to start with the ground itself, the dirt Walter farmed and the planet we are handing our children, because escapism has a great deal to answer for there.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Disposable Earth

*You do not wash the deck of a ship you
believe is going down. You loot it.*

I WANT TO TELL you about a conversation that has stayed with me for years, because it exposed the machinery under a whole way of thinking. A man in my church, a good man, generous, faithful, the kind who shows up with a truck when you are moving, told me once, with complete sincerity, that he did not see the point of getting worked up about the environment, because, and I am quoting him almost exactly, it is all going to burn anyway. He was not being cruel. He was being consistent. He had been taught a version of Christianity in which the earth is a temporary stage set, scheduled for demolition, and the only thing that finally matters is getting souls off it before the fire. Given that theology, his conclusion was airtight. Why maintain a house you have been told is condemned.

That sentence, it is all going to burn anyway, is the escapist

gospel applied to the ground under our feet, and it is one of the most spiritually and practically destructive ideas the church has ever let itself believe. And I want to be careful and fair, because the man who said it to me was not a villain and was not lazy and did not hate the world. He had simply drawn the correct conclusion from a false premise. If the earth is a doomed vessel and salvation is evacuation, then caring for the earth is not merely optional, it is almost foolish, like polishing the brass on the Titanic. The escapist premise makes creation care look like a distraction from the real work, at best a hobby, at worst a compromise with a world we are supposed to be leaving.

So let me go after the premise, because the behavior follows the premise and you cannot fix the behavior without fixing the premise. The premise is that the earth is going to be annihilated. I dealt with the main proof text in the last chapter, the fire of Second Peter that turns out to be a refiner's fire and not an incinerator, the earth found and purified rather than deleted. But let me build the positive case, because it is not enough to defang one verse. The whole Bible has to be heard.

Start where the Bible starts. God made the earth and called it good, six times good and once very good, before there was a single human soul to save. The earth was not created as a disposable container for souls. It was created as a good thing in itself, the object of God's own delight, the theater of His glory. And when God made humanity, His very first commission, before the fall, before the law, before anything, was to work the garden and keep it. The Hebrew words are worked and guarded, the language of a gardener and the language of a watchman. The first human job description was creation care. It was not a concession to a

fallen world. It was the original vocation of the image of God, to tend the earth on God's behalf, as His stewards, His under-gardeners. We were made to keep the garden, and we have spent our history strip-mining it, and the escapist theology gave us a religious excuse to keep doing it.

Now bring in the resurrection, because this is where the argument becomes not just ethical but eschatological. If God were going to annihilate the earth, then the escapist would be right and creation care would be beside the point. But God is not going to annihilate the earth. He is going to renew it. Romans 8 has the whole creation groaning in labor, waiting to be set free from its bondage to decay, and Paul ties that liberation directly to our resurrection. The earth is not the wrapping paper we discard to get at the gift of saved souls. The earth is part of the gift. It is going to be redeemed alongside us, healed alongside us, glorified alongside us. And if that is the earth's destiny, then how we treat it now is not spiritually neutral. It is either a rehearsal for its redemption or a rebellion against it.

Think about what it means that the resurrected earth is continuous with this one. When Jesus rose, He did not get a brand new body unrelated to the old. He got this body, transformed, still bearing the wounds, continuous with the one that was buried. The tomb was empty precisely because the new body was the old body raised, not a replacement issued while the corpse stayed in the grave. And that continuity is the pattern for the whole creation. The new earth is not a different earth God makes after junking this one. It is this earth, raised, this creation carried through death into indestructible life, the same world healed. Which means the mountains you love and the rivers you fish and the soil you plant may, in some way we cannot fully picture, be

there in the end, redeemed. You are not caring for a doomed thing. You are caring for something God intends to resurrect.

That reframes everything. When you plant a tree, protect a watershed, refuse to poison a river, clean up what your industry fouled, you are not polishing brass on a sinking ship. You are, in a small and anticipatory way, doing to a corner of creation what God is going to do to all of it. You are getting the world ready for its King, the way you clean a house before an honored guest arrives, except the guest is going to move in and stay and make the house better than you ever could. Creation care, on the resurrection view, is not environmentalism borrowed from the culture and baptized. It is resurrection hope enacted in the dirt. It is a rehearsal.

Now I have to be honest and even-handed, because this subject has been captured by tribes and I refuse to hand it to one. There is a version of environmental concern that is itself a substitute religion, that worships the creation instead of the Creator, that treats human beings as a pollutant on an otherwise pristine planet, that has no place for the unique dignity of the image of God and would happily sacrifice human flourishing to an abstraction called nature. That is not the biblical view either, and Christians are right to resist it. The Bible does not teach that the earth is divine or that humans are a cancer on it. It teaches that the earth is God's good creation and humans are its appointed stewards, higher than the rest of creation and responsible for it, neither its masters to exploit nor its servants to worship. The steward is not the owner, and the steward is not the equal of the sparrow. The steward is answerable to the Owner for how the sparrows fared under his watch.

And that is precisely the note the escapist and the earth-

worshiper both miss, from opposite sides. The escapist says the earth does not matter because we are leaving it. The earth-worshiper says the earth is ultimate because there is nothing beyond it. The Bible says the earth matters enormously because it belongs to God and He is going to redeem it, and we will answer to Him for how we treated what He loved and intends to raise. That is a heavier accountability than either the exploiter or the idolater carries. I would rather answer for having strip-mined a hobby than for having strip-mined the very thing God was preparing to resurrect.

Let me bring it home to my own house, because I am inside this indictment like every other. I have five sons. I am handing them a world, and the theology I hand them will tell them what that world is for. If I hand them escapism, I hand them permission to use the world up, because it is all going to burn anyway, and I will have taught them contempt for the ground under their feet in the name of the God who made it. But if I hand them the resurrection, I hand them a reason to love the world fiercely and tend it carefully and refuse to loot it, because they will know it is not a doomed ship but a seed in the ground, and God does not plant what He means to lose. I would rather my sons overwater the garden out of love than let it die out of a theology that told them it did not count.

So here is the verdict, and I want the good generous man with the truck to hear it, because I said far too little to him when he told me it was all going to burn. It is not all going to burn. It is all going to be raised. And if you knew that, really knew it in your gut the way you know the resurrection of your own body, you would treat this earth the way a farmer treats ground he intends to plant again next spring, not the way a looter treats a house he is about to leave. The earth is not disposable, because nothing God intends to redeem is

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

disposable. And that same logic, the logic that will not let the earth be disposable, is about to make justice something more than a distraction too. If God is going to put the world right, then putting things right is not a side project. It is the family business.

CHAPTER NINE

Why Escapism Makes Justice Optional

*If the world is going to be thrown away,
injustice is a temporary
inconvenience. If the world is going to
be raised, injustice is a wound in the
thing God is healing.*

THERE IS A HYMN I grew up hearing at funerals, and there is a line in it, and I want to look at that line honestly because it captures the whole problem. This world is not my home, I am just passing through. It is a beautiful old song and I do not want to be cruel to it. But sit with the theology of that line for a moment, because it has consequences a mile wide. If this world is not my home and I am just passing through, then the injustices of this world are somebody else's problem, or

nobody's problem, features of a way station I am leaving rather than wounds in a home I am staying in. You do not renovate a hotel room. You do not fight for the plumbing in a place you are checking out of in the morning. Passing through is precisely the posture that makes injustice bearable, because it makes injustice temporary and beside the point.

And history bears this out in ways that ought to make us tremble. There is a long and shameful record of Christians using the hope of heaven to make peace with hell on earth. The clearest and most damning example is the way a certain kind of Christianity was preached to enslaved people in America. The gospel handed to them by their enslavers was very often precisely an escapist one. Bear your suffering now, obey your masters, and one day you will fly away to a better place where the chains fall off and the streets are gold. Heaven as compensation. Heaven as the reward for enduring an injustice you were told not to resist. The escapist gospel was, in that context, a tool of oppression, because a hope aimed entirely at the next world is a hope that leaves this world's arrangements exactly as they are. If your reward is elsewhere, then your oppressor can rest easy, because your religion has been enlisted to keep you patient in your chains.

But here is the thing that should stop every one of us, and it is the most important sentence in this chapter. The enslaved people themselves, so many of them, did not accept the escapist version. They reached past it to something older and truer, and it is written all over their spirituals, and we have misread those songs for a century. When they sang about crossing the Jordan and reaching the promised land, we heard escapism, souls flying off to heaven. But listen to

what they actually meant. The promised land was not only the sky. It was Canaan, a land, an earth, a place of justice and rest. Their hope was not merely to leave their bodies behind. It was for God to come down and put the world right, to break the chains in fact and not only in the sweet by and by. When they sang go down Moses, tell old Pharaoh to let my people go, they were not singing about disembodied souls escaping matter. They were singing about the God who acts in history to liberate real bodies from real bondage on real ground. They understood the resurrection hope better than the theologians who enslaved them, because they were the ones being crushed, and a crushed people cannot afford a hope that only kicks in after they are dead.

That is the great tell. Escapism is a hope you can afford only if you are comfortable. The comfortable can be content with a heaven that leaves the earth as it is, because the earth as it is treats them well. It is the crushed, the enslaved, the poor, the grieving, who need the world itself to be put right, who cannot survive on a hope that abandons the body and the ground and the arrangements of power. And so, strikingly, it is often the most oppressed Christians who have held the fullest biblical hope, and the most comfortable Christians who have shrunk it down to escape. The size of your hope tells you something about how much the present arrangement is costing you. I say that as a comfortable man who has too often preferred the smaller hope.

Now let me build the positive case, because it is not enough to expose the abuse. The resurrection does not merely permit justice. It fuels it. Here is the logic, and it is airtight once you see it. If God is going to renew the creation, if the new heaven and new earth are a place where righteousness dwells, if the New Jerusalem comes down and

God wipes away every tear and there is no more death or mourning or crying or pain, then the future God is bringing is a future of perfect justice. Every wrong righted. Every wound healed. Every oppressor answerable. Every victim vindicated. That is the world that is coming. And here is the point Paul makes explicitly in First Corinthians 15, in the very chapter on resurrection, the point that ties the whole thing together. Because your labor in the Lord is not in vain. Therefore, he says, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord. The therefore is everything. Because the dead are raised and the world is renewed, therefore your work matters, therefore it is not wasted, therefore you do not give up.

Do you see the machinery. Escapism says the world is going to be discarded, therefore your labor to make it more just is ultimately futile, chasing the wind, arranging furniture in a condemned building. Resurrection says the world is going to be raised, therefore your labor to make it more just is not futile at all, but is somehow taken up into what God is going to make permanent. N.T. Wright argues, and I find this persuasive and moving, that our works of justice and beauty and love in this life are not merely gestures that will be swept away, but are in some real sense built into God's new creation, that the cup of cold water and the act of mercy and the stand for the oppressed are not lost but preserved, carried through into the world that is coming. I do not know the mechanics of that, and I will not pretend to. But I know the direction of it, and the direction changes how you get up in the morning. If your justice work is doomed, you do it, if you do it at all, out of grim duty. If your justice work is being woven into the permanent future, you do it out of hope, because you are not fighting a losing battle, you are rehearsing the world that wins.

Let me be scrupulously fair to the other side here, because this territory gets seized by tribes and I will not hand it to one. There is a real danger, and conservative Christians are right to name it, of collapsing the gospel into a political program, of treating the kingdom of God as identical to some party's platform, of making justice the whole of Christianity and losing the cross and the resurrection and the forgiveness of sins in the process. That is a genuine error, and it has produced its own kind of hollowed-out faith, a Christianity with lots of activism and no worship, lots of causes and no Christ. I am not arguing for that, and I want to say so plainly, because the moment you argue for justice from the resurrection, someone will hear you baptizing their politics. I am not. The kingdom of God is not the platform of the left or the right, and any preacher who tells you it is has traded the cross for a flag, whichever flag.

But here is the discipline that keeps this honest, and I hold myself to it. The critique of injustice, if it is genuinely resurrection-shaped, cuts in every direction and flatters no tribe. The same hope that condemns the exploitation of the poor condemns the exploitation of the unborn. The same hope that will not let us ignore the prisoner will not let us ignore the elderly and the disabled whom a utilitarian culture finds inconvenient. The same hope that indicts the greed of the powerful indicts the envy and the malice that can hide inside the movements against them. Resurrection justice is not a partisan weapon, because the world it is bringing indicts all of us, and the moment your doctrine of justice only ever fires at the people you already disliked, it has stopped being the kingdom of God and become your tribe in a robe. I have caught myself doing exactly that, aiming the prophetic word only at the sins of the other side, and it is a betrayal of

the very resurrection I claim to preach.

So what does resurrection justice actually look like on a Tuesday. It looks like a man who visits the prison not because he thinks he can fix the whole broken system by Friday but because the prisoner bears the image of a God who is coming to set things right, and the visit is a rehearsal for that day. It looks like a church that feeds the hungry not as a warm-up to the real gospel of getting souls to heaven, but as an act of the gospel itself, a foretaste of the feast on the mountain where God wipes away tears and death is swallowed up. It looks like a Christian who fights for the vulnerable, all of them, without checking first whether it scores points for her team, because she is not serving a team, she is rehearsing a kingdom. And it looks like the refusal, the flat refusal, of the sentence it is all going to be sorted out in heaven anyway. No. God is going to sort it out on a renewed earth, and He has drafted us into the sorting, now, as a preview.

Here is the verdict. Escapism made justice optional because it made the world disposable, and a disposable world does not deserve the trouble of being put right. The resurrection makes justice essential because it makes the world redeemable, and a redeemable world is worth every ounce of the labor, because the labor is not swept away but taken up. This world is not a hotel I am passing through. It is my Father's house, and it has been vandalized, and He is coming to restore it, and He has handed me a broom and told me to start in my own room. That is not escapism. That is the family business. And the family business will one day include the hardest thing of all, the thing every one of us dreads and denies, which is the grave of someone we cannot live without. So let us go there next, honestly, without the lies, and see what the resurrection actually does for grief.

CHAPTER TEN

Grief in the Light of Resurrection

Do not let anyone dry your tears too fast. The God who is going to raise the dead wept first.

I HAVE STOOD BESIDE more open graves than I can number, and I have learned something that the escapist gospel never taught me and could not teach me, because it did not have the resources. I have learned that the deepest comfort and the fullest permission to grieve come from the same doctrine, and it is not the doctrine of the soul flying away. It is the doctrine of the body coming up. Escapism, when you actually take it to a graveside, does something cruel that it does not intend. It tells you not to cry.

Watch how it works, because it is subtle and it is everywhere. If the person you love was really a soul, and the

body in the box is just a shell, then your grief is, strictly speaking, a category error. You are weeping over packaging. The real person is fine, better than fine, released and happy in heaven, and your tears are a kind of misunderstanding, an overattachment to the discarded suit. And so the escapist funeral, with the best intentions in the world, is always subtly rushing you past your grief, telling you not to be sad because he is in a better place, treating your tears as a failure to grasp the good news. Do not cry, he is with Jesus. And the mourner, who knows in her bones that something real and terrible has happened, that a person, not a shell, has been torn out of the world, is left feeling that her grief is faithless, that a better Christian would be smiling. I have watched this happen. I have done this to people. I have handed a shaking widow a theology that told her the shaking was a sign of weak faith.

The resurrection does the opposite, and this is one of the most pastorally important things I know. The resurrection gives you permission to grieve with your whole body, because it agrees with your body that something real and terrible has happened. Death is not a graduation on the resurrection view. Death is an enemy, the last enemy, an obscenity, a violation of the good creation, a tearing in half of a human being who was never meant to be torn. When you weep at a grave, you are not making a category error. You are seeing clearly. You are agreeing with God, who hates death, who calls it an enemy, who is going to destroy it. Your tears are not a failure of faith. They are an act of truth-telling. They say, this should not be, and they are right, it should not be, and God says so too.

Look at Jesus at the tomb of Lazarus, because this is the whole gospel of grief in one scene. Jesus is about to raise Lazarus. He knows, in the next five minutes, that dead man is going to walk out of that tomb alive. If anyone ever had

grounds to skip the grief and go straight to the comfort, it was Jesus in that moment, standing on the certainty of resurrection with the miracle already loaded. And what does He do. Jesus wept. The shortest verse in the Bible and one of the most important. The Lord of life, holding the power of resurrection in His hands, seconds away from proving death is not final, stands at His friend's grave and weeps. He does not say, why are you crying, he will be up in a minute. He weeps. He lets the horror of death be horror even though He is about to undo it. And that tells you everything about how the resurrection wants you to grieve. Not less. Fully. With permission. The certainty of resurrection did not cancel the tears of Christ. It did not make the loss less real. It made it possible to weep and hope at the same time.

That phrase, weep and hope at the same time, is the whole thing, and Paul gives it to us in the clearest sentence about Christian grief in the New Testament. In First Thessalonians 4, he says he does not want them to grieve as those who have no hope. Now read that carefully, because almost everyone misreads it. Paul does not say, do not grieve. He says, do not grieve as those who have no hope. He assumes you will grieve. He commands only that your grief be a different kind of grief, not the grief of hopelessness but the grief of hope, not less painful but differently shaped, tears with a floor under them. The pagan grieves with no bottom, because for the pagan the loss is absolute and final. The Christian grieves just as hard, weeps just as much, but the tears fall onto a floor, and the floor is the resurrection. You do not stop crying. You cry standing on something.

Let me tell you why this is not a cheap comfort, because I am allergic to cheap comfort and so should you be. Cheap comfort says the loss is not real. It says you will feel better

soon, it says he is in a better place so cheer up, it says all the things that minimize the wound in order to make it stop bleeding faster. The resurrection does not minimize the wound. It insists the wound is exactly as deep as you feel it to be, that death really has done a terrible thing, that the person you lost really is gone from the world in a way that leaves a hole nothing else can fill. It refuses to shrink the loss. And then, having agreed that the loss is total, it makes a claim more audacious than any cheap comfort ever dared. It says the loss is not final. Not because it was not real, but because God is going to reverse it. The grave is not a full stop. It is a comma. The body in the ground is a seed, and the God who plants does not lose His seed, and there is a morning coming when that grave gives back what it took.

I want to speak directly to the person reading this who is in it right now, because I have been the pastor to enough of you to know you are here. Someone you cannot live without is gone. The bed is too big. The phone does not ring. You reach for them in your sleep and they are not there and you wake into the loss again every single morning. Hear me carefully. Your grief is not a lack of faith. Weep. Weep as long and as hard as your body needs to, because your body is telling the truth, a person has been torn out of the world and it is an atrocity and God agrees with you that it is an atrocity. Do not let anyone rush you off the grief in the name of heaven. The God you are grieving toward wept at a grave Himself, and He was about to raise the man.

And then, when you can bear it, and not before, let the second word come, the one under the tears. This is not the end of them. The Christ who rose is the firstfruits, and the firstfruits guarantee the harvest, and your beloved dead is not lost but planted, and there is a morning coming, a real

morning on a real remade earth, when the dead in Christ rise first and you see that face again, not as a ghost, not as a memory, but as a body, healed, whole, incapable of dying again, and you get to hold on and never let go. That is not a metaphor I am offering you to take the edge off. That is a promise anchored in an empty tomb outside Jerusalem, and if it is true, and I have staked my life that it is, then your grief, however bottomless it feels tonight, has a floor, and the floor is the resurrection of the dead.

I lost people before I believed any of this, and I grieved them as one who had no hope, and I know the difference in my own body. The pagan grief I once carried was a falling with no bottom, a loss that meant exactly nothing and led exactly nowhere, a wound the universe did not even notice. And the grief I carry now, when I bury someone I love, is not smaller. If anything it is larger, because I no longer tell myself the lie that they were only a shell. It is larger, and it has a floor. I fall, and I land on the resurrection, and I get up, and I keep grieving, and I keep hoping, and the two do not cancel. They hold hands. That is the only grief worth having, and it is the only grief the resurrection makes possible.

So the verdict of this chapter is a strange one, and I mean it as tenderly as I have ever meant anything. Grieve harder. Not less. The resurrection does not ask you to feel death less. It asks you to feel it fully and truthfully as the enemy it is, and then to know, underneath the full weight of it, that the enemy is already defeated, that the tomb is already empty, that the morning is already coming. Weep at the grave. And then, when you are ready, look east, because the sun that rose on one grave outside Jerusalem is going to rise on all of them. Which raises the question the escapist can never answer and the resurrection answers with a laugh. If we are not going to

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

float around in eternal disembodied rest, then what on earth are we going to do. Let us talk about the work of the world to come.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

What We Will Actually Do

*Heaven is not a retirement. It is a
coronation, and the crowned get to
reign.*

I HAVE TO DEAL with the boredom problem, because it is real and almost no one admits it. Somewhere deep down, a great many Christians find the standard picture of heaven quietly terrifying, and they feel guilty for finding it so, and so they never say it out loud. The picture is this. You die, and you go to heaven, and you spend eternity in a disembodied state, floating on clouds, playing a harp, singing in an endless church service that never lets out. And the honest human heart, if it is being truthful, looks at that picture and feels not longing but dread. An eternal church service. Forever. With no end and no body and nothing to do but sing. I have had

people confess this to me in hushed voices, ashamed, as if the problem were their lack of spirituality. The problem is not their spirituality. The problem is that the picture is a lie, and their hearts are right to recoil from it, because it is Plato's heaven with a church bulletin, and God never promised it to anyone.

Let me kill the boredom problem at the root. It comes entirely from the escapist error, from the disembodied, world-abandoning picture, because once you strip away the body and the earth and everything you could actually do, all that is left is a vague spiritual hovering, and of course that sounds boring, because a human being was never made to hover. We were made to work, to make, to build, to tend, to explore, to rule. Strip a human of all of that and you have not given him heaven, you have given him a sensory deprivation tank for eternity, and no wonder his heart sinks. The boredom problem is not a problem with the biblical hope. It is a symptom of how badly we have mangled the biblical hope.

Because the biblical picture of the world to come is not idleness. It is vocation. Go back to the beginning again, because the end always rhymes with the beginning. In the garden, before the fall, in the state of unbroken fellowship with God, what was the human being doing. Working. Keeping the garden. Naming the animals. Cultivating. The original paradise was not a hammock. It was a job, a good job, meaningful work in a good world under a good God, and it was not a curse but a blessing. The curse came later and made the work thorny and sweaty and frustrating, but the work itself was there before the curse, part of the original goodness. Which means the redemption of the world is not the abolition of work but its restoration, work with the thorns

removed, labor without the futility, making and building and tending in a world that finally cooperates instead of resisting.

Now look at how the New Testament describes our future, because it is drenched in the language of activity and rule. Jesus tells parables where the faithful servant is rewarded not with a permanent vacation but with more responsibility. Well done, good and faithful servant, you have been faithful over a little, I will set you over much. Enter into the joy of your master, yes, but the joy is bound up with being set over much, with greater stewardship, with expanded trust. In Revelation, the redeemed are told they will reign with Christ, that they will be a kingdom of priests, that they will rule. Reigning is not floating. Reigning is doing something. The picture is not of retired souls at rest but of restored image-bearers taking up again, at last, the vocation we were made for and botched, the calling to govern the creation under God, wisely and well and forever.

So what will we actually do. I have to be careful here, because the Bible gives us the direction and not the details, and I refuse to invent details to sound impressive. But I can reason from the direction, and the direction is unmistakable. We will work, but the work will not exhaust us or frustrate us. We will make things, because we are the images of a Maker and making is in our nature, and I cannot believe the God who filled us with the urge to create will strike it out of us in the world to come. I suspect there will be music being composed and not just sung, gardens being planted, things being built, questions being explored, because a renewed and unimaginably vast creation is not going to run out of things to discover in the first ten thousand years. The theologians talk about the beatific vision, the endless deepening of our knowledge and enjoyment of an infinite God, and that is

surely central, but I do not think it cancels activity, I think it fuels it, the way love for a person makes you want to do things and not just stare. We will worship, yes, but worship in the biblical sense was never only singing. It was a whole life offered, work and rest and making and ruling, all of it as worship.

Let me steelman the traditional picture, because I have been hard on it and it is not entirely wrong. When the old hymns and the old paintings put the emphasis on rest and worship and the presence of God, they were reaching for something true and precious. There is a rest that remains for the people of God, a Sabbath rest, and after the sweat and thorns of this cursed life the promise of rest is genuinely sweet, and I do not want to replace an eternity of idle bliss with an eternity of frantic activity, which would be its own kind of hell. And the worship is real. The center of the new creation is God Himself, the Lamb on the throne, and the deepest activity of the redeemed is the enjoyment and adoration of Him. The old picture was not wrong to put God at the center or rest in the frame. It was wrong only to subtract the world and the body and the work, to make the rest an idleness and the worship a permanent service with nothing else in the life. The traditional picture got the object of our joy right, God Himself, and got the shape of our existence wrong, disembodied and inert.

Here is why this matters for your Tuesday, because a doctrine of the world to come that does not touch this week is just decoration. If the work of the new creation is continuous with the good work of this creation, then your work now, the actual work you do, the teaching and the building and the farming and the parenting and the healing and the fixing, is not a meaningless way to pass the time until the real thing

starts in heaven. It is a rehearsal for the real thing. When you do your work well, honestly, with skill and love, you are practicing the vocation you will hold forever. When the farmer farms well, he is doing now, under the curse, what he will do gloriously without the curse. When the mother raises her children with patience, when the craftsman makes the joint fit true, when the nurse tends the body with tenderness, they are not marking time. They are apprenticing for a world where such work goes on without frustration and without end. Your work is not a distraction from eternity. It is a rough draft of it.

And this is the thing that finally answers the boredom problem for good. You are not afraid of eternity because eternity is too long. You are afraid of the wrong picture of eternity, the empty one, the hovering one, the harp on the cloud. But an eternity of good work in a good body on a good earth in the presence of a good God, an eternity of making and building and exploring and ruling and loving, an eternity in which the best days of your working life are not the peak but the faint foretaste, an eternity that gets richer and not thinner the longer it goes, because it is anchored in an infinite God who can never be exhausted, that is not something to dread. That is something to ache for. The problem was never that heaven was too long. The problem was that we made it too small.

So the verdict is this. We will not sit on clouds. We will reign on a renewed earth. We will not float in idle disembodied bliss. We will work the way we were always meant to work, without the thorns, under the King, forever. Heaven is not a retirement home for tired souls. It is the coronation of restored image-bearers, taking up at last the vocation we fumbled in the garden. And if that is true, then

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

the question everyone eventually asks, the question that the whole edifice can seem to stand or fall on, becomes unavoidable. What about the other side of judgment. What about the ones who are not there. What about hell. I have put it off long enough. Let us handle it, honestly, and without either the cruelty or the cowardice that usually attend it.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Hell and Judgment, Honestly

*A God who did not judge evil would not
be good. He would be indifferent, and
indifference is not love. It is the absence
of it.*

I HAVE PUT THIS chapter off, and I have done it on purpose, because I wanted you to feel the weight and the goodness of the resurrection hope before I asked you to look at its shadow. But I cannot write an honest book about the last things and skip the hardest one, the one that makes skeptics recoil and makes believers squirm and makes preachers either shout it cruelly or hide it entirely. Judgment. Hell. The possibility that the story does not end well for everyone. If I dodged it, you would rightly conclude I was selling you a comfort I had to censor to keep. So let me handle it the way I would want it

handled if I were the skeptic I used to be, honestly, without cruelty and without cowardice.

Start with why judgment cannot simply be deleted, because the modern instinct is to delete it, and I understand the instinct and I share it more than you might think. We want a God of pure acceptance who condemns no one, and a hell that is either empty or nonexistent, and I feel the pull of that wish in my own chest. But follow the wish out and see where it lands. A God who never judges is not a God of love. He is a God of indifference. Think about it in human terms. If you told me you loved your children and I discovered you were completely indifferent to whether they were abused, that you would never lift a finger against the man who harmed them, that you regarded the cruelty done to them with a serene neutrality, I would not conclude you were loving. I would conclude you did not love them at all, because love that is indifferent to the harm done to the beloved is not love. It is apathy wearing love's clothes. A God who looked at the trafficking of children, the torture of the innocent, the whole blood-soaked record of human cruelty, and felt no wrath, would not be good. He would be a moral monster of a different kind, complicit through sheer indifference.

The oppressed have always understood this better than the comfortable, which is the same pattern we saw with justice. It is easy for a well-fed Western academic to wish away the judgment of God, because he has rarely been on the receiving end of the evil that judgment answers. But go to the people who have been crushed, the survivors of genocide, the families of the murdered, the enslaved and the abused, and you will find that the wrath of God is not a doctrine they want deleted. It is a doctrine they cling to, because it means their

suffering is seen, that the universe is not morally blank, that the ones who did this will not simply get away with it forever. Miroslav Volf, a theologian who lived through the wars in the former Yugoslavia in the 1990s and watched his own people slaughtered, wrote that it was precisely in that context that he came to understand the necessity of divine wrath, that a God who did not judge such evil would be unworthy of worship. The doctrine of judgment is not the enemy of the victim. It is the victim's last hope that the accounts will finally be settled.

So judgment stays, because a world where evil is never answered is a world without justice, and the resurrection, remember, is God putting the world right, and you cannot put the world right without dealing with the wrong in it. The very same hope that comforts the grieving demands the judging of the guilty, because a renewed creation in which the unrepentant torturer sits down to eternal feast beside his unavenged victim as if nothing happened is not renewal. It is moral chaos crowned. The tears cannot be wiped away until the cause of the tears is dealt with. Judgment is not the opposite of the resurrection hope. It is part of it.

Now let me turn to hell itself, and here I have to be careful, and I have to be honest that faithful Christians disagree, and I have to tell you where I land and why, and where my own position has objections I cannot fully answer. This is second-order territory, the kind of question that divides faithful churches without dividing the faith, and I will treat it as such. There are, broadly, three views held by people who take the Bible seriously, and I am going to state each in its strongest form, the form its own best defenders would recognize, before I tell you anything about my own leaning.

The traditional view, held by the majority of the church

through most of its history, is that hell is conscious, and that the punishment of the finally unrepentant continues forever. Its defenders argue that this is the plain reading of Jesus own words, that He spoke of hell more than anyone in the New Testament, that He used the language of unquenchable fire and undying worm and outer darkness and eternal punishment, and that the gravity of sin against an infinite God warrants an infinite penalty. They argue that a hell that simply ends is a hell with no real weight, and that the seriousness with which Jesus warned about it makes sense only if the stakes are genuinely ultimate. This is a coherent and serious position and I will not caricature it.

The second view, called conditional immortality or annihilationism, held by a growing minority of serious evangelical scholars, argues that the finally unrepentant do not suffer forever but are finally destroyed, that the wages of sin is death and not eternal life in torment, that the language of destruction and perishing and the second death should be read as meaning what it says, an end. Its defenders argue that immortality is a gift given to the saved, not a possession everyone has by nature, and that only the Platonic assumption of the naturally immortal soul forces us to read destruction as unending conscious suffering rather than as actual destruction. It is a serious position, argued from the text, and it is not the liberal compromise it is sometimes dismissed as.

The third view, universal reconciliation, held by a minority through history and named as a hope even by some of the orthodox, argues that God's love will finally win every heart, that the fire of judgment is purifying rather than destroying, that eventually all will be reconciled and hell will empty. Its defenders point to the passages about God reconciling all

things and being all in all, and to the character of a love that does not give up. I regard this view as the weakest of the three on the text, because it seems to me to require overriding a great deal of what Jesus plainly said, but I will not pretend its defenders are unserious or unloving, because many of them hold it precisely out of a high view of God's love, and the impulse is holy even where I think the conclusion overreaches.

Now here is where I land, and I offer it as my leaning and not as a test of fellowship. I hold the reality of hell and judgment as non-negotiable, because Jesus taught it and the victims need it and love requires it. On the duration and nature, I lean toward taking the language of destruction seriously, and I find the annihilationist reading more textually honest than we have usually admitted, though I hold it with an open hand and I know the strongest objection to it, which is the small number of passages that do seem to speak of eternal conscious duration, and I cannot fully dissolve them. What I am certain of is this. Hell is real, it is terrible, it is the just answer of a good God to evil that will not repent, and no one who ends there will be able to say God was unjust. What I am not certain of, and what I refuse to pronounce on with a confidence the Bible does not give me, is exactly how long and in exactly what mode. A pastor who claims more precision than Scripture offers is not being faithful. He is being proud.

But let me say the pastoral thing, because doctrine that stays cold is doctrine that has failed. The point of the doctrine of hell is not to give you a weapon to consign your enemies to, and God help the preacher who has ever seemed to relish it, and God forgive me for the times I have preached it with more heat than tears. The point of the doctrine of hell is the terrible

seriousness of the human person. You are not a disposable soul. You are an eternal creature, and your choices matter with a weight that reaches past death, and the God who made you takes you seriously enough to let your no to Him be a real no with real consequences. Hell is, in a strange way, the dark side of your dignity. A creature whose choices meant nothing could not go to hell, but a creature whose choices meant nothing could not love either, and God wanted creatures who could love, which means creatures who could refuse, which means the possibility of a refusal that hardens into a final one. C.S. Lewis put it as memorably as anyone, in *The Great Divorce* in 1945, when he wrote that in the end there are only two kinds of people, those who say to God, Thy will be done, and those to whom God says, in the end, thy will be done. The door of hell, Lewis said, is locked on the inside.

And here is the note I want to end on, because it is the resurrection note and it changes even this. The judgment is real, but so is the cross. The whole reason there is a gospel at all is that God did not want the judgment to fall on us and so let it fall on Himself. The wrath that a good God must have against evil, the wrath the victims need and love requires, God poured out on His own Son at the cross, so that anyone, anyone, who turns to Him can be spared it. Judgment is real, and it is escapable, and it is escapable not by being good enough but by hiding in the crucified and risen Christ who already bore it. That is why the doctrine of hell in a Christian mouth should never sound like a threat delivered from a safe distance. It should sound like a warning shouted by someone who was on the same road and got pulled off it by grace. I am not standing outside the danger telling you about it. I was in it, an atheist heading nowhere good, and a nail-scarred hand reached in and pulled me out, and that is the only reason I

can tell you the danger is real, because I know both the danger and the rescue from the inside.

So the verdict is somber and it is honest. There is a judgment, because there is a God who is good and evil is real and love is not indifferent. There is a hell, in some form the Bible describes with terrible seriousness and does not fully map, and I will not pretend it away to make the book more comfortable, because I do not trust a hope that has to lie to survive. But standing between you and that judgment is a cross, and rising over it is an empty tomb, and the same resurrection that promises to raise your body promises to have already borne, in the body of Christ, everything the judgment could demand of you. Now let us come back into the light, because the resurrection is not only about how the story ends. It is about how you live tonight. So how does the resurrection of the body change the way you live now, today, before any of it has arrived. That is where we turn.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

How Resurrection People Live Now

*You cannot rehearse a play you do not
believe is being performed.*

*Resurrection is the rehearsal that
proves you believe the show is real.*

EVERYTHING I HAVE ARGUED for so far could still sit on a shelf as a fascinating correction to a doctrinal error, and if that is all it does, I have wasted your time and mine. Because the resurrection hope was never meant to be information. It was meant to be a way of living. The whole New Testament makes this move relentlessly. It states the hope, and then it says therefore, and the therefore is always about how you live on Tuesday. So let me gather the threads and ask the practical question the escapist can never quite answer. If the great hope is the resurrection of the body and the renewal of all

things, how does that change the way you get out of bed tomorrow.

Start with the deepest thing, the thing under all the others. Resurrection people live without the fundamental fear that governs most human lives, the fear of death. The writer of Hebrews says something staggering about what Christ accomplished, that He came to free those who through fear of death were all their lives held in slavery. Read that slowly. All their lives held in slavery, by the fear of death. That is a diagnosis of the human condition so accurate it takes your breath away. Almost everything we do, if you trace it down far enough, is a strategy against death. We accumulate money to insulate ourselves from it. We chase fame to outlast it. We cling to youth to deny it. We build and grasp and hoard and control, all of it, at bottom, a frantic management of the fact that we are going to die. The fear of death is the hidden engine of most human misbehavior, the root of the greed and the cowardice and the desperate self-protection that ruins so much.

And the resurrection cuts that engine at the root. If death is not the end, if death is a defeated enemy, if the worst thing that can happen to you has already been reversed in advance by an empty tomb, then the fear that enslaved you loses its grip. This is not theoretical. You can watch it in history. Why were the early Christians so impossible to intimidate. Why did the Roman Empire, which knew how to make people afraid, fail so completely to frighten these people into silence. Because you cannot control a person who is not afraid to die, and these people were not afraid to die, because they believed the tomb was empty and their own bodies were coming up. The martyrs went into the arena singing. That is not

fanaticism. That is resurrection, doing exactly what resurrection is supposed to do, unclenching the fist of fear that runs the human race. A person who has genuinely lost the fear of death is the freest person alive and the most dangerous to every tyranny, because there is no longer any lever to pull.

Now bring that down to your ordinary life, because you are probably not facing a Roman arena tomorrow. What does it look like when the fear of death loosens in a normal person on a normal week. It looks like generosity, because you are no longer hoarding against the end. If your treasure is a resurrection you cannot lose, you can hold your money and your time and your comfort with an open hand, because you are not depending on them to save you from oblivion. It looks like courage, because you can tell the truth and stand for the vulnerable and take the risk of love, since the thing you were protecting, your own survival, is already secured beyond death. It looks like freedom from the frantic self-curation of the age, the desperate building of a legacy, because you do not need to outlast death by being remembered when death itself has been defeated. Resurrection people can afford to be forgotten, because they are not counting on memory to grant them the immortality only God can give.

Let me get even more concrete, because I promised you the weight of everyday life and I mean to deliver it. The resurrection changes how you treat your own body, as I argued earlier, not as a rental car to be run into the ground but as a temple to be honored, destined for glory. It changes how you work, as I argued, not as time to be killed but as a vocation to be rehearsed, a rough draft of the work of the world to come. It changes how you grieve, weeping fully but on a floor. It changes how you regard the earth, tending it as a

seed rather than looting it as a wreck. It changes how you pursue justice, not as futile deck-scrubbing but as the family business of a God who is putting the world right. Every single one of these is the resurrection cashing out into a Tuesday. The doctrine is not abstract. It has hands and feet and it walks into your ordinary life and rearranges the furniture.

But let me name the trap, because there is a way to hold all this and still get it wrong, and I have fallen into it, so I know the shape of it. The trap is triumphalism, the resurrection turned into a denial of present suffering. There is a version of resurrection Christianity that is so eager to say death is defeated that it forgets death is still, for now, an active and terrible enemy. It waves away the cross in a hurry to get to Easter. It tells the suffering person to buck up because Christ has won, and in doing so it becomes as cruel as the escapism it replaced, just from the other direction. The escapist minimizes the loss by saying the body was a shell. The triumphalist minimizes the loss by saying the victory is already total. Both leave the grieving person feeling unmet. And the New Testament refuses both, because it holds the resurrection together with the cross, the already together with the not yet, the victory together with the ongoing war. Christ is risen, and death is still killing people, and both are true, and a resurrection faith that cannot hold both has curdled into a slogan.

So the resurrection life is lived in a particular tension, and I want to name it precisely, because getting the tension right is the whole art of Christian living. We live in the time between the decisive victory and the final one. The kingdom has come in Christ and the kingdom has not yet come in full. The tomb is empty and the graves are still full. Death is defeated and death still stalks the earth. This is the already

and the not yet, and it deserves its own chapter, which it will get. But for now, the practical upshot is this. Resurrection people are neither escapists who abandon this world as doomed, nor triumphalists who pretend it is already fixed. They are people who work in the world with hope and grieve in the world with honesty, who plant trees they may not sit under and fight battles they may not win and love people they will lose, all of it in the confident expectation that none of it is wasted, because the God who raised Jesus is going to raise all of it, and the labor and the tears and the love will be found again on the far side, purified and permanent.

I think of the early Christians in Rome during the plagues, and this is not legend, it is documented, that when the epidemics swept the city and the pagans fled, leaving their own sick relatives to die alone in the streets, the Christians stayed. They stayed and nursed the dying, their own and the strangers, and many of them caught the disease and died doing it. The sociologist Rodney Stark, in his 1996 study *The Rise of Christianity*, argued that this behavior was a major reason the faith spread, because people watched these Christians face plague without the terror that gripped everyone else, and they wanted to know what these people had that took the fear away. What they had was resurrection. They could nurse the dying without being enslaved by the fear of death, because they believed death was not the end, and so they were free to spend their lives in love in a way the fearful could not afford. That is resurrection living, and it changed the world not by argument but by a courage the world could not explain.

So the verdict of this chapter is a challenge and I aim it at myself first. If you actually believed the resurrection, really believed it down in the place where the fear of death lives, you

would live differently, and the difference would be visible. You would be more generous, because you would not be hoarding against oblivion. You would be more courageous, because your survival is already secured. You would grieve more honestly and hope more stubbornly and work more freely and love more recklessly, because the worst thing has already been undone and the best thing is already guaranteed. And if none of that is true of you, if you hold the doctrine and live like a person still enslaved to the fear of death, then whatever you believe, you do not yet believe the resurrection, not where it counts. I say that as a man who checks his own life against it and finds it wanting more often than not. The test of whether you believe the resurrection is not whether you can recite it. It is whether you have stopped being afraid to die. And that brings us, unavoidably, to your own death, the one you are not facing today but will face, the one nobody escapes, the one the resurrection was built to answer.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Facing Your Own Death

*You are going to die. The resurrection
does not make that untrue. It makes it
not the end of your sentence, only the
comma.*

I NEED TO WRITE this chapter as if I were sitting across from you, because this is the one that stops being about doctrine and becomes about you, personally, the reader holding this book. You are going to die. I do not know when, and neither do you, but the number of your days is finite and it is counting down, and no amount of theology changes that fact. The resurrection is not a denial of your death. It is the only honest answer to it. And I want to talk to you about facing it, not the death of others, which we have covered, but yours, the one you carry around in the back of your mind and mostly refuse to look at.

Let me start by admitting the terror is legitimate. Our age

has developed an elaborate machinery for not thinking about death, and I understand it, and I participate in it. We hide the dying in institutions. We use soft language, passed away, lost, gone, anything but died. We keep the old and the sick out of sight. We fill every silent moment with a screen so we never have to sit alone with the fact of our own ending. Ernest Becker, in his 1973 book *The Denial of Death*, argued that this evasion is the hidden organizing principle of human culture, that nearly all our striving is a project to avoid facing our own mortality. He was not a Christian, and he was largely right, and the accuracy of his diagnosis is itself a kind of judgment on us. We have built a civilization dedicated to pretending we will not die, and the pretense is so thin that a single honest funeral can tear right through it.

The escapist gospel, I have to say, colludes with the denial. This is one of its subtler evils. By telling you that the real you is a soul and death is just the shedding of a shell, escapism lets you avoid the full horror of death, because on that account death is not really death at all, just a transition, a doorway, hardly worth the dread. And that sounds like a comfort until you are actually dying, and then it rings hollow, because your body knows better. Your body knows that death is real, that it is coming for the whole of you, that the tearing apart is an atrocity and not a graduation. The escapist comfort works right up until the moment you need it most, and then it fails, because it was built on a denial of the very thing you are now staring at.

The resurrection does something braver. It does not let you deny your death. It makes you look right at it, in all its horror, and it agrees with you that it is horror, and then it makes a promise on the far side of the horror rather than a denial on the near side of it. Paul does not say death is not

real. He calls it the last enemy. He does not say do not fear death because it is a mere transition. He says death is defeated, swallowed up in victory, its sting drawn out. There is a world of difference between denying the enemy and defeating him. Escapism denies the enemy is real. Resurrection admits the enemy is real and terrible and then announces he has been beaten. And only the second one can actually hold you when you are the one lying in the bed with the machines and the failing breath, because only the second one is telling you the truth.

So how do you face your own death as a resurrection person. Let me try to give you something you can actually carry into that room, because I have sat by too many beds not to know that this is where the theology has to become bread. First, you get to be honest. You do not have to pretend you are not afraid, and you do not have to perform a serene faith you do not feel, because even Jesus, in the garden of Gethsemane, faced His own death with sweat like drops of blood and a prayer that the cup might pass. The Lord Himself did not face death with breezy calm. He faced it with agony and honesty and a wrenching desire to avoid it, and then trust underneath the agony, not instead of it. If the sinless Son of God could tremble before death and still trust the Father, then you are allowed to tremble too. The resurrection does not require you to feel no fear. It gives you something to trust underneath the fear.

Second, you get to grieve your own dying, and this is something almost no one gives people permission to do. When you are dying, you are losing things, real things, the faces you love, the mornings, the ordinary pleasures, the unfinished work, and it is right to grieve them, because they are good and you are losing them for now. Do not let anyone,

including a well-meaning Christian, tell you not to be sad about leaving a world you love. The world is good. It is right to love it and right to mourn leaving it. The resurrection does not ask you to stop loving the world in order to die well. It asks you to trust that the world you love is not being taken from you forever but only for a while, that you will have it back, healed, on the other side. You grieve the losing, and you grieve it as one who has hope, the same weep-and-hope that governs all Christian grief, now turned toward your own life.

Third, and this is the heart of it, you get to entrust yourself to a God who has been through death ahead of you and come out the other side. This is what the incarnation and the resurrection together give you that no philosophy can. When you walk into death, you are not walking into a country no one has returned from. You are following a man who went in ahead of you, all the way in, dead and buried, and came out, and He has promised to come and get you. Jesus said, I am the resurrection and the life, whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live. He said it to a grieving woman at her brother's tomb, and He said it as a man who was about to die Himself and rise Himself, so that the promise was not a theory He held but a road He walked. You die into the hands of someone who has done this before you and will not let go. That is the difference between the Christian death and every other. You are not stepping off a cliff into darkness. You are stepping into the arms of the one who conquered the darkness from the inside.

I want to tell you about the deaths I have witnessed, because I have been given the sacred and terrible privilege of being in the room. I have seen people die badly, in fear and denial, clinging and terrified, and I have seen people die well, and the difference is not temperament and it is not lack of

pain. I have watched people in real physical agony die with a peace that had nothing to do with the absence of suffering. I sat with a woman in my church, dying of cancer, who had every reason to rage against the dying of the light, and instead, near the end, she said to me, almost with a kind of impatience, why is everyone so worried, I am just going home ahead of you. And I remember thinking that she had it exactly right, more right than the escapist version, because she did not mean she was floating off to be a disembodied soul forever. She meant she was going ahead, to be with Christ, to wait for the morning, on the front porch, and that we would all be along, and that the body they were about to bury was a seed and not a shell. She died like a woman who believed the tomb was empty. And it was one of the most powerful sermons I have ever received, preached from a hospice bed by a woman with no strength left to preach.

So here is what I want to leave you with about your own death, and I mean it as the most practical thing in this book, because it is the one appointment you will certainly keep. You are going to die, and the resurrection does not spare you that, but it changes the meaning of it entirely. Your death is not the end of your story. It is a comma, not a period. It is the moment you step ahead of the ones you love, into the presence of Christ, to wait for the morning when your body comes up out of the ground, healed and whole and incapable of dying again. You do not have to deny your death to face it well. You have to look at it honestly, grieve it truly, and then entrust yourself to the one who died ahead of you and rose and is waiting to catch you. Die into His hands. He has done this before. He will not drop you.

And that peace in the face of death is only possible because of a strange and crucial truth that I have been

circling this whole book and now have to face directly. We live between two moments, the resurrection that has already happened and the one that has not yet. We live in the already and the not yet, and getting that tension right is the difference between despair and presumption, between the escapist who gives up on this world and the triumphalist who pretends it is already fixed. So let us finally look, head on, at the strange in-between time we are actually living in.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Already and the Not Yet

*We are living in the middle of the story,
and the middle is the hardest place to
keep your nerve.*

THERE IS A PHRASE theologians use that sounds like jargon but is actually one of the most pastorally useful ideas in all of Scripture, and I want to hand it to you as a working tool, because it explains almost every frustration and every hope of the Christian life. The already and the not yet. The kingdom of God has already come, decisively, in the person and resurrection of Jesus, and the kingdom of God has not yet come in its fullness, and we are living in the overlap, in the strange middle time between the two, and almost every confusion in the Christian life comes from collapsing the tension in one direction or the other.

Let me picture it for you with an image that the scholar Oscar Cullmann made famous in the years after the Second World War, because he had lived through exactly the reality it describes. Think of a war with a decisive battle and a final surrender. There is a day when the decisive battle is won, the day the outcome of the whole war is settled beyond reversal, when everyone who understands the situation knows the enemy has lost. And then there is a later day, sometimes much later, when the surrender is signed and the fighting actually stops and the victory is complete. Between those two days there is a strange interval. The war is, in the deepest sense, already won, its outcome no longer in doubt. And yet the war is not yet over, and people are still fighting and still dying, sometimes in the bloodiest battles of the whole conflict, in the interval between the decisive day and the final one. Cullmann said the resurrection of Jesus was the decisive day, the battle that settled the outcome of the whole war against death and evil, and that we now live in the interval, in the time between the victory that is certain and the surrender that is not yet signed. The decisive day has come. The final day has not. We live in between.

This single idea dissolves the two great errors I have been circling all book. The escapist error is to give up on this world as if the decisive day had not happened, to treat the world as still under the unbroken reign of death and decay, to conclude that nothing here can be redeemed and the only option is to wait for evacuation. That is a failure to grasp the already. The decisive battle has been won. The world is not a doomed ship, because its liberation has already begun in the risen body of Christ, and to write it off is to deny the victory that has already occurred. The escapist is like a soldier who does not know the decisive battle was won and keeps living in

despair as if the enemy still controls the outcome.

The triumphalist error is the opposite, and it is just as common, and it is the failure to grasp the not yet. The triumphalist acts as if the surrender were already signed, as if the fighting were over, as if suffering and death and injustice were already abolished and anyone still experiencing them must be doing something wrong. This is the prosperity preacher telling the sick they are sick because their faith is weak. This is the shallow Christianity that cannot make room for grief because it thinks the victory is supposed to feel total already. And it is cruel, because it lands on suffering people with the accusation that their suffering is a failure of faith rather than the ordinary condition of living in the interval where the war, though won, is not yet over. The triumphalist is like a soldier who thinks the war is finished and cannot understand why his comrades are still dying, and so concludes they must be cowards.

The truth is the harder middle, and it is where the whole New Testament lives. Yes, and not yet. Christ is risen, and you still get cancer. Death is defeated, and your mother still died. The kingdom has come, and the world is still full of injustice and grief and the ordinary erosion of everything you love. Both are true at once, and the Christian life is the art of holding both without letting go of either. When you are tempted to despair, when the world looks so broken that redemption seems like a fantasy, you reach for the already. The decisive battle has been won. The tomb is empty. The outcome is not in doubt. And when you are tempted to a shallow triumphalism, when you want to pretend the suffering is not real or the grief is a failure, you reach for the not yet. The surrender is not signed. We are still in the interval. The fighting is real and the dying is real and it is

right to grieve it. You need both hands, one on the already and one on the not yet, and if you let go of either you fall.

Let me show you how this works in a real life, because abstractions do not comfort anyone. Suppose you are a parent, and your child is sick, gravely sick. The escapist in you says, this world is broken and full of suffering, all we can do is pray them into heaven and wait for the world where there is no more sickness. And that is a failure of the already, because it gives up on the healing God can and does still do in the interval, and it treats the child's body as a lost cause. The triumphalist in you says, God has already won, I will claim the healing, and if I have enough faith the child will certainly be well, and if the child is not well it is because my faith failed. And that is a failure of the not yet, and it is monstrous, because it will crush you with guilt if the child dies, as if their death were your spiritual failure rather than the ordinary tragedy of the interval. The truth in the middle is harder and kinder. You pray for healing with real hope, because the decisive battle has been won and God still heals in the interval and it is right to ask. And you hold that hope with an open hand, because the surrender is not yet signed and death still operates in the interval, and if the child is not healed it is not because your faith failed but because we are still in the time between the victory and its consummation. And either way, whether the child is healed now or raised later, death does not get the final word, because the decisive day has already happened and the final day is certainly coming.

Do you see how much freedom that gives you, and how much honesty. You do not have to pretend the world is fine. You do not have to give up on the world either. You get to work and pray and hope for real change in the interval, real healing, real justice, real redemption breaking in, because

the kingdom has genuinely come and its power is genuinely at work. And when the change does not come, when the healing does not happen and the injustice does not yield and the death still falls, you do not collapse into despair or into self-accusation, because you know you are living in the not yet, in the interval where the war is won but not over, and the final victory is coming whether or not you see it today.

This is why the New Testament is so relentlessly hopeful and so utterly honest about suffering at the same time, and why that combination is so rare and so precious. Paul, who suffered as much as any man, beaten, shipwrecked, imprisoned, is the same Paul who wrote the most soaring hope in all of literature. He does not choose between the suffering and the hope. He holds both, in the same breath, in the same sentence sometimes. We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed. Perplexed, but not driven to despair. Persecuted, but not forsaken. Struck down, but not destroyed. That is the grammar of the interval. Afflicted, but. Perplexed, but. Struck down, but. The suffering is real, named honestly, not minimized. And then the but, and the but is the already, the decisive victory that means the affliction does not get the last word. Afflicted, but not crushed. That single but is the whole Christian life, the hinge between the honesty and the hope, and it only makes sense if you understand that we are living in the interval between the resurrection that has happened and the one that has not yet.

I have to confess how badly I hold this tension, because I swing between the two errors constantly, and I suspect you do too. On my dark days I am an escapist, giving up on the world, longing to be out of it, treating the brokenness as final. On my shallow days I am a triumphalist, papering over the grief, impatient with suffering, wanting the victory to feel more

total than the interval allows. The mature Christian life is the slow, hard-won ability to stay in the middle, to keep both hands gripped, to be honest about the not yet without letting go of the already, and I am not there yet, and I doubt I will fully arrive on this side of the resurrection. But naming the tension helps, because at least I know which error I am falling into on any given day, and I can reach for the hand I have let go of.

So here is the verdict. We live in the interval, in the strange and difficult middle of the story, between the decisive victory and the final one, and this is the hardest place to keep your nerve, because you can see the enemy is beaten and you can also see the enemy is still killing people, and both are true, and the temptation is always to resolve the tension by denying one of them. Do not resolve it. Live in it. Keep one hand on the empty tomb and one hand on the graves that are still full, and hold on, because the interval will not last forever. The surrender is coming. The final day is coming. The already is going to swallow up the not yet, and every tear the interval has cost you is going to be wiped away by a hand you can feel. But before we get to that final day, I have to circle back to the older way of speaking that this whole book has been gently correcting, because I do not want to leave you thinking I have simply thrown out the going-to-heaven language your grandmother loved. I have not. I want to show you where it belongs, honored and preserved, inside the larger hope. Let me be fair to the tradition I have been correcting.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

In Defense of Your Grandmother's Hymns

*I am not here to take your
grandmother's hymns away. I am here
to tell you they were pointing at
something bigger than they knew.*

I HAVE SPENT FIFTEEN chapters correcting a picture, and I would be a coward and a poor pastor if I did not now turn around and honor what was true and precious in the very thing I have been correcting, because there is a way to be right about doctrine and wrong about people, and I have watched theological correctness curdle into contempt too many times to want any part of it. So let me be fair to the tradition. Let me defend your grandmother's hymns, and the pastor who told you your loved one was in a better place, and the whole warm inherited world of the going-to-heaven

gospel, because it held onto something the resurrection recovery must never lose.

Start with what the old way got right, and it got a great deal right. When your grandmother sang about heaven, about the sweet by and by, about meeting again on that beautiful shore, she was holding onto truths that are absolutely non-negotiable and that I have affirmed all through this book. She was holding onto the reality that death is not the end. She was holding onto the certainty that the dead in Christ are safe, that they are with the Lord, that they are beyond the reach of suffering. She was holding onto the promise of reunion, that she would see her people again, that the goodbyes of this life are not final. She was holding onto the presence of God as the center of the hope, that whatever else heaven is, it is being with Him. Every one of those is true. Every one of those I have affirmed. The old way was not wrong about these things. It was, if anything, more confident about them than much of the modern church, which has grown embarrassed about the afterlife altogether.

And here is something I have to say plainly, because I could be misheard as arrogant otherwise. Your grandmother, singing *I Will Fly Away* at her husband's funeral, may have had a truer and deeper faith than the theologian who could correct her hymn. The theology in the hymn was imprecise. The faith underneath it may have been diamond. She may have known God, really known Him, trusted Him, loved Him, and been held by Him in her grief, in a way that no amount of doctrinal precision can manufacture. I have met people with perfect eschatology and thin faith, and I have met people with muddled eschatology and a faith that could move mountains, and if I had to choose which to have, I would take the second

every time. The point of correcting the doctrine is never to look down on the saints who held it imperfectly. It is to give their real faith a bigger and truer object, so that the diamond has an even better setting.

So let me show you where the old language belongs, because it does belong, and the mistake was never in what it affirmed but in what it left out. When the old hymn says the soul flies away to be with Jesus, it is describing, imperfectly, the intermediate state, and the intermediate state is real. The dead in Christ really do go to be with Him. So the hymn is not false. It is incomplete. It describes the front porch beautifully and forgets to mention the house. The correction is not to tear down the porch. It is to add the house. Yes, your loved one flew away to be with Jesus, and that is true and precious, and now let me tell you what comes after that, the part the hymn did not sing, the morning when the body comes up out of the ground and God makes all things new. The old language is not a rival to the resurrection. It is the first verse of a song that has more verses, and the tragedy was only that we stopped singing after the first verse and forgot there were more.

I want to steelman the traditional going-to-heaven framework as strongly as I can, because I have been hard on it and honesty demands I give it its best case. Its defenders could say, and rightly, that the going-to-heaven language has comforted the dying and the grieving for two thousand years, that it has held the hand of the widow and the orphan and the terminally ill and given them peace at the moment they most needed it, that it has kept before the church the crucial truth that our ultimate hope is not in this world but in God, and that it has resisted the constant temptation to reduce Christianity to a this-worldly program of self-improvement or social reform. All of that is true and all of that is valuable, and a

recovery of the resurrection that lost any of it would be a bad trade, swapping one imbalance for another. The going-to-heaven language kept the church's eyes lifted above the merely earthly, and in an age that constantly tries to shrink Christianity down to therapy or politics, that upward pull is a gift, not merely an error.

Here is the balance I am trying to strike, and it is a delicate one. The going-to-heaven language erred by making the intermediate state the whole hope and forgetting the resurrection, by pointing so exclusively upward that it lost the promise of a renewed earth and a raised body, by letting the porch swallow the house. That error had real costs, the disposable earth and the disposable body and the optional justice I have spent chapters tracing. Those costs are real and worth correcting. But the correction must not overshoot into the opposite error, into a this-worldly Christianity so focused on the renewed earth that it loses the transcendent God at the center, so busy with justice and creation care that it forgets the intermediate comfort of the dying, so eager to affirm the body that it becomes embarrassed about the soul. The recovery of the resurrection is not a swing from heaven to earth. It is the recovery of the whole biblical hope, which includes both, the soul with Christ now and the body raised later, the comfort of the front porch and the glory of the house, the transcendent God who is above and the incarnate God who comes down.

I think of my own grandmother, the one whose casket I stood beside as an unbelieving young man, furious in a way I could not name. She was not a theologian. She sang the old hymns. She would have told you, if you had asked, that she was going to heaven when she died, and she would have pictured something like the clouds and the harps. And I have

come to believe that her simple faith was reaching, through the imperfect words she had been given, toward exactly the thing this book is about. She loved that farm. She loved those hands, her own calloused hands that made the pie and held mine. She would not, if she had understood it, have wanted a heaven that left all of that behind as so much shell. She would have wanted the resurrection, the real thing, the renewed earth and the raised body and the reunion that is not a reunion of ghosts but of embodied people on solid ground. She wanted the bigger hope. She just did not have the words for it, because the church had let the words grow small. And I like to think that when I finally see her again, on the morning I have been describing, she will not be a wisp in the clouds but my grandmother, in a body, with those hands, on ground that does not die, and that she will be delighted to discover that the hope was even bigger than the hymns she sang.

So I will not take your grandmother's hymns away from you, and I will not let anyone else take them either, not in the name of theological precision or anything else. Sing them. Sing them at the funerals. But sing them knowing what they are, first verses of a longer song, true as far as they go, pointing beyond themselves to a hope even bigger than they knew how to name. And when you get to the last funeral, when it is your turn in the box, I hope someone sings the old hymn over you, and I hope someone also stands up and finishes the song, and says, yes, she has flown away to be with Jesus, and that is true, and there is more, because one day her body is coming up out of this ground, and God is going to make all things new, and this grave we are standing at is not a full stop but a comma. The old hymns were never the problem. Stopping after the first verse was the problem. Let us sing the whole song. And the whole song ends where the

Bible ends, on the last day, with a city coming down and a voice from the throne, and that is where this book has been walking all along, so let us finally go and stand at the end of the story and look at what God has promised to do.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Day the Sea Gives Up Its Dead

*On that day, every grave in every field
will be a scandal to death, because
death will have to give back everything
it took.*

I WANT TO TAKE you to the end now, to the last day, the day the whole story has been walking toward, and I want to do it not as an argument but as something closer to a vision, because there are things the Bible describes that are meant to be seen more than analyzed, and the end of all things is one of them. Let me try to show you the day, drawing only on what Scripture actually says, refusing to invent details, but letting the promises stand up in front of you at their full height.

There is a phrase in Revelation 20 that has haunted me for years, and I want you to feel the weight of it. And the sea gave

up the dead that were in it. Think about what that image is doing. The sea, in the ancient imagination and all through the Bible, is the place of chaos, the swallower, the taker, the grave that gives nothing back. When a body was lost at sea it was lost utterly, beyond recovery, beyond even the dignity of a grave. And the promise of the last day is that even the sea, even the most final and hopeless place of loss, will be forced to give up what it took. The sea gave up its dead. Death will not be allowed to keep a single thing. Every grave in every field, every body lost at sea, every soldier in an unmarked pit, every child in an unmarked grave, every ash scattered on the wind, all of it, God will reclaim, because the resurrection is not selective and death is not permitted to keep its plunder. That is the scandal of the last day, from death's point of view. Death, which has been the great winner of all of history, the undefeated champion, the one thing every human being finally lost to, is going to be made to open its hands and give everything back.

Paul describes the moment in First Corinthians 15, and he can barely contain himself, and I do not blame him. Behold, he says, I tell you a mystery. We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. And then, when the perishable puts on the imperishable and the mortal puts on immortality, then, he says, then shall come to pass the saying that is written, death is swallowed up in victory. And he cannot help himself, he turns and taunts the defeated enemy directly. O death, where is your victory. O death, where is your sting. The great enemy, the last enemy, the one that has terrorized every human life, is finally so thoroughly beaten that Paul mocks it to its face. Where is your

sting now. And the answer is that death has no sting, because the thing that gave death its sting, the finality of it, has been broken by a body that got up out of a tomb and guaranteed that all the other bodies would follow.

Picture it. The trumpet sounds. And across the whole earth, in every cemetery and every battlefield and every place a body was ever laid, the ground begins to give up its dead. Not ghosts rising. Bodies. The graves opening not to release souls but to return the whole persons, raised, transformed, imperishable, radiant, incapable of dying again. Walter comes up out of the ground outside Fenton, calloused hands and all, and the ground he loved and farmed gives him back. Your mother, your father, your child, the ones you buried with your own hands and thought you had lost forever, the ground gives them back, not as memories, not as spirits, but as people you can hold. And the reunion is not a reunion of wisps in the clouds. It is embodied. It is arms around necks and faces you can touch and voices you can hear and the whole aching absence of years filled up in an instant, because the dead in Christ have come up out of the ground and death has been made to give them back.

And it does not stop with the dead, because the same power that raises the bodies renews the earth. Revelation 21 puts the two together, the resurrection and the new creation, and shows us the outcome. The New Jerusalem comes down out of heaven, God moves in with His people, and the voice from the throne says the words this book takes its name from. Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. And then the promise that undoes every grief this book has touched. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall

there be mourning nor crying nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away. Read it slowly, because every clause is a specific enemy destroyed. Death, no more. Mourning, no more. Crying, no more. Pain, no more. Not managed. Not compensated for. Gone. The former things have passed away, not the created things, but the fallen things, the death and the mourning and the pain, burned out of creation like dross out of gold, and what is left is the good world God made, healed, with God Himself dwelling in it, wiping tears from faces with His own hand.

I want to sit on that image of the hand, because it is the tenderest thing in the whole Bible and it is the answer to everything. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes. Not a decree issued from a distant throne. A hand, on a face, wiping a tear. God so present, so near, so intimately with His people on the renewed earth, that He personally attends to each grief, each individual tear, wiping it away with the tenderness of a father with a weeping child. This is not the disembodied heaven of the clouds, where God is a distant light and we are dissolved spirits. This is God with us, embodied presence with embodied people, close enough to touch, close enough to wipe a tear from a cheek. That is the end of the story. Not our escape up to a distant God, but a near God, come down, dwelling with His people, drying their faces with His own hand.

Let me be honest about what I am doing and not doing here. I am not claiming to know the details, the mechanics, the timeline, the geography of the new creation. The Bible speaks of these things in the language of vision and symbol, and anyone who turns Revelation into a literal blueprint or a coded newspaper is abusing it. I do not know exactly what the resurrection body will be like beyond that it will be physical

and glorious and incapable of dying. I do not know exactly what the new earth will look like beyond that it will be this creation renewed and God will dwell in it. I refuse to invent what Scripture does not give. But I know the direction, and the direction is unmistakable and it is everything. The direction is down and toward, not up and away. The direction is embodied, not disembodied. The direction is renewal, not escape. The direction is God coming to dwell with us on a healed earth, not us floating off to a distant heaven. And that direction changes everything about how you live and grieve and work and die, which has been the argument of this entire book.

So here is the verdict of the vision, and it is the verdict of the whole story. On the last day, death does not win and does not even survive. It is not accommodated, not befriended, not reinterpreted as a doorway. It is destroyed, and forced to give back everything it took, and then it is gone forever, and mourning and crying and pain go with it. And what is left is not less than this world but more, this world healed, this world with God dwelling in it, this world where the graves have given up their dead and the sea has given up its dead and every tear has been wiped away by a hand you can feel. That is the reward. Not a disembodied heaven. A resurrection, on a renewed earth, in the presence of God. That is what the church traded away for an escape, and that is what I have spent this whole book trying to hand back to you. There remains only to gather it all up, to say plainly what it means for the living of your one wild and finite life, and to leave you, as every honest ending should, not with everything resolved but with something to carry. So let me try to say the last thing.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Ascension and the Absent King

*He did not leave to abandon the world.
He left to be crowned over it, and a
crowned King comes back.*

THERE IS AN EVENT in the Christian story that we mostly skip, and skipping it has done more damage to our hope than we realize. The ascension. Forty days after the resurrection, the New Testament tells us, Jesus was taken up, and a cloud received Him out of the disciples sight, and He went to be at the right hand of the Father. We rush past it, treating it as a kind of stage exit, the tidy way of getting the risen Jesus offstage so the church age can begin. But the ascension is not a stage exit, and reading it as one is exactly the escapist mistake in miniature. The ascension is a coronation, and everything about our hope depends on getting that right.

Watch what the escapist instinct does with the ascension. It reads the cloud that received Jesus as the moment He left the material world behind, shed the earthly, and returned to the pure spiritual realm where He belonged all along. On this reading the ascension is the un-incarnation, the reversal of Christmas, God finally getting out of the body and back to being properly spiritual. And if that is what the ascension is, then it is the divine endorsement of escapism, the pattern for our own hope, the soul leaving the body and the earth behind to return to the spiritual realm above. But that is precisely not what the ascension is, and the whole New Testament screams against the reading.

Because the Jesus who ascended did not leave His body behind. This is the thing to hold onto with both hands. He ascended as a man, in a body, the same scarred, physical, fish-eating body that walked out of the tomb. The incarnation did not end at the ascension. It was made permanent. There is, right now, at this moment, a human being at the center of all reality, a man with a body and hands and a face and scars, seated at the right hand of the Father. God did not un-become flesh. He took flesh into the very throne room of the universe and kept it there. And that single fact demolishes escapism at its root, because it means the material, the physical, the embodied, is not something even God is trying to escape. He carried it up with Him. He enthroned it. The body is so far from being a prison to be shed that a human body now sits on the throne of heaven.

And the cloud. That cloud that received Him is not a weather system and it is not the boundary of the material world. All through the Bible, the cloud is the sign of the presence and glory of God, the cloud on Sinai, the cloud in the tabernacle, the cloud on the mountain of transfiguration.

When the cloud receives Jesus, it is not carrying Him away to a distant location. It is enclosing Him in the glory of God, hiding Him not in a far-off place but in the very presence of the Father, which is not somewhere else so much as somewhere deeper, the dimension of reality where God dwells, interlocking with our own at every point. Jesus did not travel to a heaven located up past the clouds. He passed into the presence of God, which is nearer than our own breath and yet veiled from us for now. The ascension is not a departure to a distant place. It is a hiding in glory, close and unseen, until the day the veil is drawn back.

Why does this matter for how you live tonight. Because the ascension means the King is not absent in the way we feel He is absent. We feel like the world is running without its rightful ruler, chaos unopposed, the throne empty, and that feeling is the engine of a great deal of despair. But the New Testament insists the throne is not empty. Jesus is not waiting in the wings to become King someday. He was crowned at the ascension. He is reigning now, at the right hand of the Father, and the reason we do not see His reign is not that it has not begun but that it is veiled, hidden in the cloud of glory, waiting to be revealed. We live under the reign of a King we cannot yet see, and the not-yet-seeing is the hardest part of the interval, but the reign is real. The world is not running without a ruler. It is running under a ruler whose crown is hidden and whose return is certain.

And that is the other half of the ascension, the half the angels made sure the disciples did not miss. As the disciples stood staring up into the sky where Jesus had gone, two men in white stood by them and said, why do you stand looking into heaven. This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go. Do not

miss what the angels are doing. The disciples are doing the escapist thing, staring up into the sky, as if the point were now to gaze upward toward the heaven where Jesus went, as if our hope were up there where He disappeared. And the angels correct them, almost sharply. Stop staring up. He is not staying up there and neither is your hope. He will come back, in the same way you saw Him go, which is to say bodily, visibly, to the earth. The direction of the hope is not up where He went. It is here, where He is coming back to. The ascension is not the end of the story pointing us skyward. It is the guarantee of the return pointing us to the renewed earth.

So the Christian does not live staring up into heaven waiting to go there. The Christian lives on the earth waiting for the King to come back to it. That is a completely different posture, and it produces a completely different life. The one staring up into heaven has already half-left the world, disengaged, waiting for evacuation, useless to the earth he is trying to leave. The one waiting for the King's return is planted, engaged, working, because he knows the King is coming back here, to this world, to inspect and to reign and to renew, and so this world and its condition matter enormously. If your King is coming back to the earth, you keep the earth ready for Him. If your King is waiting to whisk you off the earth, you let the earth go to ruin. The ascension, rightly understood, is one more nail in the coffin of escapism, because it sends us not gazing upward but working downward, keeping the house ready for the King who is coming home.

Let me be fair to the instinct the ascension seems to endorse, because there is something true in the upward gaze. It is right that our hope is anchored in God and not in the world's own resources, right that we look beyond the earthly

to the transcendent, right that Christ is exalted above us and we worship Him as Lord. The upward direction is not wholly wrong. Christ is above, enthroned, exalted, and to look to Him there is the posture of worship. The error is only in thinking the upward gaze is the final direction of our hope, in staring up as if we were going to that heaven, when in fact the One we look up to in worship is the One we wait for to come down in glory. We look up to worship the ascended King. We look forward to His return to the renewed earth. Both directions are true, and the escapist collapsed them into one, keeping only the upward and losing the return.

So here is the verdict. The ascension is not the divine blessing on escape. It is the coronation of a human body over the whole cosmos, the permanent joining of God to matter, and the guarantee that the King who went bodily into the cloud of glory will come bodily back to the earth He reigns over. There is a man on the throne of the universe. He is reigning now, hidden. And He is coming back, not to evacuate the world but to renew it, in the same way the disciples saw Him go. So we do not stand staring up into heaven. We get to work on the earth, keeping the Father's house ready, because the King is coming home. And a King coming home means there is one more thing this whole hope demands of us that we have not yet faced directly, which is what we are supposed to be doing in the meantime, in the long interval, with the years we are given. What is the mission of a resurrection people. Let me take that up, because a hope this size was never meant to be believed only. It was meant to be lived, and lived on purpose.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Mission of a Resurrection People

*A hope you only believe is a hope you
do not yet trust. A hope you trust, you
enact.*

IF EVERYTHING I HAVE argued is true, then the church has a mission that is far larger and far more urgent than the escapist gospel ever gave it, and I want to spend this chapter drawing it out, because a hope this size that changed nothing about how the church actually spends its days would be a hope no one really believed. The escapist gospel gave the church a mission that was, in the end, very small. Rescue souls off the sinking ship before it goes down. Get people to say the prayer so their disembodied souls go to the right place when the body dies. That mission is not wrong exactly, souls do need rescuing and the prayer does matter, but it is a

fragment of the mission, a single amputated piece of something much larger, and the church spent centuries acting as if the fragment were the whole.

Because if the gospel is not evacuation but renewal, if God is not junking the world but redeeming it, if the end is not our escape to heaven but heaven coming to earth, then the mission of the church is not merely to rescue souls off the earth. It is to be, right now, in the middle of the interval, a preview of the renewed creation, a colony of the coming kingdom, a place where the future God is bringing shows up early. Paul calls the church the body of Christ, and I do not think that is only a metaphor for organization. I think it means the church is meant to be the place on earth where the risen life of Jesus becomes visible in advance, where the world can look and see a foretaste of what God is going to do to everything. The mission is not to get people off the earth. The mission is to bring heaven to earth, in preview, in the community of the redeemed, as a sign and a rehearsal of the day when God brings it in full.

Think about what that does to every ordinary activity of the church. When the church feeds the hungry, on the escapist view that is at best a strategy to get a hearing for the real message about the soul, a bit of bait for the gospel hook. But on the resurrection view, feeding the hungry is the gospel, or part of it, a genuine preview of the day when God spreads a feast on the mountain and no one is hungry ever again. When the church heals the sick, on the escapist view that is a nice thing that ultimately does not matter because the body is going to die anyway. But on the resurrection view, every healing is a signpost, a small anticipation of the day when there is no more sickness and death is no more, a

preview breaking into the interval. When the church makes peace, pursues justice, reconciles enemies, cares for the dying, protects the vulnerable, makes beautiful things, it is not doing add-ons to the real spiritual work. It is doing the real work, rehearsing the world that is coming, letting the future leak into the present.

This does not diminish evangelism. Let me say that clearly, because someone will hear me relocating the mission away from souls and worry I am gutting the call to proclaim the gospel and see people come to faith. I am not. The proclamation of the crucified and risen Christ, the call to repentance and faith, the seeing of dead souls made alive, is central and non-negotiable and I would die for it. But watch how the resurrection frame enlarges even evangelism rather than shrinking it. On the escapist view, evangelism is getting a soul's ticket punched for heaven. On the resurrection view, evangelism is inviting a whole person, body and soul, into the community of the coming kingdom, into the people who will be raised on the last day and reign on the renewed earth, into the new creation that has already begun in Christ. It is not a smaller thing than getting a soul to heaven. It is a bigger thing. It is welcoming someone into the future of the world.

And here is where the mission becomes deeply personal for me, because I founded a network of pastors, the Pastors Connection Network, precisely because I believe the church's mission is larger than most of us were trained to think, and because pastors, more than anyone, need each other to keep from shrinking it back down. It is so easy, in the grind of ministry, to let the mission collapse into managing a religious institution, keeping the machine running, getting people in the door and keeping them vaguely happy until they die and go to the better place. That is the escapist mission wearing a

suit, and it is exhausting and it is small, and I have felt it try to swallow me. The resurrection mission is harder but it is alive. It calls the church to be a colony of heaven on earth, a community where the future shows up early, and that is worth a pastor's whole life in a way that running the religious machine never could be.

Let me be concrete about what this looks like in a local church, because I am a working pastor and I distrust visions that never touch the parking lot. A resurrection church grieves honestly, refusing the escapist rush past the pain, weeping with those who weep because it knows death is a real enemy. And a resurrection church hopes stubbornly, refusing to let the grief have the last word, because it knows the enemy is defeated. A resurrection church honors bodies, feeds them, heals them, protects them, because they are destined for glory and not for the trash. A resurrection church cares about the earth, not as a political posture but as a rehearsal for the redemption of creation. A resurrection church pursues justice, all of it, without checking which tribe it flatters, because it is the family business of a God who is putting the world right. A resurrection church works, makes, builds, creates, because it is apprenticing for the vocation of the world to come. And a resurrection church proclaims the crucified and risen Christ as the only hope of the world, calling everyone into the community of the coming kingdom. That is not a program. It is a way of being the church that takes the resurrection seriously enough to let it govern everything.

I have to name the cost, because a mission this large costs something, and the escapist mission was popular partly because it was cheap. It is easy to run a church whose only mission is to get souls to heaven, because you can do it while

ignoring the hungry, the earth, the prisoner, the injustice, the grief, all the hard heavy things, on the grounds that they do not ultimately matter. The resurrection mission will not let you ignore any of it, because all of it matters, all of it is being redeemed, all of it is the family business. That is a heavier call. It will cost you your comfort and your neat categories and your ability to look away from the suffering of the world with a clear conscience. But it is the real thing, and the cheap thing was never the gospel, it was a fragment of the gospel with the cost cut out. I would rather carry the heavy real thing than the light false one, and I say that as a man who has been tempted by the light false one every week of his ministry.

So here is the verdict of the mission. A resurrection people does not wait to be rescued off the earth. It works to bring heaven to earth in preview, as a colony of the coming kingdom, a community where the future God is bringing shows up early, so that the world can look at the church and catch a glimpse of what God is going to do to everything. The mission is not evacuation. It is anticipation. Not getting souls off a sinking ship, but keeping the Father's house ready for the King who is coming home, and letting the light of the coming day shine into the dark of the interval. That is a mission worth a life. And now, having walked the whole length of it, from the funeral where it began to the mission it demands, there remains only to gather it up and say the last thing, the thing I would want said if this were the last thing I ever got to say, and to leave you, as I promised at the start, not with everything tied off, but with weight to carry out the door. Let me try to say it.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Millennium and the Maps

The people most certain about the timeline are usually the least changed by the hope. Certainty about the map is not the same as trusting the country.

I HAVE TO SPEND a chapter on a subject I would rather avoid, because avoiding it would be a kind of cowardice, and because the way the church has fought over it is itself a symptom of the disease this book diagnoses. The millennium. The rapture. The great charts with their arrows and their dispensations, the whole industry of end-times prediction that has consumed so much Christian energy and produced so much heat and so little formation. I want to handle it honestly, tell you where I land, and then, more importantly, tell you why I think the fighting over the map has

distracted us from the country it was supposed to lead to.

Let me define the terrain, because most people have absorbed a set of assumptions they have never examined. The word millennium comes from Revelation 20, which speaks of a thousand years during which Christ reigns and Satan is bound. Around that single passage, the church has built several competing systems, and I am going to state each fairly, because they are held by serious believers and this is second-order territory where faithful churches divide without the faith itself being at stake.

The premillennial view holds that Christ will return before the thousand-year reign, that there will be a literal future period of His visible rule on the earth. Within it, one influential strand, dispensational premillennialism, adds the idea of a rapture, a moment when the church is caught up to meet Christ in the air before a period of tribulation, a scheme worked out in detail in the nineteenth century and popularized enormously in the twentieth through study Bibles and, later, bestselling novels. Its defenders argue it takes the prophetic texts most literally and preserves a real future for God's promises. The postmillennial view holds that the gospel will gradually advance until the world is substantially christianized, and that Christ returns after this golden age, the millennium being a period the church brings about through the spread of the kingdom. Its defenders argue it takes most seriously the promises of the gospel's triumph and refuses despair about history. The amillennial view holds that the thousand years is symbolic, that we are in the millennium now, the reign of Christ from His ascension to His return, and that the number is not a literal count but a picture of the fullness of His present rule. Its defenders argue it reads

Revelation as the symbolic literature it plainly is and avoids the endless failed attempts to fit current events onto the prophetic chart.

Now let me tell you where I land, and then let me tell you why I hold it loosely, because the how of holding a view matters as much as the view. I lean amillennial, or perhaps to a chastened optimistic reading, because I think Revelation is symbolic literature and was never meant to be a coded timeline, and because the history of confident date-setting and chart-making is a history of unbroken failure that ought to teach us humility. Every generation that has turned the prophecies into a newspaper has been wrong, every single one, and the wreckage of their certainties should make us cautious about the whole enterprise. So I do not hold a detailed map. I hold the country. Christ has come, Christ is reigning now though hidden, Christ will return bodily and visibly, the dead will be raised, the earth will be renewed, and God will dwell with His people forever. That much is clear, creedal, and non-negotiable. The precise sequence of the last events, the timing of the millennium, the question of a rapture, these I hold with an open hand, and I will not divide from a brother over them.

But here is what I actually want to say in this chapter, the thing that matters more than which view is right. The obsession with the map has distracted us from the country, and the distraction is itself a form of the escapist disease. Think about it. The energy the church has poured into end-times charts, into identifying the antichrist in the current headlines, into predicting the date of the rapture, into arguing about the sequence of tribulation and millennium, is enormous, and almost none of it has made anyone more generous, more courageous, more just, more loving, more

like Christ. It has produced anxiety, division, sensationalism, and a strange spectator relationship to the future, in which the Christian's job is to figure out the schedule and watch it unfold rather than to live faithfully in the interval. The map-making is a way of being fascinated by the future without being formed by it, and that is exactly backward.

And notice how much of the popular map-making is escapist to its core. The rapture, in its popular form, is the escape fantasy in its purest expression, the church snatched off the earth before the trouble comes, evacuated to safety while the world burns below. Whatever the exegetical merits of the underlying text, the cultural power of the rapture idea is the power of escape, the dream of getting out before the collapse, and it has fed the very disposability of the earth I spent a chapter tracing. If the plan is that God airlifts the church out before the world goes down, then the world going down is not our problem, and creation care and long-term justice and any labor whose payoff is decades away become pointless, because we will be gone. The escapist eschatology and the escapist ethics reinforce each other, and the whole machine runs on the fantasy of getting out.

The resurrection hope refuses the fantasy. It does not airlift you out. It plants you in the ground like a seed and promises to raise you. It does not evacuate the earth. It renews it. And that means the resurrection people cannot be spectators of a schedule. They must be laborers in an interval, working, planting, building, loving, with no guarantee of an early exit, because the promise was never an early exit. The promise was resurrection, on the far side of death, on a renewed earth, and everything in between is to be lived faithfully, not watched anxiously off a chart.

Let me be fair, because I have been hard on the map-makers and some of them are dear saints who love the Lord. The impulse behind the map-making is not wholly bad. It is the desire to take the Bible's prophecies seriously, to believe that God has a plan and history is going somewhere, to resist the modern despair that says history is just one meaningless thing after another. Those are good impulses. The Bible does teach that history is going somewhere, that God has a plan, that the end is not chaos but consummation. The error is not in believing the future is real and planned. The error is in thinking our job is to decode the schedule rather than to live faithfully toward the country, in mistaking certainty about the map for trust in the God who holds it. A person can be an expert on the timeline and a stranger to the hope, and a person can be hopeless about the timeline and utterly formed by the country. I would rather be the second.

So here is the verdict, and I offer it as a plea more than a pronouncement. Hold the map loosely and the country tightly. The details of the millennium and the rapture and the sequence of the last things are second-order questions where faithful Christians differ, and you should hold your view with humility and refuse to break fellowship over it. But the country the maps are supposed to lead to is not in doubt and is not second-order. Christ will return. The dead will rise. The earth will be renewed. God will dwell with His people and wipe away every tear. That is the hope, and it is meant to form you, not merely to fascinate you. So stop staring at the chart on the wall and start living toward the country it points to, because the test of your eschatology is not whether you can date the rapture. The test is whether the hope has made you more like the Christ who is coming. And that test brings us close to home, into the most ordinary and most sacred of

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

human arrangements, the family, because the resurrection has something to say even there, even to a marriage, even to the raising of children, and it is not what you have been told.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Marriage, Children, and the Hope That Outlasts Them

*The resurrection does not make your
family less precious. It makes it a
rehearsal for a love that death will not
be allowed to end.*

I WANT TO BRING this hope all the way down into the most tender and complicated place in most people's lives, the family, because I am a husband and a father of five sons and a man who was raised without a father, and I have thought a great deal about what the resurrection means for the people we love most, the ones we share a name and a table and a bed with. And I have to start with a hard saying of Jesus that has troubled people for two thousand years, because if I dodge it I

have not earned the right to say anything comforting afterward.

The Sadducees, who did not believe in the resurrection, came to Jesus with a trick question designed to make the resurrection look absurd. A woman, they said, was married to seven brothers in succession, each one dying in turn. In the resurrection, whose wife will she be. They thought they had Him, because the whole thing sounds ridiculous if you imagine the resurrection as just a resumption of this life exactly as it is. And Jesus answer, in Matthew 22, has been misread as cold, and I want to read it rightly, because it is not cold at all. He says that in the resurrection they neither marry nor are given in marriage, but are like the angels in heaven. People have taken this to mean that our deepest human bonds are dissolved in the resurrection, that we will not know or love our spouses and children, that the family is a temporary arrangement swept away in the world to come. And that reading has caused real grief, because it seems to say the love you built your life on does not survive.

But look more carefully at what Jesus is and is not saying. He is not saying love is abolished. He is saying that the institution of marriage, with its purpose of forming families and bearing children and securing lineage in a world where death makes such things necessary, will not operate in the same way in a world where death is no more. Marriage in this age exists partly because we die, because the race must be continued, because we need the covenant bond to hold us against loss and time. In the resurrection, where death is destroyed and time is redeemed, the particular institution of marriage as we know it is fulfilled and surpassed, not because love ends but because the thing marriage was pointing to

arrives. Marriage in this life, the New Testament says elsewhere, is an icon, a picture of the union between Christ and His church. When the reality comes, the picture is not destroyed but absorbed into what it always signified. You do not mourn the loss of the engagement ring on the wedding day. The ring is fulfilled in the marriage. Marriage in this age is the ring. The wedding of Christ and His people is the marriage.

So does that mean you will not know your wife in the resurrection, will not love your husband, will not recognize the children you raised. I cannot believe it, and I do not think the text requires it, and here is why. The resurrection is not the abolition of the persons you loved. It is their raising, whole, in continuity with who they were. The woman married to the seven brothers will be there, and so will the brothers, and they will know one another and love one another, more fully than they ever could in this life, not less. What changes is not the love but the exclusivity and the institution, because in a world where all are fully united to Christ and to one another in perfect love, the particular exclusive covenant that protected love against loss in this age is not diminished but caught up into a wider and deeper communion. You will not love your spouse less in the resurrection. You will love them, and everyone else, with a love this life could not contain. The love is not lost. It is enlarged past the point where the old container can hold it.

Let me make this personal, because I am not writing an argument, I am writing to people who love people they are going to lose or have already lost. If you are married, and you have built a life with someone, and you have wondered with a knot in your stomach whether death is going to take them from you forever, whether the person you know better than

any other is going to be dissolved into some anonymous heavenly bliss where you no longer know them, hear me. That is not the promise. The promise is resurrection, and resurrection means the person, raised, whole, known, loved, in continuity with who they were, on a renewed earth where death can never separate you again. The love you built is not a temporary arrangement to be swept away. It is a rehearsal, a foretaste, a small and real participation in the love of the world to come, and it will not be deleted. It will be fulfilled. Every good thing in it will be there, purified and permanent, and the only things that will be missing are the fear of losing it and the failures that marred it.

And children. I have five sons, and I was raised without a father, and so the question of what the resurrection means for the raising of children is not abstract to me, it is the deepest question of my life. When I was a boy with no father, the escapist gospel would have told me that it did not finally matter, that the wound of fatherlessness was a temporary trouble of a temporary world, that in heaven the soul would be free of all such earthly sorrows. And there is a thin comfort in that, but it is a lie, or at least a half-truth that leaves out the better half. Because the resurrection does not tell me my fatherlessness did not matter. It tells me it mattered enormously, that it was a real wound in a real world that God intends to heal, that the father-shaped hole in my life is not going to be dissolved but filled, that on the renewed earth I will know the fatherhood of God in a way that heals every absence, and more, that the fathering I have tried to do for my own sons, however flawed, is not a temporary arrangement but a participation in something eternal, a rehearsal for a communion that death will not end.

That changes how I father. If my sons are eternal creatures

destined for resurrection, then raising them is not merely a two-decade project of getting them launched into adulthood before they leave and I die. It is the shaping of people who will live forever, the tending of image-bearers destined for glory, a work whose significance reaches past my own death and theirs into the world that is coming. When I am patient with them, when I am present in a way my own father never was, when I teach them and correct them and love them, I am not just managing a household. I am doing eternal work on eternal people. And when I fail them, as I do, the resurrection is also my hope there, because it means my failures are not the final word over my sons any more than death is, that the God who is making all things new can heal even the wounds a father leaves, as He is healing the ones my father left in me.

Let me be honest about the hard cases, because a chapter on family that only speaks to the happy ones is a lie by omission. Some of you have families that are broken, marriages that failed, children who are estranged, parents who wounded you past what seems healable, or families that death has already torn apart. And I will not hand you a sentimental picture of family reunion that ignores the real fractures. But here is what the resurrection offers even to the broken family, and it is better than sentiment. It offers a God who is going to put things right, who is going to heal what was broken, reconcile what was estranged, restore what was lost, on the far side of death, in a way that this life could not manage. The reconciliation you could not achieve, the healing you could not force, the restoration you gave up hoping for, is not off the table. It is deferred, held, promised, in the hands of a God who specializes in raising dead things. I do not know the details of how God heals every broken family, and I will not pretend to. But I know the God who wipes away every tear

does not leave the deepest wounds of the family untouched, and I know that the resurrection reaches even there.

So here is the verdict. The resurrection does not make your family less precious by relativizing it to a heavenly future. It makes your family more precious by revealing it as a rehearsal for a love that death will not be allowed to end. Your marriage is an icon of a union that is coming. Your children are eternal creatures you have been given to shape. Your broken places are wounds God intends to heal. And the love you have built, however imperfect, however marred by failure and loss, is not a temporary arrangement swept away in the world to come, but a small and real participation in the love that will fill the renewed earth, when death is no more and every tear is wiped away and no one you love is ever taken from you again. Love your people fiercely. Death is not going to get to keep them. And that certainty, that death does not get to keep what we love, only holds if we can trust God through the suffering that fills the interval, which is the last hard thing I have to face before I can say the final word. What do we do with the suffering, the real, unanswered, present suffering, while we wait.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Suffering That Comes Before the Morning

*The resurrection is not an answer to
suffering. It is a promise that suffering
does not get the last word, which is
better than an answer.*

I HAVE SAVED THIS for near the end because it is the objection under all the objections, the wound under all the wounds, the thing that made me an atheist in the first place and the thing that nearly kept me one. If God is good and God is powerful, why is there so much suffering. Why the cancer wards full of children. Why the tsunamis and the genocides and the slow humiliation of dementia. Why the specific, personal, unbearable grief that some of you are carrying as

you read this. I cannot write a book about the resurrection hope and pretend the problem of suffering does not stand in the doorway, arms crossed, demanding to be answered before it will let the hope pass.

So let me first say what the resurrection does not do, because false advertising here would be a betrayal. The resurrection does not explain your suffering. It does not tell you why the child died, why the marriage ended, why the diagnosis came, why the particular sorrow of your particular life was allowed. The Bible, strikingly, does not offer a tidy explanation of suffering, and anyone who hands you one is selling something the Bible does not stock. The book of Job, the Bible's own extended meditation on undeserved suffering, spends thirty-seven chapters building toward an explanation and then does not give one. When God finally speaks to Job out of the whirlwind, He does not explain the suffering. He does not tell Job about the wager in heaven, does not justify Himself, does not offer the tidy theodicy Job's friends kept trying to construct. God answers Job's demand for an explanation with a tour of the wildness and vastness of creation, essentially asking Job whether he is in a position to run the universe, and Job, remarkably, is satisfied, not because he got an answer but because he got God. The lesson of Job is not that there is a good explanation we cannot see. It is that we are given God Himself instead of an explanation, and that this, in the end, is more than an explanation could have been.

But the resurrection adds something to Job that Job did not have, and it is the thing I most want you to hold. The resurrection does not explain suffering, but it does defeat it, and defeating it is better than explaining it. Consider what an

explanation would actually give you. Suppose God appeared and gave you a complete, satisfying account of exactly why your child had to die, a reason so good that you had to admit it was worth it. Would that heal you. I do not think it would. The child would still be dead. The explanation, however satisfying, would not give the child back. An explanation leaves the suffering exactly where it is and merely justifies it. But the resurrection does not justify the suffering. It reverses it. It does not tell you why the child died. It promises you the child raised. And a raised child is worth infinitely more than an explanation of why the child died. The resurrection does not answer the problem of suffering. It undoes the suffering, which is what you actually wanted all along. You never really wanted an explanation. You wanted the suffering not to have happened, or to be made right, and the resurrection is the promise that it will be made right, more than right, so thoroughly right that the sufferings of this present time, Paul says, are not worth comparing with the glory that will be revealed.

Now I have to be careful with that Pauline claim, because in the wrong hands it becomes monstrous. Not worth comparing with the glory. Said coldly, to a suffering person, that sentence is an obscenity, a minimizing of their pain, the very thing this book has fought against. But Paul does not say it coldly, and he does not say it as a spectator. This is a man who was beaten with rods, stoned and left for dead, shipwrecked three times, imprisoned, hungry, cold, in constant danger. When Paul says the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing to the coming glory, he is not a comfortable man waving away other people's pain. He is a scarred man who has suffered as much as almost anyone, telling you from inside the suffering that the coming glory is

so great it will outweigh even this. That is not minimizing. That is a battlefield report from someone who has been in the worst of it and glimpsed what is coming. The weight of the glory does not make the suffering weightless. It makes the suffering, however heavy, lighter than the glory, the way even the heaviest thing is light compared to something heavier still.

And here is the deepest thing the resurrection gives us for suffering, deeper than explanation, deeper even than reversal. It gives us a God who suffered. This is the scandal and the glory of Christianity, the thing no other account of the world offers. When you cry out from the depths of your suffering, why, where are you, do you even care, the Christian answer is not a philosophical justification delivered from a safe distance. The Christian answer is a cross. God did not stay above the suffering, explaining it or permitting it from a throne untouched by it. God came down into it, took a body, and suffered, really suffered, betrayal and abandonment and torture and death, the worst that suffering can do. On the cross God experienced God-forsakenness, cried out my God my God why have you forsaken me, entered the very darkness that makes people atheists, and did not explain it but bore it. When you suffer, you do not suffer before a God who does not understand. You suffer before a God with scars, who has been where you are, who took the worst of it into His own body. That does not explain your suffering. But it means you are not alone in it, that the God you are crying to has cried the same cry, and there is a comfort in that which no explanation could ever give.

Let me tell you how this landed for me, because I did not come to it as theory. I came to Christ, in part, through exactly this, through the discovery that the God I had rejected

because of suffering was a God who had suffered. As an atheist, my strongest argument was the suffering of the world, the pointless agony of it, and I threw it at Christianity expecting it to have no answer, expecting a God who sat above the pain dispensing it or ignoring it. And what I found instead was a God on a cross, a God who had entered the very suffering I was using as my argument against Him, a God who did not answer the problem of pain with a syllogism but with wounds. And it did not answer my question, but it dismantled it, because I had assumed suffering proved God was either absent or cruel, and here was a God who was neither absent nor cruel but crucified, present in the suffering, bearing it. I could no longer say the suffering of the world proved there was no God who cared, because the central claim of the faith was a God who cared so much He bled. The problem of suffering did not get solved. It got a companion, a God in the fire with me, and that changed everything.

So what do you do with the suffering that fills the interval, the real present suffering that has not yet been reversed, while you wait for the morning. You do three things, and I have watched people do all three, and they are the shape of faithful suffering. You lament, honestly, loudly, the way the Psalms lament, the way Job lamented, the way Jesus lamented from the cross, refusing the false piety that pretends suffering does not hurt. God can handle your rage and your grief and your why, and the Bible is full of people hurling exactly those at Him, and He does not strike them down, He includes their laments in His own book. And you endure, holding on, putting one foot in front of the other, not because you understand but because you trust the God who has been in the fire with you. And you hope, keeping your eyes on the morning, on the resurrection, on the day the

sufferings of this present time are swallowed up in a glory that outweighs them, on the hand that will wipe away every tear. Lament, endure, hope. That is the shape of suffering in the interval, and it is not a formula, it is the actual practice of the saints who have suffered before you and held on.

So here is the verdict, and it is the hardest-won verdict in this book. The resurrection is not an answer to the problem of suffering, and I will not insult your pain by pretending it is. It is something better than an answer. It is a promise that suffering does not get the last word, backed by a God who did not explain suffering from a distance but entered it and bore it and rose out the other side. Your suffering is real, and it is not the end, and you do not suffer alone, and there is a morning coming when it will be not merely explained but reversed, wiped away by a hand that still bears the scars of having suffered with you. That is what I have to offer you in the fire. Not a reason. A companion, and a morning. And it has been enough for the saints for two thousand years, and it was enough to pull an angry atheist out of the dark, and I believe it will be enough for you. Which leaves me only the last word to say, the gathering up of the whole thing, the sending of you out the door with the weight of it. Let me say it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Table, the Water, and the Rehearsal

*Every time the church eats the bread
and drinks the cup, it is practicing for
a meal that has not been served yet.*

I WANT TO TAKE you into the two most physical things the church does, because they are not incidental to the resurrection hope, they are the resurrection hope enacted with water and bread and wine, and the church has too often reduced them to spiritual symbols floating free of their bodily meaning, which is the escapist error creeping even into the sacraments. Baptism and the Lord's Supper. Water and a meal. The two things Jesus left His church to do with its hands, and both of them are, at their heart, rehearsals of resurrection.

Start with baptism, and notice first how physical it is.

Jesus did not leave His church a purely inward, spiritual rite. He left it water, a body going down into water and coming up out of it. And Paul, in Romans 6, tells us exactly what that watery drama means. We were buried with Him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead, we too might walk in newness of life. Baptism is a burial and a resurrection acted out with a body and water. Down into the water is death and burial, the old self drowned, the body given over to the grave. Up out of the water is resurrection, the new self raised, the body brought up into new life. Every baptism is a small enacted resurrection, a body going under and coming up, a physical rehearsal of the day the graves will open and the sea will give up its dead.

And this is why the physicality of baptism matters and why the escapist instinct to spiritualize it away is a loss. If salvation were merely the rescue of a soul, why water at all, why bodies, why this drama of burial and rising. Because salvation is not the rescue of a soul from a body. It is the death of the old self and the resurrection of the whole person, body and soul, and the water enacts exactly that, the whole embodied person plunged and raised. When you watched someone baptized, or when you were baptized yourself, you saw the gospel performed in the only medium that could carry its full meaning, a body in water, going down into death, coming up into life. It is a rehearsal. It is the resurrection in miniature, done with your hands and someone's body, so that the promise is not merely heard but seen and felt and remembered in the muscles.

Now the table, the Lord's Supper, and here the resurrection theme is even richer than we usually notice. We tend to think of communion entirely as a memorial of the cross, a looking back at the death of Jesus, the broken body

and the shed blood, and it is that, but it is not only that. Jesus, on the night He instituted it, said something that points the whole thing forward. I will not drink again of the fruit of the vine, He said, until that day when I drink it new in the kingdom of God. The Supper does not only look back to the cross. It looks forward to a feast, the marriage supper of the Lamb, the great banquet on the mountain that Isaiah saw, where God spreads a feast of rich food and swallows up death forever and wipes away tears from all faces. Every communion is a small foretaste of that feast, an appetizer of the resurrection banquet, a rehearsal for the day when the whole family of God sits down at a table on the renewed earth and eats and drinks in the presence of the King who conquered death.

Notice that it is a meal. Of all the things Jesus could have left His church as its central rite, He left a meal, bread and wine, food and drink, the most bodily and ordinary of human acts. He did not leave a moment of silent inward contemplation, a purely spiritual exercise of the mind. He left something you eat, something that goes into your body, something you taste. And that is not an accident. The center of Christian worship is a meal because the center of the Christian hope is a feast, because the God who is going to renew the earth is going to do it in a way that includes eating and drinking and bodies and tables, because the risen Christ ate fish, because the new creation is not the abolition of physical joys but their perfection. When the church eats the bread and drinks the cup, it is practicing for a meal that has not been served yet, keeping its taste for the feast alive through the long interval, refusing to forget that the hope is bodily and the future is a banquet.

Let me draw out why this matters for how you worship and

how you live. The sacraments are God's answer to our tendency to make the faith too spiritual, too inward, too escapist. Left to ourselves, we drift toward a religion of pure ideas and feelings, a Christianity that happens entirely between our ears and never touches our bodies. And God, knowing this about us, gave us water and bread and wine, physical things we must do with our bodies, precisely to keep us from floating off into a disembodied faith. Every baptism drags the gospel back into the water. Every communion drags the hope back onto the table. The sacraments are anchors against escapism, weekly and lifelong reminders that this faith is about bodies, that its center is a body broken and a body raised, that its future is a feast and not a fog. A church that takes the sacraments seriously will find it much harder to drift into the clouds, because it keeps having to do things with water and bread that will not let the gospel become merely spiritual.

I have to be fair to the traditions that understand these things differently, because the church has divided over the sacraments and this is second-order territory where I owe honesty about my own view and its limits. Christians disagree about what exactly happens in baptism and the Supper, whether the bread and wine become the body and blood or represent them or convey grace in some other way, whether baptism should be for infants or believers, and these are real differences held by serious believers, and I am not going to resolve them here or pretend my own view is beyond dispute. What I am claiming is more basic and, I think, common ground across the traditions. Whatever else these rites are, they are physical, they involve bodies and water and food, and they are oriented toward resurrection, baptism enacting death and rising, the Supper anticipating the feast. On that,

the traditions largely agree, however they differ on the mechanics, and that shared physicality is itself a witness against the escapist reduction of the faith to a purely inward affair.

So here is the verdict. The two central acts of the church are not spiritual exercises that happen to use physical props. They are physical rehearsals of a physical hope, a body buried and raised in the water, a body broken and a feast anticipated at the table. Every time the church baptizes, it performs the resurrection with water and a body. Every time the church eats the bread and drinks the cup, it practices for the feast on the mountain where death is swallowed up forever. These are not escapes from the body into the spirit. They are the gospel insisting, week after week, that the hope is embodied and the future is a banquet, so that a people prone to drift into the clouds keep getting pulled back to the water and the table and the promise of a raised body on a renewed earth. And that same insistence, that the good things of the body and the earth are not distractions but foretastes, has one more place to go, into the strange question of beauty and making, of why we build cathedrals and write symphonies and plant gardens, of whether any of it lasts. Let me take that up, because the resurrection has something to say about the things we make.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Why the Cathedral Was Not a Waste

*If the world is going to be raised, then
the beautiful things we make in it are
not doomed. They are the first drafts of
a glory that will not be lost.*

THERE IS A QUESTION that haunts every artist and every builder and every maker of beautiful things, whether they name it or not, and the resurrection answers it in a way the escapist gospel could never even ask. The question is whether any of it lasts. You spend your life making something beautiful, a painting, a building, a piece of music, a garden, a well-crafted thing, and you know that you will die and the thing will decay and eventually the sun itself will burn out, and so a voice whispers that all of it is finally futile, sandcastles before the tide, a brief arrangement of matter

that entropy will erase. And the escapist gospel, far from silencing that voice, actually agrees with it. If the world is going to be burned up and only souls go to heaven, then every beautiful thing made of matter is doomed, and the cathedral and the symphony and the garden are, at best, harmless distractions, at worst a foolish investment in a world that is going to be scrapped.

I have felt the pull of this, and I suspect you have too. Why build something beautiful and lasting if it is all going to be destroyed. Why should a Christian pour a life into art or architecture or craft, when the real work is saving souls for a heaven where none of these things will matter. The escapist gospel has a genuine and corrosive effect on Christian culture-making, because it whispers that beauty is a luxury, that making things is a lesser calling, that the artist and the builder are spending themselves on a doomed world while the evangelist does the eternal work. And so, tragically, we have often surrendered beauty to the secular world, made peace with ugliness in our own buildings and worship and art, because we half-believed that beauty did not finally matter, that it was going to burn anyway.

But if the world is not going to be scrapped, if it is going to be raised, then the whole question changes, and the change is thrilling. Because now the beautiful things we make are not doomed sandcastles. They are, potentially, the first drafts of a glory that will carry over into the renewed creation. I said earlier, following the direction of Scripture and the argument of N.T. Wright, that our works of love and justice are somehow taken up into God's new creation, not lost but found again, purified and permanent. And I believe the same is true of beauty, of the good and beautiful things we make. Revelation

gives us a haunting detail about the New Jerusalem, that the kings of the earth will bring their glory into it, that the glory and the honor of the nations will be brought into the city. Whatever exactly that means, and I will not overreach, it suggests that the good and glorious achievements of human culture, the beauty we have made, will not simply be deleted but will somehow be carried in, purified, into the renewed creation. The cathedral was not a waste. It was a first draft.

Think about what that does to the calling of the maker. If you are an artist, a musician, a builder, a craftsman, a gardener, anyone who makes beautiful things, the resurrection tells you that your work is not a distraction from the eternal but a rehearsal for it, that the beauty you make now is a foretaste of the beauty that will fill the renewed earth, and that it is possible your work, or the essence of it, will be found again on the far side of death, taken up into the world God is making. That does not mean every scribble survives, and it does not mean art is more important than love or justice, and I am not building a doctrine of the eternal preservation of your specific paintings. I am saying the direction of the resurrection is that beauty is not doomed, that making beautiful things is a good and even eternal kind of work, that the maker is not wasting his life on a sinking ship but apprenticing for the decoration of the King's own city.

And this reframes the ordinary too, not just the cathedral but the small beautiful things anyone can make. The meal cooked with care, the room made lovely, the song sung well, the small craft done with excellence, the garden tended into beauty. On the escapist view these are trivial, pleasant distractions of no eternal weight. On the resurrection view they are small acts of anticipation, little previews of a world where beauty is everywhere and nothing beautiful is ever

lost. The mother who makes her home beautiful, the cook who makes the meal lovely, the amateur who paints for no audience but the joy of it, are all doing something that participates, in a small way, in the future God is bringing, a future not less beautiful than this world but infinitely more. Beauty is not a luxury the resurrection permits. It is a rehearsal the resurrection dignifies.

Let me guard against a misreading, because I can be heard as baptizing every act of self-expression as eternally significant, and that is not what I mean. Not everything called art is good, and not everything called beauty is beautiful, and the resurrection does not promise to preserve the ugly, the cruel, the merely fashionable, or the self-indulgent. The fire of judgment, remember, burns away the dross. What is carried into the new creation is what is genuinely good, genuinely true, genuinely beautiful, and much of what our culture produces is none of those things and will not survive the fire. So the resurrection does not flatter the artist into thinking everything he makes is eternal. It calls the artist to make things genuinely good and true and beautiful, things worthy of a world that is going to last, because the fire is coming and only what is real will come through it. That is a higher standard, not a lower one. The resurrection does not tell you everything you make matters. It tells you that what is genuinely good in what you make will last, and it calls you to make things good enough to last.

There is a deep freedom in this for the maker, and I want to name it, because the artist's life is often haunted by the fear of futility. If you make beautiful things knowing they are all doomed, you make them in a kind of despair, a defiance of the tide that you know will win. But if you make beautiful things knowing that the good in them will be found again,

that you are apprenticing for the King's city, that beauty is not a losing battle against entropy but a rehearsal for a world where beauty wins, then you make them in hope, freely, joyfully, as an act of anticipation rather than defiance. The Christian artist is not building a sandcastle before the tide. He is drawing a first sketch of a glory that is coming to stay. And that changes everything about how he holds the brush.

So here is the verdict. The cathedral was not a waste, and neither is the symphony, the garden, the well-made thing, the beautiful home, the small craft done with love. In a world that is going to be scrapped, beauty is a doomed distraction, and the escapist gospel was right to treat it as a luxury. But the world is not going to be scrapped. It is going to be raised, and the glory of the nations will be brought into the city, and the good and true and beautiful things we make are not sandcastles but first drafts, apprentice work for the decoration of a world that will not end. So make beautiful things, and make them good enough to last, because the resurrection has told you that beauty is not futile, that the maker is not wasting his life, and that nothing genuinely beautiful is ever finally lost. And if beauty is not lost, and the body is not lost, and the earth is not lost, and the love is not lost, and even the suffering will be reversed, then there is nothing left to say but the last thing, the personal thing, how a man who was sure none of this was true came to stake his whole life on it. Let me tell you that, and then I will let you go.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

How an Atheist Came to Bet His Life on a Corpse

*I did not come to the resurrection
because I wanted comfort. I came
because I could not make the empty
tomb go away, and it would not let me
go.*

I HAVE REFERRED TO my own story throughout this book, in pieces, and I have held most of it back, but I cannot end without telling it plainly, because the hope I have been describing is not a doctrine I inherited and defended. It is a hope that broke into a life that was built entirely against it, and if you are reading this as a skeptic, as I once was, I owe you the honesty of how it happened, not to manipulate you toward a decision but because the how of it matters to the

truth of it.

I did not grow up believing. I grew up without a father, which shaped everything, including my atheism, though I did not see the connection for years. A boy without a father learns early that there is no one coming to help, that the universe does not arrange itself for your good, that you are on your own, and it is a short step from there to concluding that there is no Father at all, no one behind the universe, no one coming. My atheism was intellectual, and I could give you the arguments, and I did, at length and with confidence. But underneath the arguments was a wound, and the wound was fatherlessness, and the two fed each other. I did not believe in God partly because I could not construct the case for Him, and partly because I could not forgive Him for not existing when I needed Him, which is a strange thing to hold against someone who does not exist, and should have told me something, but did not, for a long time.

And I was a good atheist, a serious one, not the lazy kind who never thought about it. I read the arguments on both sides. I found the problem of suffering decisive, as I have said, the pointless agony of the world proof enough that no good and powerful God stood behind it. I found the miracles absurd, the resurrection especially, a piece of ancient wishful thinking that no thinking modern person could credit. I was sure, and my sureness was comfortable, and I had no intention of examining it, because I did not think it needed examining. I thought the whole question was settled and I was on the winning side of history.

What undid me was not an emotional experience. I want to be clear about that, because the easy story is that the fatherless boy needed a father and so invented a heavenly

one, and I have to tell you it did not happen that way, it happened almost the opposite way. What undid me was the historical evidence for the resurrection, which I picked up intending to refute and could not. I have laid out the substance of it earlier in this book, the empty tomb the authorities could have disproven with a corpse and never did, the witnesses who died for a claim they were in a position to know was false, the explosion of a movement in the very city where the grave was, the mutation of Jewish belief that had no category for a single man raised in the middle of history. I went at all of it expecting to knock it down, and instead I found that the naturalistic explanations required more faith than the resurrection did, that to maintain my atheism I had to believe a series of things more improbable than the miracle I was trying to avoid.

And that made me angry, genuinely angry, because I did not want it to be true. This is the part the skeptic will understand and the lifelong believer often does not. I was not looking for God. I was not hoping to find Him. I had built a life and an identity on His absence, and the evidence that He might be there, that the tomb might really be empty, that the corpse might really have gotten up, was not welcome news, it was an intrusion, a threat, a thing that would cost me everything if I let it in. I resisted it for a long time. I looked for the hole in the argument. I read the skeptical responses hungrily, wanting them to work. And they did not work, or rather they worked only if I already assumed the conclusion, only if I decided in advance that resurrection was impossible and then explained away whatever evidence remained. And one day I saw that I was doing exactly that, assuming my conclusion, protecting my unbelief the way I had accused believers of protecting their belief, and the intellectual

dishonesty of it became unbearable to me, because if there was one thing I prized it was following the evidence, and I was not following it, I was fleeing it.

I remember the night it broke, and I will not dress it up, because it was not dramatic. I was sitting alone, and I had run out of ways to keep the empty tomb at a distance, and I said, out loud, to the God I had spent my life denying, something like, if you are real, if you actually did this, then I have been wrong about everything and I do not know what to do with that. It was not a prayer of faith exactly. It was more like a surrender, the surrender of a man who has been fighting a fact and has finally run out of strength to fight it. And nothing spectacular happened in the room. No light, no voice, no flood of feeling. But something had shifted, and I knew it, and it was this. I had stopped fighting. I had let the empty tomb be what the evidence said it was, and once I did that, once I admitted the corpse had gotten up, the whole world reorganized itself around that fact, because if that was true then God was real and I was known and the universe was not the cold indifferent machine I had always believed, and, this is the part that undid the fatherless boy, there was a Father after all, and He was not absent, and He had come, in a body, all the way down into the death I had used as my argument against Him.

That is why the resurrection is not an abstract doctrine to me, and why this book has the urgency it has. I did not choose the resurrection because it was comforting. It was not comforting at first, it was terrifying, because it cost me the entire edifice of my life and my certainty. I chose it because I could not honestly make it go away, because the tomb would not stay shut, because the evidence pointed there and I had promised myself I would follow the evidence. And having

followed it, I found that the thing I had been fighting was the best news there could be, that the God I had denied because of suffering was a God who had entered suffering, that the Father I had been angry at for being absent had come all the way down into the absence, and that death, the thing that had made me an atheist, the pointless erasing end of everything, was not the end at all, but a defeated enemy on a leash, soon to be destroyed.

So when I tell you that heaven is not your reward, that the hope is bigger than escape, that God is going to raise your body and renew the earth and wipe every tear away with His own hand, I am not passing on a comfortable tradition I inherited. I am telling you the thing that broke into my life against my will and reorganized everything, the thing I examined as an enemy and surrendered to as a truth, the thing I have staked my entire life on since. I bet my life on a corpse that got up outside Jerusalem two thousand years ago, and I have never once regretted the bet, and I am asking you, whatever you believe right now, to look at that empty tomb honestly, the way I finally did, and see whether you can make it go away. I could not. And if you cannot either, then you are where I was, at the edge of a grave that will not stay shut, feeling the whole world begin to lean, and I can tell you from the other side that the leaning is not the end of everything you love. It is the beginning of a hope bigger than anything you dared to want. So let me say the last word, and then let you go carry it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Ache the Modern World Cannot Name

We built a world with no room for the resurrection and then wondered why it feels like nothing lasts.

I WANT TO STEP back from the biblical text for a chapter and look at the world we actually live in, the modern secular West, because the escapist gospel did not shrink the Christian hope in a vacuum. It shrank it inside a culture that was itself losing any hope at all, and the two losses are connected, and I think naming the connection will help you feel why the recovery of the resurrection matters not just for the church but for the whole exhausted, disenchanted age.

The philosopher Charles Taylor, in his 2007 book *A Secular Age*, described the great shift that produced the modern world, and he called one crucial piece of it

disenchantment. There was a time, he argued, when people lived in an enchanted world, a world charged with meaning and presence, where the divine and the human and the natural interpenetrated, where the boundary between this world and the sacred was porous. And over several centuries, through a long and complicated process, the West built a different kind of world, what Taylor called the immanent frame, a world closed in on itself, where meaning is something we make rather than something we find, where the transcendent is bracketed out, where the self is what he called buffered, sealed off, no longer porous to anything beyond the material. We live inside that buffered, immanent frame now, most of us, whether we believe in God or not, and it is the air we breathe, and it has a particular feeling to it, and the feeling is a kind of flatness, a sense that this is all there is, that meaning is a construction, that nothing finally lasts.

And here is what I want you to notice. The escapist gospel and the immanent frame are strange allies, opposites that reinforce each other. The secular immanent frame says there is no transcendent, no beyond, nothing after death, this world is all there is and then you are gone. The escapist gospel says the transcendent is real but it is entirely elsewhere, in a heaven completely separate from this world, and this world is a doomed waiting room you escape. Both of them, from opposite directions, empty this world of ultimate significance. The secularist empties it by denying anything beyond it. The escapist empties it by locating everything that matters beyond it. And so the two of them, enemies as they seem, agree on the crucial point, that this world, this earth, these bodies, this life, do not finally matter, one because there is nothing more and the other because the more is entirely elsewhere. Both leave you living in a world drained of

ultimate meaning.

The resurrection breaks both. Against the secularist, it insists there is a beyond, a transcendent God, a life after death, a hope past the grave. But against the escapist, it insists that the beyond is coming here, that the transcendent God is going to dwell in this world, that the hope past the grave is the raising of these bodies on this earth renewed. The resurrection re-enchants the immanent frame not by fleeing it but by flooding it, by promising that the world we live in, far from being all there is or being a doomed waiting room, is the very thing God is going to fill with His presence and glory. It takes the secular world's love of the material and the earthly, which is real and not wholly wrong, and it takes the religious world's love of the transcendent and the eternal, which is also real and not wholly wrong, and it refuses to let them be enemies, because it promises the transcendent God dwelling in the material world forever. The resurrection is the healing of the split that both secularism and escapism live inside.

Now here is the ache I mentioned, the one the modern world cannot name. Taylor argued that even inside the buffered, immanent frame, even for people who fully believe there is nothing transcendent, there remains a haunting, a sense that something is missing, a flatness that people feel and cannot account for, a longing that the closed world cannot satisfy. People raised entirely inside secularism, who have never believed in God and do not expect to, nonetheless often report a nameless ache, a sense that life should mean more than it does, a grief at the transience of everything, a protest of the heart against the flatness of the world they have been handed. They cannot name it because their framework has no words for it, no category for a longing that points

beyond the immanent frame, and so they medicate it or distract it or achieve past it, and it does not go away.

C.S. Lewis named that ache better than anyone, decades before Taylor described the world that produces it. He called it *Sehnsucht*, using the German word for a longing that has no earthly object, a desire that is triggered by beautiful things but is never satisfied by them, that seems to point through them toward something they only echo. In his 1941 sermon *The Weight of Glory*, Lewis argued that this longing is not a neurosis to be cured but a signal to be heeded, that the fact that no earthly thing satisfies it is evidence that we were made for something no earthly thing can provide, that the ache is homesickness for a home we have not yet seen. And Lewis, unlike the secularist, had a name for the home. It was not a disembodied heaven of pure spirit. It was, in his own imagination, a world more solid and more real than this one, the renewed creation, the greener grass and the higher mountains of the resurrection, the very thing this book has been describing. Lewis understood that the ache the modern world cannot name is resurrection-shaped, a longing for a world that is coming, a homesickness for the new creation.

I have felt this ache, and I felt it most sharply as an atheist, before I had any framework that could account for it, and I think that is common. When I did not believe in anything beyond the material, the ache was strongest, because I had a longing with no object and no name and no permission to take it seriously, and I explained it away as sentimentality or evolutionary residue or wishful thinking, and it did not go away. It is one of the things that eventually cracked my unbelief, not as an argument but as a datum, this stubborn longing for a world that did not exist, this grief at transience that made no sense if transience was simply the way of

things, this protest of my heart against the very flatness my mind insisted was the truth. The ache did not prove anything by itself. But it sat there, insisting, and my atheism had no room for it, and the resurrection, when I finally faced it, did, because the resurrection said the ache was true, that I was made for a world that does not pass away, that the homesickness was real homesickness for a real home that is coming.

So if you are living inside the immanent frame, inside the flat, closed, buffered world of secular modernity, and you feel it, the ache, the sense that something is missing, the grief at transience, the longing that no achievement or pleasure or relationship fully satisfies, I want to tell you what it is, because your world will not tell you. It is not a defect. It is not immaturity. It is not something to be medicated away. It is homesickness. You were made for a world that does not die, and you are living in a world that does, and the ache is the memory of your true home and the longing for it, and the resurrection is the promise that the home is real and it is coming, not a disembodied heaven elsewhere but this world healed, this creation renewed, the very solidity and beauty you love, purified and made permanent, with God dwelling in it and every tear wiped away.

So here is the verdict. The modern world built a frame with no room for the transcendent and then found itself haunted by a longing the frame could not satisfy or name. The escapist gospel offered a transcendent so separate from this world that it, too, drained this world of meaning. And the resurrection breaks the whole false choice, insisting that the transcendent God is coming to dwell in this world, that the ache we feel is homesickness for a renewed creation, and that the longing which no earthly thing satisfies is a signal that we

were made for a world where the earthly is flooded with the glory of God and nothing good is ever lost. Name the ache. It is homesickness for the resurrection. And a people who know what the ache is are free to live in the world in a way the anxious, grasping, disenchanted age cannot, which brings me to the thing that ache drives us toward when we cannot name it, the endless consuming, and how the resurrection frees us from it. Let me take that up, because it is one of the most practical differences the hope makes.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The Endless Wanting and the End of It

*We consume the world to fill a hole the
size of the resurrection, and the world
keeps not fitting.*

I HAVE TO TALK about wanting, because the modern West is organized around it, and I think the resurrection is the only thing large enough to answer it, and this is one of the places where the hope becomes most practical, most Tuesday-shaped, most relevant to the actual texture of your anxious, acquisitive, exhausted life. We live in a consumer culture, and I do not mean that as a throwaway insult, I mean it as a precise description. We have built an entire civilization on the manufacture and multiplication of desire, on making people want things and then want more things, on a machinery of advertising and comparison and endless

novelty designed to keep the wanting going, because the wanting is what the whole economy runs on. And it is exhausting, and it does not satisfy, and almost no one asks why.

The philosopher and social critic Zygmunt Bauman described modern consumer society as one in which we are trained never to be satisfied, in which the point is not to fulfill desire but to keep it perpetually unfulfilled, always reaching for the next thing, because a satisfied consumer is a dead consumer, useless to the machine. And whether or not you accept the whole analysis, you have felt the thing it describes. You get the thing you wanted, and the wanting does not stop, it just relocates to the next thing. The house, the car, the promotion, the experience, the relationship, the achievement, and each one satisfies for a moment and then the hunger returns, undiminished, pointed at something new. We are a people in a permanent state of wanting, and we have organized our whole economy and much of our identity around it, and it is making us anxious and tired and strangely empty in the middle of unprecedented abundance.

Now connect this to the ache I named in the last chapter, because they are the same thing seen from a different angle. The endless wanting is what the unnamed ache becomes when it is misdirected onto the world. The longing that is really homesickness for the resurrection, for a world that does not pass away, gets aimed at things that do pass away, at possessions and experiences and achievements, and of course they cannot satisfy it, because they are finite and the longing is infinite, they are passing and the longing is for permanence. And so we do the only thing the consumer culture teaches us to do, we assume the problem is that we do

not have enough yet, and we reach for more, and the more does not fill the hole either, because the hole is the size of the resurrection and nothing world-sized will fit it. Augustine said it sixteen centuries ago, that our hearts are restless until they rest in God, and the consumer culture is the industrial-scale exploitation of exactly that restlessness, the monetization of a longing that only God can satisfy, sold back to us in a thousand products that promise the rest they can never deliver.

The resurrection ends the endless wanting, not by killing desire but by giving it its true object and its true security. Here is how. First, the resurrection tells you what the wanting is really for. It is not for more stuff. It is for a world that does not pass away, for a renewed creation, for the presence of God, for a life that death cannot touch. Once you know that, you can stop demanding of the finite things a satisfaction they were never able to give, and you can receive them for what they actually are, good gifts, real pleasures, foretastes of the feast, but not the feast itself, not the thing that will finally fill you. That reframing alone breaks the tyranny of the wanting, because the wanting only enslaves you as long as you believe the next thing will finally satisfy it. Once you know the next thing cannot, because the longing is resurrection-sized, you are free from the compulsion to keep reaching, free to enjoy the good things without demanding that they be God.

Second, the resurrection frees you from the fear that drives so much of the accumulation. I said earlier that the fear of death is the hidden engine of human misbehavior, and consumer accumulation is one of its clearest expressions. We hoard and grasp and build in part because we are afraid, afraid of scarcity, afraid of the future, afraid, at bottom, of

death and oblivion, and possessions are a way of insulating ourselves against the fear, of feeling secure, of building a wall of stuff between us and the void. But if the resurrection is true, if death is defeated and your future is a raised body on a renewed earth in the presence of God, then the fear that drives the accumulation is answered at the root, and you can hold your possessions loosely, give generously, live simply, not because you are more disciplined than other people but because you are less afraid, because your security is a resurrection you cannot lose rather than a pile of things that moth and rust destroy.

Let me make this concrete, because a critique of consumerism that stays abstract is just one more consumer good, a bit of intellectual entertainment that changes nothing. What does it look like when the resurrection frees a person from the endless wanting. It looks like generosity, the open hand, the ability to give away money and time and comfort without the panic that you are diminishing yourself, because your true wealth is elsewhere and secure. It looks like contentment, the ancient and nearly extinct virtue, the ability to say enough, to be satisfied with what you have, to stop reaching, because you know the reaching was always aimed at something no possession could provide. It looks like simplicity, not as a performance or a trend but as a natural consequence of no longer needing your stuff to save you. And it looks like a strange freedom from comparison, from the exhausting measuring of your life against everyone else's, because your worth and your future are secured by the resurrection and not by whether you are keeping up, and a person whose future is guaranteed by the empty tomb has nothing to prove and no one to keep up with.

I have to implicate myself here, because I am writing this

from inside a consumer culture and inside a consumer heart, and I am not exempt. I feel the wanting. I feel the pull to acquire, to compare, to build the wall of security, to reach for the next thing as if it would finally satisfy. Believing in the resurrection has not made me immune to any of it, and I distrust any preacher who claims otherwise. What it has done is give me a place to stand when I notice the wanting, a truth to preach to myself, a way of catching the misdirected longing and pointing it back at its true object. When I feel the endless reaching, I try to remember what it is really reaching for, and I try to let the finite things be finite, good but not God, and I fail at this often, and I come back to it, because the alternative is to be run by the wanting forever, and I have tasted enough of the freedom to know I do not want to go back.

So here is the verdict. The consumer culture runs on a longing it deliberately keeps unsatisfied, and the longing is really homesickness for the resurrection, misdirected onto things that cannot bear its weight. We consume the world to fill a hole the size of the new creation, and the world keeps not fitting, and so we reach for more, forever. The resurrection ends the endless wanting, not by killing desire but by naming its true object and securing its true future, so that the finite things can be received as the good gifts they are without being demanded to be the God they are not, and the fear that drives the accumulation is answered at the root by a future that death cannot touch. A resurrection people can be content, generous, simple, and free from comparison, not because they are better than the anxious consuming age, but because they are less afraid and less deceived about what they were really wanting all along. And what they were wanting all along, under the stuff and the ache and the reaching, was the thing death seems to take and the

resurrection promises to give back, the people and the world and the life we love. So let me end the argument where it began, at the grave, with the one question that finally matters, what death can and cannot keep.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

What Death Cannot Keep

*Death has taken everyone you love or it
will. The resurrection is the
announcement that death does not get
to keep any of them.*

I WANT TO COME back to the grave, because that is where this book started, at Walter's graveside outside Fenton, and it is right that it should end there too, because the grave is the place where all our theories are tested and most of them fail. Anyone can believe in a comfortable hope in a comfortable room. The question is what your hope does at the graveside, in the presence of the actual body of someone you actually loved, when the theories meet the dirt. And I have been at enough gravesides now to tell you which hopes survive the test and which do not.

The escapist hope does not survive the test, not really, not when you look closely. It offers the comfort that the soul is elsewhere, and that is a real comfort as far as it goes, but it asks you to look at the body in the box and call it a shell, and something in you knows that is a lie, because that is not a shell, that is the hand that held yours, that is the face you kissed, that is the person, and to call it a shell is to let death win the argument about what a human being is. The escapist hope, at the graveside, ends up agreeing with death that the body does not matter, that the person has already essentially escaped the thing in the box, and so it offers comfort at the price of denying the full horror of what death has done, which means it offers comfort at the price of a lie, and lies do not finally comfort, they only postpone.

The secular hope does not survive the test either, and I say this with sympathy, having held it. The secular hope, at the graveside, offers nothing, or it offers the cold consolation that the person lives on in memory, in the difference they made, in the atoms that return to the earth and are recycled into new life. And there is a kind of dignity in facing the void without flinching, and I respect the honesty of the secularist who refuses false comfort. But it is a hope that offers no hope, a consolation that consoles only by lowering your expectations to nothing, and it asks you to stand at the grave of the person you cannot live without and accept that they are simply gone, erased, finished, that the love was real but the loss is total and final and meaningless. And the human heart, standing at that grave, protests, because it cannot believe that love this real ends in erasure this complete, and the secular hope has no answer to the protest except to call it wishful thinking and tell you to grow up.

Only the resurrection survives the test at the graveside,

and it survives because it is the only hope that refuses both lies, the lie that the body does not matter and the lie that the loss is final. The resurrection stands at the grave and it does not call the body a shell. It calls it a seed. It agrees with your protesting heart that this is the person, the whole person, body and all, and that death has done something monstrous and real in taking them. It does not minimize the horror. And then, having agreed that death has done its worst, it makes the one claim that can actually answer the grave. It says death does not get to keep them. It says the body in the ground is a seed and the God who plants does not lose His seed, and there is a morning coming when the graves will open and the sea will give up its dead and the person you buried will come up, not as a memory, not as a ghost, not as a recycled arrangement of atoms, but as themselves, raised, whole, healed, in a body you can hold, on an earth that does not die, and you will never have to let go again.

Think about what death takes and then think about what the resurrection gives back. Death takes the body, and the resurrection gives back the body, raised and glorified. Death takes the person from the world, and the resurrection returns the person to a renewed world. Death takes the future you would have had with them, all the years and the ordinary days and the conversations and the presence, and the resurrection gives back a future with them longer than any you could have had here, unbounded, unthreatened, on the far side of the last enemy that will trouble you no more. Death takes the touch, the voice, the face, the embodied particular presence of the beloved, and the resurrection promises the touch and the voice and the face restored, because it is a resurrection of the body and not merely a survival of the soul. Everything death takes, the resurrection gives back, and

more, purified of everything that marred it, freed from the possibility of ever being taken again. Death is a robber, but it is a robber whose loot is going to be reclaimed, every last piece of it, down to the last body in the last grave.

Let me say the thing about reunion plainly, because it is what people most want to know and what pastors are often too cautious to say. Will I see them again. Will I know them. Will I hold them. And the answer of the resurrection, the answer of the New Testament, is yes. Not as a sentimental hope but as a promise grounded in an empty tomb. Paul comforts the grieving Thessalonians precisely with reunion, telling them that the dead in Christ will rise and that we will be caught up together with them, and, he says, so we will always be with the Lord, and together, all of us, the living and the raised dead, reunited, never to be parted again. The reunion is not a soft consolation the Bible offers to soften the blow. It is the explicit promise. You will see them again. You will know them, because the resurrection preserves the person in continuity, the same person raised, not dissolved into some anonymous bliss. And you will be together, embodied, on the renewed earth, in the presence of God, and death, which parted you, will be no more, and the parting will be undone, and you will never say goodbye again.

I think of the people I have buried, and I think of the people I will bury, and I think of my own body going into the ground someday, and I hold all of it up against this promise, and it holds. It is the only thing I have found that holds. When I stand at a graveside now, I do not tell the family the body is a shell, because it is not, and I do not tell them the loss is final, because it is not. I tell them what is true, which is harder and better than either lie. I tell them death has done a real and terrible thing, and it is right to grieve it with your whole body,

and also, and at the same time, death does not get to keep what it has taken, because the tomb outside Jerusalem is empty, and the one who rose is the firstfruits of a harvest that includes this body in this ground, and there is a morning coming, a real morning on a real remade earth, when this grave will give back what it took, and you will hold on and never let go, and God Himself will wipe the tears from your face with His own hand.

So here is the verdict, and it is the verdict this whole book has been building toward. Death has taken everyone you love, or it will. That is the one certainty, the appointment none of us miss, the robber that visits every house. And the resurrection is the announcement, grounded in history, staked on an empty tomb, that death does not get to keep any of them. Not the body. Not the person. Not the future. Not the touch or the voice or the face. Not one of them. Death is a robber whose every theft is going to be reversed, a jailer whose every prisoner is going to be freed, an enemy whose every victory is going to be turned inside out on a morning that is coming as surely as the sun. What death cannot keep is everything. That is the hope the church traded for an escape, and it is time to trade it back. Let me gather it all up now, and say the last word, and send you out to live in the light of a morning you have not yet seen.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The Resurrection on a Tuesday Afternoon

A hope that only shows up at funerals is too small. The resurrection is supposed to change what you do with an ordinary Tuesday.

THE TAGLINE OF EVERYTHING I try to do as a pastor is connecting the depth of theology to the weight of everyday life, and I have spent this whole book on the depth, on the theology of the resurrection and the new creation, and now I owe you the weight of everyday life, the Tuesday afternoon, because if this hope only shows up at funerals it is not the hope the New Testament describes. The New Testament resurrection is not a doctrine for deathbeds. It is a power for Tuesdays. So let me get specific and ordinary, more ordinary than I have been, and show you what the resurrection does to

a normal week in a normal life, because that is where you actually live, not at gravesides but at kitchen tables and desks and in traffic and in the ten thousand small choices that make up a life.

Start with your work, the thing you spend most of your waking hours doing, the thing that so often feels meaningless, a treadmill, a way of paying bills until you can retire and then die. The escapist gospel has nothing to say to your work except that it is a necessary evil, a way of surviving in a doomed world until the real thing starts in heaven. But the resurrection, as I argued earlier, tells you your work is a rehearsal for the vocation of the new creation, that when you do good work well, honestly, with care, you are practicing the kind of work you will do gloriously forever, and that the good in your work is not wasted but somehow taken up into the world God is making. So on Tuesday afternoon, when your work feels pointless, the resurrection gives you a reason to do it well anyway, not for the paycheck, not to impress anyone, but because good work is a small anticipation of the world that is coming, and the God who is going to renew all things cares whether you did your work with excellence and love. That teacher grading papers, that nurse changing a dressing, that mechanic fixing an engine right, that parent making a meal, is not killing time. They are apprenticing for eternity, and it dignifies the most ordinary labor to know it.

Take your body, the one you live in every Tuesday, the one you probably neglect or resent or use badly. The escapist gospel tells you the body is a shell, a temporary suit, and so how you treat it does not finally matter. The resurrection tells you the body is destined for glory, a temple of the Spirit, the very thing God is going to raise, and so how you treat it

matters enormously, not out of vanity but out of reverence. On Tuesday that means you honor the body, you rest it and feed it and move it and do not defile it, not because you are earning anything but because you are caring for something God is going to raise. And it means you honor other bodies too, the bodies of the people you encounter on an ordinary day, the tired cashier, the annoying coworker, the difficult neighbor, because every one of them is a body destined for either resurrection or judgment, an image-bearer, a temple, and there are no ordinary people, as Lewis said in that same 1941 sermon, no mere mortals, everyone you meet is an immortal, a creature whose destiny is glory or horror, and you have never talked to a mere mortal in your life. That changes how you treat the person in front of you on a Tuesday.

Take your grief, because grief does not confine itself to funerals, it visits on ordinary Tuesdays too, in the sudden memory, the empty chair, the anniversary, the song on the radio. The resurrection gives you permission to feel it fully, to weep on a Tuesday afternoon if the grief comes, without pretending you should be over it, and it gives you a floor under the weeping, the knowledge that the loss is real but not final. So on an ordinary day, when the grief ambushes you, you do not have to run from it or perform strength you do not feel. You can let it come, and weep if you need to, and then stand up on the resurrection, on the morning that is coming, and go on with your day, grieving and hoping at once, which is the only way a Christian ever grieves.

Take your fear, the low-grade anxiety that runs under most ordinary days, the fear of the future, of loss, of failure, of death itself hiding under all the smaller fears. The resurrection answers the fear at its root, because the worst thing that can happen to you, death, has already been

defeated, and so the smaller fears lose their ultimate grip. On Tuesday afternoon, when the anxiety rises, the resurrection is a truth you can preach to yourself, that your future is secured beyond death, that the worst has already been undone in advance, that you can afford to be generous and courageous and honest because your survival is not finally at stake. It does not make the anxiety vanish, I am not promising you a magic cure, but it gives you a place to stand against it, a truth larger than the fear, and over time the standing changes you, loosens the grip, frees you to live less defensively, less graspingly, more openly.

Take your relationships, the people you live with and work with and worship with, the ones who irritate you and the ones you love and the ones you have hurt or been hurt by. The resurrection tells you these are eternal people, that the difficult coworker and the aging parent and the exhausting child are all creatures destined for resurrection, and it tells you that the reconciliations you cannot achieve now are not lost but held, that the God who is putting the world right is going to heal the broken relationships you gave up on. So on Tuesday, you treat people as the eternal creatures they are, you forgive because you know the accounts will finally be settled by God and you do not have to settle them yourself, you love because love is the currency of the world that is coming and every act of it is a rehearsal. The resurrection makes the ordinary people around you weightier, more significant, harder to dismiss, because none of them is disposable, all of them are bound for eternity, and how you treat them on an ordinary Tuesday is practice for how you will live with them forever.

And take your rest, because even rest is transformed by the resurrection, and this is one we badly need in an

exhausted age. The Bible frames the final hope partly as rest, a Sabbath rest that remains for the people of God, and it makes the Sabbath, the weekly rest, a foretaste of that final rest, a practice of trusting that the world does not depend on your ceaseless labor, that you can stop, that God holds the world when you put it down. On Tuesday, or more precisely on your Sabbath, whatever day you keep it, you rest not as a mere recovery for more work but as a rehearsal for the rest of the world to come, a weekly declaration that your worth is not your productivity, that you can cease striving because your future is secured by grace and not by grinding. In a culture that cannot stop, that measures worth by output, that runs itself ragged in the endless wanting, the resurrection makes rest an act of faith, a small resistance, a foretaste of the day when the striving is over and the rest is complete.

So here is the verdict, and it is the tagline made flesh. The resurrection is not a doctrine for funerals. It is a power for Tuesdays. It changes how you work, dignifying the most ordinary labor as a rehearsal for eternity. It changes how you treat your body and everyone else's, honoring them as temples destined for glory. It changes how you grieve, giving you permission and a floor. It changes how you fear, answering the anxiety at its root. It changes how you love, making every ordinary person weighty and eternal. And it changes how you rest, making the Sabbath a foretaste of the world to come. If the resurrection only shows up in your life at funerals, you have a doctrine and not a hope. The hope shows up on Tuesday afternoon, in the kitchen and at the desk and in traffic and at the ten thousand small crossroads of an ordinary week, and it changes what you do at every one of them, because a person who really believes the dead are raised lives differently on the most ordinary day. That is the

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

depth of theology connected to the weight of everyday life, and it is the whole point, and it was known and lived, once, by a people I have to tell you about before I finish, because they had this hope in a way we have mostly lost, and their lives were the proof of it.

CHAPTER THIRTY

What the Early Church Knew

*They out-lived and out-died the
empire that despised them, and the
secret was a hope we have shrunk
down to a felt-board.*

I WANT TO END the body of this book by taking you back to the beginning, to the first few centuries of the church, before the Platonic drift, before the escapist reduction, before the clouds and the harps had swallowed the resurrection, because those early Christians held this hope in a way that we have mostly lost, and their lives were the proof of it, and I think seeing them will make you want it the way I want it. They were not perfect, and I am not romanticizing them, but they had something we have traded away, and you can see it in how they lived and how they died and what it did to the

world around them.

Consider first how they died, because the way a people dies reveals what they actually believe. The early Christians were persecuted, off and on, brutally, and many of them were martyred, and the records of their deaths survive, and they are astonishing. They went to their deaths with a composure that baffled and enraged their persecutors, singing, praying, forgiving their executioners, refusing to recant even under torture. Polycarp, the bishop of Smyrna, an old man in the middle of the second century, was brought to the arena and told to curse Christ and save his life, and he said, eighty-six years I have served Him, and He has done me no wrong, how can I blaspheme my King who saved me. And they burned him, and he prayed as he burned. This was not fanaticism and it was not a death wish. It was resurrection. These people were not afraid to die because they believed death was a defeated enemy, that their bodies would be raised, that the worst the empire could do to them was send them ahead to Christ to wait for the morning when their bodies would come up out of whatever the empire had done with them. You cannot terrify a person who believes that, and the empire, which ruled by terror, met in these people a wall it could not break, and it did not understand what it was hitting.

Consider how they lived, because I mentioned this earlier but it bears returning to. When the great plagues swept the cities of the empire, in the second and third centuries, the pagans fled, abandoning even their own sick relatives to die alone, because the fear of death drove them to save themselves. And the Christians stayed. They stayed and nursed the sick, their own and the pagans, at enormous risk, and many of them died doing it, and the sociologist Rodney

Stark, in his 1996 study *The Rise of Christianity*, argued that this was one of the major reasons the faith spread so explosively, because people watched these Christians face the plague without the terror that gripped everyone else, and they wanted what these people had. What these people had was resurrection. They could spend their lives in love, could nurse the dying and risk the contagion, because they were not enslaved by the fear of death, because they believed death was not the end, and so they were free to be reckless with their lives in a way the fearful could not afford. Their ethics flowed directly from their eschatology. Because they believed in the resurrection of the body, they were free to lay their bodies down in love, and the watching world was converted not by argument but by a courage it could not explain.

Consider what they believed about the body and the earth, because it was robustly physical in a way that later Christianity often was not. They confessed the resurrection of the body against the Greek world that found it disgusting, and they meant it, the flesh raised, the body redeemed. They fought the various movements, the ones we broadly call Gnostic, that tried to make Christianity into a religion of escape from the material world, a secret knowledge that freed the spiritual soul from the evil prison of matter. The early church fought those movements ferociously, and they won, and the victory is why we have a Bible that begins with a good creation and ends with a renewed one rather than a doctrine of escape from an evil material world. Men like Irenaeus, writing around 180, insisted against the escapists that the same God made the world and redeemed it, that the flesh was good and would be raised, that salvation was the healing of creation and not the flight from it. They understood, better than we have, that the whole gospel hung on the goodness of

matter and the resurrection of the body, and they defended it against exactly the escapism that would later creep back in through a subtler door.

And consider what it did to the world, because a hope this size does not stay private. The early Christians, holding this robust resurrection hope, began to do things the ancient world had never seen. They cared for the poor systematically, not as occasional charity but as a way of life, because they believed the poor were image-bearers destined for glory. They took in abandoned infants, the ones the Roman world left exposed to die, especially the girls, because they believed those tiny bodies were eternal creatures beloved of God. They dignified women and slaves in ways that scandalized their culture, because they believed the resurrection was coming for those bodies too. They built, over centuries, out of this hope, the very ideas of human dignity and the care of the vulnerable that the modern secular world now takes for granted and imagines it invented. The historian Tom Holland, not himself a conventional believer, argued in his 2019 book *Dominion* that the moral instincts the modern West is most proud of, the concern for the weak, the dignity of every person, the suspicion of power, are not natural or universal but are the long downstream effects of exactly this Christian revolution, the conviction that every human body, however lowly, is loved by God and destined for resurrection. The world we live in was shaped by people who believed the dead would rise, and the shape remains even where the belief has faded.

Now I have to be honest and not romantic, because the early church was also flawed, divided, sometimes wrong, capable of its own failures, and I am not calling us back to a golden age that never fully existed. But on this one thing, the

size and the physicality and the world-shaping power of their hope, they had what we have largely lost, and I think we can see, by looking at them, both what the hope is supposed to do and how far we have drifted from it. They out-lived and out-died the empire that despised them, and the secret was not a superior technique or a better organization or a more compelling argument. The secret was a hope so large and so physical and so certain that it made them fearless in the face of death and reckless in love and unstoppable in the face of power, and that hope was the resurrection of the body and the renewal of all things, the very hope the later church shrank down to a disembodied heaven and a felt-board and a harp on a cloud.

So here is the verdict, and it is a summons. The early church knew something we have forgotten, and you can see it in how they died and how they lived and what they did to the world. They held the full resurrection hope, robust and physical and certain, and it made them a people the empire could not break and the plague could not scatter and the culture could not co-opt, a people whose courage in death and recklessness in love converted a hostile world not by argument but by the visible evidence of a hope too large to be explained any other way. We have that same hope written in our creeds, buried under centuries of Platonic drift, waiting to be recovered. The early church is not a golden age to sentimentalize. It is a witness to what this hope does when a people actually believes it, and it is a rebuke to how small we have let it become, and it is an invitation to want it again, at full size, the way they had it. They believed the dead would rise, and it made them unafraid to die and free to love, and it changed the world. So can we. But before I gather it all up, there are two more objections I have to face honestly, because

HEAVEN IS NOT YOUR REWARD

I have written toward the believer for many pages now and I owe the skeptic and the doubter the same care I promised at the start. Let me take up the hardest thing a skeptic throws at this hope, and then the hardest thing a doubting Christian carries, before I say the last word.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The Skeptic's Hardest Question

The strongest objection to the resurrection is not that it is impossible. It is that it is too good, and we are right to be suspicious of hopes that convenient.

I HAVE WRITTEN TOWARD believers for many chapters, and I want to turn now and write directly to the skeptic, the reader who has followed all of this with respect and remains unconvinced, because I promised at the start that this reader would be met and not handled, and I meant it, and I was that reader once. So let me state the skeptic's hardest objection in its strongest form, the form the skeptic himself would sign, before I say anything in answer, because a bad case for a true

thing helps no one and I would rather lose the skeptic honestly than keep him by cheating.

The hardest objection is not the one people usually name. It is not that miracles are impossible, because the honest skeptic knows that ruling out miracles in advance is not an argument but an assumption, a decision made before looking at the evidence, and the more thoughtful unbeliever does not want to reason in a circle. The hardest objection is subtler and it is this. The resurrection hope is exactly, suspiciously, precisely what a frightened human being would invent. We fear death, so we invent a defeat of death. We grieve our dead, so we invent a reunion. We cannot bear the erasure of everyone we love, so we invent a morning when the graves give back what they took. The whole thing maps so perfectly onto our deepest wishes that any honest person should be suspicious of it, because when the answer to your fear is precisely the thing you most wish were true, the most likely explanation is not that reality happens to be shaped like your wish, but that you have shaped your belief to fit your wish. The resurrection is too convenient. It is what we would invent. And that, not the impossibility of miracles, is the strongest reason to doubt it, and I want the skeptic to know that I feel the full weight of it, because I felt it as an unbeliever and I have not forgotten how heavy it is.

Let me not answer it too quickly, because a quick answer would insult the objection and the person making it. There is real force here. Human beings do invent comforting stories. The history of religion is full of wish-projection, of gods made in the image of human hope and fear, and the honest believer has to admit that much religion is exactly the wishful thinking the skeptic suspects. Sigmund Freud, in his 1927

book *The Future of an Illusion*, made this case with great power, that religious belief is the projection of the child's longing for a protective father onto the cosmos, wish-fulfillment dressed as revelation, and I have to tell you that as a fatherless boy who became a believer, I have felt the full sharpness of that particular knife, because the objection seems custom-built for me. The fatherless man who comes to believe in a heavenly Father is Freud's case study walking around. I know that. I have sat with it. And I will not pretend it away, because pretending it away would be exactly the dishonesty the skeptic rightly despises.

But here is what I found when I sat with it honestly, and I offer it not as a knockdown but as the thing that actually moved me. The wish-fulfillment objection cuts, but it does not cut where the skeptic thinks. Because notice what it can and cannot do. The fact that I wish something were true has no bearing whatsoever on whether it is true. A starving man wishes for food, and his wish does not prove there is no food. A frightened child wishes his father would come home, and sometimes the father actually comes home. The wish and the reality are not opposites, and the presence of a wish tells you exactly nothing about whether the wished-for thing exists. So the wish-fulfillment objection, pressed to its logic, does not show the resurrection is false. It shows only that we would want it to be true, which we already knew, and which is equally compatible with its being true and its being false. To move from we wish it were true to therefore it is not true is itself a logical error, the genetic fallacy, judging a claim by the psychology of those who hold it rather than by the evidence for it. And the evidence, remember, is the thing I could not make go away, the empty tomb and the witnesses and the explosion of the church, the historical particulars that do not

become less real because I happen to wish the conclusion were comforting.

And there is more, and this is the part that finally turned the objection around in my hands. C.S. Lewis noticed, and I have come to think he was right, that the argument from desire can be run in the other direction. The very fact that we have a desire that no earthly thing satisfies, a hunger for a world that does not die, is itself a strange datum that the wish-fulfillment theory struggles to explain. A hunger, Lewis observed, generally corresponds to a real thing that satisfies it. We get hungry and there is such a thing as food. We get thirsty and there is such a thing as water. We feel sexual desire and there is such a thing as sex. And we feel this other hunger, this longing for a life beyond death, for a world that does not pass away, and the wish-fulfillment theory says this one hunger, alone among all our hungers, corresponds to nothing at all, is a cruel evolutionary accident, a hunger for food in a universe with no food. That is possible. But it is at least worth noticing that it would make this one desire uniquely deceptive, and that the alternative, that the hunger points to a real satisfaction as all our other hungers do, is not obviously the more superstitious reading. The wish might be evidence rather than illusion. I do not claim this proves anything. I claim only that the wish-fulfillment objection, which looked like a killing blow, turns out to be double-edged, and the skeptic who wields it should at least notice that it can cut the other way.

So where does that leave the skeptic, honestly. Not, I think, compelled to believe, and I will not pretend otherwise or manufacture an urgency I promised at the start to refuse. It leaves the skeptic exactly where I was, unable to use the wish-fulfillment objection to dismiss the historical evidence,

because the wish and the fact are independent, and unable to be sure the longing is mere illusion, because the longing might be a signal. It leaves the skeptic having to actually weigh the historical case for the resurrection on its own terms, the empty tomb and the witnesses and the rest, rather than waving it away with a psychological theory about why believers believe. And that is all I ever ask of the skeptic, the thing I finally could not refuse myself, to look at the evidence honestly rather than to dismiss it in advance because the conclusion happens to be one we would want. The win, as I said at the beginning, is not that the skeptic agrees with me. The win is that the skeptic cannot accuse me of dishonesty, that he finishes thinking, I do not believe this, but I can no longer pretend that believing it is stupid, or that it is nothing more than a frightened man's wish. And from that honest place, which is exactly where I stood, the tomb is still there, empty, waiting to be reckoned with, and it will not go away because we would prefer it did not exist any more than it went away because I preferred it did not exist. So here is the verdict, offered to the skeptic as one who was one. The resurrection is too good to be true, and that is not an argument against it, because the goodness of a thing has no bearing on its reality, and the deepest desire of the human heart might, just might, be homesickness for a home that is actually there. Now let me turn to the believer's version of the same struggle, the doubt that lives inside the faith, because the skeptic outside the church and the doubter inside it are closer than either usually admits.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

When You Cannot Feel the Hope

*There is a difference between not
believing the resurrection and not
being able to feel it, and the church has
shamed too many people for the second
as if it were the first.*

I HAVE TO WRITE a chapter for the Christian who believes all of this and cannot feel any of it, because I have been that Christian, and I have pastored hundreds of them, and the church has too often had nothing to say to them except to question whether their faith is real. The resurrection is true, they believe it, they would affirm every word of this book, and yet at the graveside, or in the dark at three in the morning, or in the long gray stretch of an ordinary depressed week, they

cannot feel it, the hope is a fact in their heads that does not reach their chests, and they wonder if something is wrong with them, if their faith is defective, if a real Christian would feel the comfort they cannot summon. I want to speak to that person with particular tenderness, because their struggle is real and the church has too often made it worse.

Let me begin by distinguishing two things the church constantly confuses, to the great harm of doubting believers. There is a difference between not believing the resurrection and not being able to feel it. Belief is a matter of what you are convinced is true, what you would stake your life on, what you affirm when someone asks you what is real. Feeling is a matter of what your emotions are doing on a given day, and feelings are governed by a thousand things, sleep and grief and brain chemistry and circumstance and the weather, that have nothing to do with what you believe. You can believe the resurrection with your whole mind and feel nothing, and that is not a failure of faith, it is the ordinary condition of embodied creatures whose feelings do not obey their convictions. The church has too often treated the absence of feeling as the absence of faith, has shamed people for a dry heart as if it were an unbelieving one, and it is a cruelty born of not understanding the difference, and I have been guilty of it myself before I learned better, usually the hard way, in my own dry seasons.

Consider the greatest saints, because they knew this dryness and it did not disqualify them, and knowing that has saved more than one believer from despair. When the letters of Mother Teresa were published after her death, in the 2007 collection *Come Be My Light*, the world was shocked to discover that this woman, this luminous icon of faith, had

spent most of her decades of ministry in a profound spiritual darkness, unable to feel the presence of the God she served, praying into what felt like emptiness, believing without the consolation of feeling. Some sneered that this proved her faith was a sham. They had it exactly backward. It proved her faith was real, because she served and believed and gave her life to Christ for decades without the emotional reward, on the bare conviction that He was real and worth it even when she could not feel Him. That is not weak faith. That is faith at its strongest, faith stripped of feeling and standing anyway, faith that trusts the fact when the feeling has gone. The dark night of the soul, as the mystics called it, is not the absence of faith but sometimes its deepest exercise, believing in the light while standing in the dark.

So if you are the believer who cannot feel the hope, the first thing I want to tell you is that you are in the best possible company, and that your dry heart is not evidence against your faith, and that you should stop letting anyone, including yourself, treat the absence of feeling as the absence of belief. The resurrection is true whether or not you can feel it, and your faith is real whether or not it warms you, and there are seasons, sometimes long ones, when the hope is a fact you hold in the dark rather than a fire you feel in the chest, and holding the fact in the dark is faith, is perhaps the truest faith there is, because it is stripped of every reward except the truth itself.

Let me say something practical, because I do not want to leave you only comforted, I want to leave you with something to do. When you cannot feel the hope, you preach it to yourself, out loud if you have to, the way you would tell a hard truth to a frightened friend. You say the facts even when they do not move you. The tomb is empty. Christ is risen. The dead

will rise. God will wipe away every tear. You say them not because you feel them but because they are true, and you let the saying be an act of faith rather than a report of feeling. And you lean on the community, on the church, on the people who can believe for you when you cannot believe for yourself, because the faith was never meant to be carried alone, and there are seasons when you hold up the hope for others and seasons when they hold it up for you, and the church at its best is a people passing the hope back and forth so that no one has to feel it all the time for it to remain true. When you cannot sing, you stand in the congregation and let them sing it over you, and it is still yours even when you cannot make the sound.

And I want to be careful and pastoral about the darkest version of this, because some of you reading are not merely dry but are in real despair, and I will not pretend a chapter fixes that. If the inability to feel the hope has become a heaviness that does not lift, a darkness that colors everything, a weight that makes it hard to get up, then I want to say plainly that this may be more than a spiritual dryness, that depression is real and is not a sin and is not a failure of faith, and that the God who made your body has provided help through those He has given the skill to heal, and that reaching for that help, a doctor, a counselor, a friend, is not a failure of trust but an act of the same faith that trusts God to work through means. Do not suffer alone in the dark believing you are the only one, because you are not, and do not believe the despair when it tells you the hope is not for you, because it is lying, and the resurrection is as true for the person who cannot feel it as for the person who can, and God does not love you less because your heart has gone dark. Keep a path to real help visible, and walk it, because the God who is going

to raise your body is not indifferent to it now.

So here is the verdict, for the believer who cannot feel the hope, and I mean it as gently as anything in this book. The resurrection does not require your feelings to cooperate in order to be true, and your faith does not require your feelings to cooperate in order to be real. There is a difference between not believing and not feeling, and the church has shamed too many people for the second as if it were the first, and I am asking you to stop letting anyone do that to you, including yourself. You can believe in the dark. You can hold the fact when the feeling is gone. You can preach the empty tomb to your own cold heart and let the community sing the hope over you when you cannot sing it, and it is still yours, all of it, the morning and the reunion and the hand that wipes away tears, as true for you in your dryness as for anyone in their joy. The hope does not depend on your ability to feel it. It depends on a tomb that was empty on a specific morning, and that tomb is empty whether your heart is warm or cold, and the morning is coming whether you can feel it tonight or not. So hold on in the dark. The dawn does not need your permission, and it is not far. And now, having met the skeptic and the doubter both, there is one last shape of this hope I have to trace before I gather it all up, because I have spent this book arguing against a picture and I owe you, at the end, a clear account of what the picture should have been all along, said as plainly as I can say it, so that you can hand it to someone else. Let me say what heaven actually is.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

What Heaven Actually Is

Heaven is not a place you go. It is the presence of God, and its future is to come down and fill the earth.

I HAVE SPENT THIS whole book telling you what the Christian hope is not, and I have said the word heaven mostly in order to correct how it is used, and I owe you now, before the end, a plain and positive account of what heaven actually is in the Bible, because I do not want to leave you thinking I have simply thrown the word out. I have not. Heaven is a real and biblical word for a real and glorious thing. The problem was never the word. The problem was the picture we poured into it, and I want to pour the right one in, so plainly that you could explain it to a child or a skeptic or a grieving friend.

Start with what heaven is not, one more time, because the false picture is stubborn. Heaven, in the Bible, is not a location up above the sky where disembodied souls go to float

forever, playing harps on clouds, in a purely spiritual existence far removed from the material world. That is the picture we inherited, and it is Greek, not biblical, and I have spent thirty-two chapters showing why. Whenever you catch yourself imagining the hope as souls-in-the-sky, forever separate from bodies and earth, you have the wrong picture, and it will quietly poison your grief and your ethics and your love of the world, in all the ways I have traced. So let me replace it.

Here is what heaven actually is in the Bible. Heaven is, first and most basically, the dimension of reality where God dwells, God's own space, the sphere of His presence and rule, as distinct from earth, which is our space, the created sphere we inhabit. The Bible does not picture heaven as a faraway location at the top of the universe, millions of light-years up. It pictures heaven as God's dimension, interlocking with ours at every point, present and near but ordinarily veiled from us, the realm from which God rules and in which His will is done perfectly. When Jesus taught us to pray thy kingdom come, thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven, He was contrasting the two dimensions, heaven where God's will is done perfectly and earth where it is not yet, and He was teaching us to pray for the two to be joined, for heaven's perfect reality to come and fill and heal the earth. Heaven is not where we escape to. Heaven is where God's rule is complete, and the whole prayer of the church is that this rule would come down and fill the earth.

And that is exactly what the Bible promises will happen at the end, and this is the plain positive picture I want you to carry. The end of the story is not that earth is abandoned and we go up to heaven. The end of the story is that heaven and earth, God's dimension and ours, so long separated by our

rebellion and the fall, are finally joined, married, made one, so that God dwells fully with His people on the renewed earth. That is what Revelation 21 shows, the New Jerusalem, which is heaven, God's dwelling, coming down out of heaven to the earth, so that the dwelling of God is with man, the two dimensions united at last, God's space and our space become one space, filled with His presence, healed of every wound. Heaven does not stay separate and we do not fly off to it. Heaven comes down and fills the earth, and the joining of the two is the whole hope.

So what about the dead, the ones with Christ now, the intermediate state I defended earlier. Here is the plain account. When a believer dies, they go to be with Christ, in heaven, in God's dimension, and that is real and conscious and good and comforting, and I will say it at your funeral without hesitation. That is heaven in the sense of where the faithful dead are now, present with God, at rest, awaiting the end. But that state, being in heaven with Christ, is not the final hope. It is the intermediate state, the front porch, the waiting. The final hope is not to stay in heaven as a disembodied soul forever. The final hope is the resurrection, when heaven comes down and the dead are raised bodily and God dwells with His people on the renewed earth. So heaven is real, and the dead are in it now with Christ, and it is not the end, because heaven's destiny is not to be a permanent alternative to earth but to come down and be joined to a renewed earth, and the destiny of the souls in heaven now is not to float there forever but to be reunited with raised bodies on that renewed earth when the two dimensions are made one.

Do you see how this holds everything together, how it keeps the true comfort and adds the fuller hope. It lets me tell

the grieving widow that her husband is in heaven with Christ, which is true and precious, and it lets me tell her that this is not the end, that heaven is coming down, that his body is coming up, that the two of them will be reunited not as ghosts in the sky but as raised people on the renewed earth, which is truer and more precious still. It keeps the word heaven, honors it, fills it with its real biblical meaning, the dimension of God's presence, and it refuses to let heaven be shrunk into a disembodied escape, because heaven's own destiny is to come down and fill the earth. The false picture kept heaven and lost the earth and the body. The true picture keeps heaven and gains the earth and the body, because it understands that heaven was never meant to be our permanent escape from the world but God's dwelling that is coming to renew the world.

Let me put it as plainly as I can, in a way you could hand to anyone. Heaven is where God is. Right now, heaven and earth are separate, God's dimension and ours, and that separation is the ache under everything. When a believer dies, they go to be with God in heaven, which is real and good, but it is not the end. The end is when heaven comes down and joins earth, when God's dwelling fills the world, when the dead are raised in bodies and the earth is renewed and God lives with His people and wipes away every tear. So you are not going to heaven to stay there forever as a floating soul. You are going to be with Christ when you die, and then, at the end, heaven is coming to you, coming down, filling the earth, raising your body, making all things new. Heaven is not a place you escape to. It is the presence of God, and its future is to come down and fill the earth, and yours.

So here is the verdict, the plain positive account I owed you before the end. The word heaven is good and biblical and

I am not throwing it out. What I am throwing out is the picture of heaven as a faraway location where disembodied souls escape the world forever. Heaven is the dimension of God's presence, near and now veiled, where the faithful dead are with Christ, and its destiny is not to remain a separate escape but to come down and be joined to a renewed earth, so that God dwells with His people, bodily raised, on a world made new. That is what heaven actually is, and understanding it rightly keeps every comfort the false picture offered and adds every glory the false picture lost. Heaven is real. It is just not what you were told, and what it actually is turns out to be bigger and better and more solid than the clouds and the harps, because its future is not up and away but down and toward, coming to earth, coming to you, on the morning the whole book has been walking toward. And there is one more question that always comes at exactly this point, from pastors and skeptics alike, and I have to answer it before I can say the last word, because if I do not, the whole book can be heard as a call to abandon the very souls it claims to love. If the hope is a renewed earth and not an escape to heaven, then why bother telling anyone the gospel at all. Let me answer that, because it is the question that decides whether this recovery builds the church or empties it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

If Not Escape, Then Why Evangelize

*The gospel was never a rescue ticket off
a doomed planet. It was always the
announcement that the King has come
to make the world new, and you are
invited to belong to it now.*

I HAVE TO ANSWER the objection that a recovering pastor will feel most sharply, because I have felt it, and I have watched good men resist this whole recovery precisely because they feared where it led. If the hope is not escape from earth to heaven but the renewal of the earth, if we are not fundamentally rescuing souls off a sinking ship, then what happens to evangelism, to the urgent call to repent and believe, to the missionary passion that has driven the church

for two thousand years. Does the recovery of resurrection quietly gut the gospel of its urgency, turn the church into a social improvement society, and leave the lost to fend for themselves. It is a serious objection, and I owe it a serious answer, because if the recovery of resurrection empties the church of its missionary heart, then whatever its exegetical merits, it has done more harm than good.

Let me first grant what is true in the fear, because there is a real danger here and I will not pretend otherwise. It is possible to take the renewal-of-creation emphasis and let it swallow the call to personal faith, to become so focused on justice and the earth and the healing of society that the church forgets to call individuals to repentance and faith in the crucified and risen Christ, forgets that people are lost and need to be found, forgets that there is a judgment and a cross and a decision. That has happened. There are churches that traded the call to conversion for a program of social improvement and lost the gospel in the process, that became indistinguishable from a well-meaning nonprofit with a steeple, and that is a real error and I want no part of it. So the fear is not baseless. The recovery of resurrection can be misused to empty the gospel of its call. I concede that fully.

But watch what the recovery actually does when it is held rightly, because it does not shrink evangelism, it enlarges it, and this is the thing I most want the anxious pastor to see. The escapist gospel had a genuinely urgent evangelism, and I honor the urgency, but its content was thin. Its message was essentially, you are going to die and your soul will go to heaven or hell, so believe in Jesus to get the right destination. Souls as tickets, faith as the rescue from a doomed world. And that message is not false exactly, there is a judgment and

faith does save, but it is a fragment, a shrunken piece of the whole gospel, and it produced a shrunken kind of convert, one whose faith was fundamentally about securing a personal exit and who therefore had little reason to care about the body, the earth, justice, or this life at all. The escapist evangelism saved souls for heaven and left them useless for earth.

The resurrection evangelism is not less urgent. It is more urgent, and it is about something far larger than a personal exit. Its message is this. The King has come. The crucified and risen Jesus is the true Lord of the world, death is defeated, the new creation has begun in His resurrection, and God is going to renew the whole world and raise the dead and dwell with His people on a healed earth, and you, right now, are invited to turn from your rebellion, to be forgiven at the cross, to be joined to the risen Christ, to belong to the new creation that has already begun, to be raised on the last day, and to live now, in the interval, as a citizen of the world that is coming. That is not a smaller call than the escapist one. It is an infinitely larger call, and it is more urgent, not less, because it is not merely about where your soul goes when you die but about whether you belong to the new creation or are left in the old one that is passing away, whether you are raised to life or fall under judgment, whether you spend this life as a rehearser of the coming kingdom or a citizen of a rebellion that is being overthrown.

And notice what the resurrection call requires that the escapist call did not. The escapist call ended at the personal transaction, the soul secured, the ticket punched, and then the convert was largely left to wait for death. The resurrection call does not end there, because to be joined to the risen Christ is to be enlisted in His mission, to become part of the

people who bring heaven to earth in preview, who work and love and pursue justice and care for the body and the earth as rehearsal for the coming kingdom. The resurrection convert is not a rescued passenger waiting for the lifeboat. They are a citizen of the new creation with a job to do in the interval. So the recovery of resurrection does not empty the church of its mission. It gives the church a mission far larger than the escapist gospel ever imagined, a mission that includes the urgent call to personal faith and does not stop there, that saves souls and then puts the saved to work rehearsing the world that is coming.

Let me be concrete about how this changes the way we call people, because I am a pastor and I actually do this. When I share the gospel now, I do not lead with you are going to die and here is how to get to heaven, though death and judgment are real and I do not hide them. I lead with something bigger and truer. There is a God who made the world good and loves it, and the world has gone wrong, and you have gone wrong, and God has not written the world off but has come, in Jesus, to put it right, and He died to bear the judgment your rebellion deserves and rose to begin the renewal of everything, and He is coming back to finish it, and you are invited, right now, to turn from your rebellion and be forgiven and joined to the risen Christ and belong to the new world that is coming, to be raised on the last day and to live now as a citizen of that kingdom. That is a bigger invitation than a ticket to heaven, and I have found that it lands with more force, not less, especially on the skeptic, because it is not asking them merely to secure a private afterlife but to join the remaking of the world, and the human heart, even the skeptical one, aches to be part of something that large.

So here is the verdict, and I say it to the pastor most of all,

because the pastor is the one who will decide whether this recovery builds the church or empties it. The recovery of resurrection does not gut evangelism. It enlarges it. It does not remove the urgency of the call to faith. It deepens it, because the stakes are not merely where your soul goes but whether you belong to the new creation or the old order that is passing away. It does not turn the church into a social improvement society, unless it is held badly and allowed to swallow the call to personal faith, which I refuse to let it do. Held rightly, it produces converts who are not rescued passengers waiting to die but citizens of the coming kingdom put to work in the interval, and that is a fuller conversion and a larger gospel and a more urgent mission than the escapist ticket ever offered. The gospel was never a rescue ticket off a doomed planet. It was always the announcement that the King has come to make the world new, and that you are invited to belong to that world now, forgiven at the cross, joined to the risen Christ, raised on the last day, dwelling with God on a renewed earth forever. Preach that, and preach it urgently, because it is true and the stakes could not be higher, and it will not empty your church, it will give it a hope large enough to be worth a life. And now, at last, having answered the skeptic and the doubter and the anxious pastor, I can say the last word, and gather up everything, and send you out to live in the light of a morning you have not yet seen but that is as certain as the sun.

CONCLUSION

The Morning You Have Not Yet Seen

I HAVE TO END where I began, at the graveside outside Fenton, with the farmer in the box and his brother saying the thing the church has been saying too long, this is just the shell, he is up in heaven now, far from all this. I stood there and felt the whole weight of the trade we made, and I have spent this entire book trying to name it and trace it and reverse it, and now, at the end, I want to tell you what I wish I had said that day, what I would say now, what I say now at every graveside I am given the terrible privilege to stand beside.

I would tell the brother that he was right about more than he knew and wrong about less than he feared. He was right that his brother is safe, right that death did not get the last word, right that they will be together again. But he was wrong to call the body a shell, and the wrongness cost him more than he understood, because it made him agree with death about what his brother was, made him hand over to the enemy the very thing the gospel came to reclaim. That is not

a shell. That is Walter, the whole of him, the calloused hands and the slow talk and the body that loved that ground, and it is not being discarded, it is being planted, and the God who planted it does not lose His seed. There is a morning coming, I would say, a real morning on this real earth remade, when that grave gives back what it took, and Walter comes up out of the ground he loved, in a body, healed, incapable of dying again, and stands on soil that does not die, under the reign of the God who made it and became a body Himself and will not let go of what He made.

That is the hope the church traded for an escape, and I have tried in these pages to trade it back, and let me gather up now what it cost us and what it gives, because the whole book has been the argument for a single exchange. We traded resurrection for immortality of the soul, and it cost us the body, made it a shell, made it disposable, made every sin against bodies a minor offense against packaging, and the resurrection gives the body back, a temple destined for glory, honored, raised. We traded new creation for a disembodied heaven, and it cost us the earth, made it a doomed ship, made creation care a foolish polishing of brass, made the dirt beneath us a thing to use up and leave, and the resurrection gives the earth back, a good creation destined for renewal, worth tending, worth loving, worth keeping ready for the King who is coming home to it. We traded God putting the world right for God taking us away, and it cost us justice, made it optional, made the wrongs of this world someone else's problem in a world we were leaving, and the resurrection gives justice back, makes it the family business of a God who is coming to wipe away every tear and settle every account. We traded the honest weep-and-hope for a rush past the grief, and it cost us the truth of our own losses, made us call

the beloved dead a shell and pretend the wound was not a wound, and the resurrection gives grief back its honesty and its floor, permission to weep fully and hope stubbornly at once. That is the trade, four losses for four recoveries, and it is time, past time, to make it.

But I do not want to end with an argument, because arguments are not what finally hold people at gravesides, and this book has never really been about winning an argument. I want to end with the morning, because the morning is the thing, and I have been pointing at it the whole way, and now I want to let you look at it as squarely as Scripture lets us look at it, and then I want to send you out to live in its light.

There is a morning coming that you have not yet seen. It is a morning on this earth, renewed, the same earth you know, healed of everything that mars it, the mountains and the rivers and the fields and the cities, all of it purified in the refiner's fire that burns away the evil and leaves the good standing. And on that morning a trumpet sounds, and across the whole earth the graves begin to open, and the sea gives up its dead, and the ground gives back everyone it took, not as ghosts, not as memories, not as recycled atoms, but as themselves, raised, whole, glorious, in bodies that can never die again. And the New Jerusalem comes down out of heaven, the dwelling of God with man, and God moves in, and He walks among His people on the renewed earth, close, present, embodied, near enough to touch, and He goes from face to face, and with His own hand He wipes away every tear, and death is no more, and mourning is no more, and crying is no more, and pain is no more, because the former things, the fallen things, have passed away, and behold, the voice from the throne says, behold, I am making all things new.

And on that morning you will see the ones you have lost. Not their souls hovering in a distant cloud, but them, raised, in bodies, the faces you kissed and the hands you held, restored, healed, laughing, and you will hold on and never have to let go again, because death, which parted you, has been destroyed, and there are no more goodbyes on the renewed earth, not ever. The bed will not be empty anymore. The phone will not go unanswered. The chair will not be vacant. The reunion the old hymns half-glimpsed and could not quite name will be real and embodied and permanent, the whole family of God gathered on solid ground in the presence of the King, and every loss reversed, and every wound healed, and every tear wiped away by the hand of God.

I do not know when that morning comes. I hold the map loosely and the country tightly, as I said, and I will not pretend to a timeline I do not have. But I know it is coming, because a tomb outside Jerusalem was empty on a specific morning two thousand years ago, and the one who rose is the firstfruits, the first sheaf of a harvest that includes every grave in every field, and the firstfruits guarantee the harvest, and God does not bring in the first sheaf and leave the field to rot. The morning is coming because Easter already happened, because the decisive battle is already won, because there is a man with scarred hands on the throne of the universe who has promised to come back and finish what He started, and He does not break His promises, and the same power that raised Him is going to raise you.

So here is how I want to leave you, because I promised at the start that the ending would not resolve everything but would leave you something to carry, and this is what I want you to carry out the door. You are going to die. I have not softened that anywhere in this book and I will not soften it

now. Everyone you love is going to die, or you are, and death will take all of it, the bodies and the faces and the years, and it will look, for a while, like death has won, the way it looked for a while after they laid a body in a borrowed tomb outside Jerusalem and rolled a stone across the door and went home in the dark, sure it was over. But it was not over. It was Friday, and Sunday was coming, and the stone that looked so final was about to be rolled away by a power the whole world had underestimated. And that is where you live now, on the far side of that Sunday, in the long interval between the empty tomb and the morning it guarantees, and your whole life is meant to be lived in the light of a morning you have not yet seen but that is as certain as the sun.

Live in that light. Grieve your dead, honestly, with your whole body, and then stand up on the resurrection and go on, weeping and hoping at once. Love the world God made, fiercely, because it is not a doomed ship but a seed in the ground. Honor the bodies around you, all of them, because there are no ordinary people and every one of them is bound for glory. Do your ordinary work well, because it is a rehearsal for eternity. Pursue justice as the family business of a God who is coming to put the world right. Give generously and live simply and refuse the endless wanting, because your future is secured by an empty tomb and you have nothing to prove and no one to keep up with. And when your own morning comes, and it will, do not be afraid, because you are not stepping off a cliff into darkness, you are following a man who went into the dark ahead of you and came out the other side and is waiting to catch you, and He will not drop you, and the last thing you feel will not be the cold of the grave but the warmth of a hand wiping the tears from your face.

Heaven is not your reward. It never was. Heaven, the

disembodied waiting room, the shell in the box and the soul in the clouds, was always too small, always a fragment mistaken for the whole, always the church's comfortable trade for a hope it found too large to carry. Your reward is bigger than heaven. Your reward is resurrection, on a renewed earth, in a body that cannot die, in the presence of a God who came down and dwells with His people and wipes away every tear with His own hand. That is the hope the church traded for an escape. And I have spent this whole book, and I will spend the rest of my life, and I will spend my own dying breath, trying to hand it back. The tomb is empty. The morning is coming. Behold, He is making all things new. Now go and live like you believe it, because it is true, and it is bigger than anything you dared to want, and it is coming, and it will not be stopped.